Warrior Woman

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34819162.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Original Female Character(s), Original Male Character(s), Swift Wind | Spirit, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Darla | Mara's Ship (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
adora crash lands on ehteria, catradora, catra is not with the horde, Adorable Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Poor Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver is abusive, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, shera AU

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by Sams_drabbles (UntitledMeek)

Summary

****INCOMPLETE****

Join General Adora in building a new life after crash landing on the mysterious planet, Etheria where she learns the truth about the demise of her home planet and must help her new friends in defeating a common foe lest the same fate that befell Eternia is brought onto Etheria. Along the way she learns new things about herself and learns to love with a fierce woman who compliments her in every way imaginable, but love isn't easy, especially for two soldiers who were taught to never fall in love.

Notes

Based in the 2018 She-ra universe, some aspects may agree with the cannon universe, but its basically its own 'universe' and the story will be different.

Updates on the 30th/31st of the month (hopefully)

I am personally designing the OC's in this series, character profiles will be linked to the posts I make on Tumblr/Twitter for a visual. Some characters from the show will have small design changes, so I will be sketching them too; if there is no link to a character profile, just assume they're identical to the show (I am a lazy person, so not every character will be redesigned 😆).

Story begins in Chapter 2 of the work, Chapter 1 is where I will add character profiles.

Character Profiles

Chapter Summary

Character profiles; for Chapter 1, skip to Chapter 2 of the work

Warrior Woman Character Profiles:

After time skip in Chapter 3 (6 years)

General Adora; She-Ra, Princess of Power

Species: First One/Eternian

Born January 19, 28 years old [22 in chapters 1 &2]; 5'8/173cm

Adora has loved swords since she was a baby often opting to stare at her Aunt Mara's sword rather than play with her toys. As a daughter born into the She-Ra line she was raised with a strong sense of justice, and Adora, more than most, would do anything in her power to bring justice to those who deserve it.

She hates bullies and frilly clothing; she would often refuse to wear frilly dresses when attending formal events resulting in her attending many events in basic dresses.

Adora was born on the planet Eternia but never knew the planet as it was destroyed when she was just a baby. She was inducted into the ranks of Base Grayskull at 8 years old and rose quickly through the ranks, eventually becoming the youngest General at 20 years old.

At 16 the magic of She-Ra was passed to her from her Aunt Mara and she has been training to master her magic ever since.

Catra; Fugitive of the Horde, Defector

Species: Magicat

Born October 28, 28 years old; 5’2/158cm

Catra loves to win, and she doesn’t often lose, her skill in hand-to-hand combat was unmatched in the Horde due to her superhuman strength, speed, and agility. She’s also had a weakness for sweet foods ever since leaving the Horde and eating ‘normal’ food for the first time.

As is typical for the Magicat species, Catra hates water, but even more than her hate for water is the detestation she feels toward her ‘adoptive mother’, AKA her childhood abuser. Not much is known about her species and she is assumed to have no family; she was left at a Horde encampment as a baby then integrated into the Horde as one of the many orphaned children that make up their forces.

Kamila [kah-mee-lah]; Villager

Species: Artimi

Born August 27, 10 years old [4 in chapters 1 &2]; 5’0/152cm

Kamila imprinted on Adora almost as soon as she met her and has been attached to her hip ever since, even now, 6 years after Adora came to Ardglass.

The thought of Adora leaving one day, even only for a short, necessary, amount of time is enough to ruin her day, usually resulting in her hanging off Adora for the rest of the week.

She grew up in Ardglass and never knew her home planet where she would have one day been queen, her mother, Freja, rarely talks of the planet where she grew up, stating that she wants Kamila to have a normal childhood. Where her mother generally wears the traditional clothing of her people, Kamila prefers to wear simple pants and a shirt.

She lives in Ardglass with her mother and uncle, Marcus, but also considers Hathor, her mothers former personal guard, to be family as well.

Queen Glimmer [glih-mer]; Queen of Etheria/Brightmoon

Species: Etherian/Angelic Being

Born December 1, 26 years old; 5'4/163 cm *[Introduced in Chapter 7]*

Glimmer loves her family and cake, the two often going hand in hand with her best friend Bow when they raid the Castles kitchens.

On the contrary she hates the Horde, often losing her temper and rushing into battle without thinking, but she's working on that. Even more than her hate of the Horde is her hate of the Hordes Second in Command, Shadow Weaver, the reason she was now Queen instead of her beloved mother.

She lives in Brightmoon with her people and family, but is rarely seen at the castle for long as she is also the leader of the Rebellion against the Horde, constantly on missions to free the neighboring towns from the Hordes rule.

Bow; Archer/Rebellions Second in Command

Species: Etherian

Born September 9, 29 years old; 5’9/175 cm *[Introduced in Chapter 7]*

Bow loves pirates, he gets overexcited every time he and Glimmer cross the seas to visit Mermista and Sea Hawk. He also loves cats in any form, there are cats flooding every corner of Brightmoon, more calling the castle home After every mission.

He hates long shirts, opting for any sort of crop top available, as well as arguments of any kind.

He lives in Brightmoon with Glimmer, but takes frequent trips to his parents library in the Whispering Woods.

Nisha [nih-sha]; Force Captain

Species: Ashwin

Born December 12, 27 years old; 6'7/201cm *[Introduced in 'A Fallen Warrior']*

After her betrayal, she always held a particular dislike for Catra, even more so than the others, no one knows why, especially Catra. She was 'rescued' from her Kingdom after the Horde attacked and has been with them ever since, hopelessly loyal.

Before time skip (Chapters 1 &2)

Cara [cah-rah]; Mayor’s daughter

Species: Aqualina

Born March 11, 6 years old; 3’9/114cm

Cara likes to go on adventures and will often be found exploring the outskirts of the Whispering Woods. She’ll eat almost anything but will not touch grapes, despises them with a passion only a 6-year-old can manifest. She has many Aunts, Uncles, and Cousins living all over Etheria, but only her parents stayed in Ardglass.

Her mother, Frieshia, owns a wares shop and her father, Connlan is the Mayor of Ardglass and she often stays with him during the days in the Town Center.

Frieshia [free-she-ah]; Shop Owner

Species: Aqualina

Born January 17, 28 years old; 5’1/155cm

Frieshia would do anything for her family and friends, spending much of her time in her shop; the villagers know that if they need a friendly face or a willing ear, her shop is the place to go.

The only thing known to get on her nerves is when travellers come to their village for aid and treat her people like dirt it is then, and only then, that she has ever raised her voice.

Frieshia loves her family, she has dozens of brothers and sisters populated across Etheria and though she may not see them as often as she’d like, they get along famously when they are together. Her daughter, Cara, as dubbed by Frieshia, is ‘the light of her life’, she’d not known true happiness until her daughter came into their family.

Connlan [cone-lan]; Mayor of Ardglass

Species: Aqualina

Born October 4, 32 years old; 5’5/165cm

Connlan has always liked order, even as a child. He would constantly be cleaning and reordering his room until he was satisfied then go on to the rest of the house.

As a child he loved surprises, until a surprise party went wrong, and now, as Mayor, surprises never bode well for him.

When he met Frieshia, he fell instantly in love, the fact that she was a complete slob didn’t matter, her selflessness and unconditional love was enough for him, they were married a year later, their daughter Cara arriving not long after that and she has had him wrapped around her pinky ever since.

Tecla [tech-lah]; Farrier, Stable Owner

Species: Xiomara

Born November 7, 18 years old; 6’1/185cm

Tecla has loved horses all her life, as soon as she was able to walk she would be out in the stables with her mother cleaning and exercising the animals.

As is the natural instinct of the Xiomara species Tecla is wary of hunters, and with her wariness paired with her brash attitude she has been known to run hunters out of town when she finds them wandering too close to her stables.

Taking over after her mothers passing Tecla is now the towns farrier and oversees the stables.

After their mothers passing the triplets, Tecla, Mina, and Sorina are the only ones left of their immediate family, this naturally making them extremely close.

Thane [thay-ne]; Villager

Species: Xiomara

Born July 28, 7 years old; 4’5/135cm

Thane loves to hang in the stables and help Tecla clean and exercise the animals. Animals, horses specifically, have fascinated him for years.

He sleeps with a nightlight due to a paralyzing fear of the darkness, no one really knows why he’s afraid, but he cannot be in complete darkness without experiencing a panic attack.

Thane lives in Ardglass with his parents, Elke and Lyla, and brother, Sayyida.

Sayyida [say-ida]; Villager

Species: Xiomara

Born December 19, 9 years old; 4’11/150 cm

Sayyida loves to dance and often dances around the village in search of a partner in his fun.

He will eat nearly anything, but not apples, even as a baby he would refuse to eat applesauce, instead he takes his share of the fruit to the stables to give a treat to the animals.

He and his younger brother, Thane, live in Ardglass with their parents, Elke, and Lyla.

Elke [elle-key]; Fighter/Soldier

Species: Xiomara

Born April 17, 34 years old; 6’7/201cm

Elke has always loved learning. When he was younger he would often stay late in the villages school to catch up on extracurricular work and tutor others.

He is always the first to step in when a stunt is taken too far, or when someone is in immediate danger, dubbed as the protector of the village by all, he always responds “I just hate danger.”

At 13 he met his mate Lyla whose family had sought asylum in Ardglass. At 18 they were formally mated (married) and had their first son, Sayyida, their youngest Thane 2 years later.

Lyla [lie-lah]; Seamstress

Species: Xiomara

Born April 23, 34 years old;6’1/185 cm

Lyla’s love for cooking is second only to her love for her boys (Sayyida, Thane, and Elke), she is usually in charge of planning

and cooking holiday meals for the town.

She has an extreme dislike for rough play, especially when it involves her sons.

Lyla's family sought asylum from the Horde in Ardglass when she was 12 and they decided to stay when the danger had passed. She was wary of Elke at first, she would catch him staring at her, but when he finally gained the courage to speak to her, her wariness quickly fled when she realized that he was just a big 'teddy bear.' At 18 they were formally mated (married) and had their first son, Sayyida, their youngest Thane 2 years later.

Freja [fray-ah]; Seamstress/Dancer

Species: Artimi

Born February 28, 25 years old; 6'3/191cm

Freja loves her daughter and they are never apart for long, as is typical for their species.

She despises fighting and encourages all to choose any option but violence to resolve a conflict.

Freja was next in line for the throne on her home planet when Horde Prime invaded and destroyed her home. She, her brother, Marcus, unborn daughter, Kamila, and royal guard, Hathor, were rushed off the planet and sent to Etheria to seek asylum from the alien invasion. After coming across Ardglass in their travels Freja chose to live as a 'regular citizen' in the village where she gave birth to and now raises the love of her life, Kamila.

Hathor [hay-thor]; Farmer/Artimi Royal Guard (formerly)

Species: Artimi

Born November 1, 41 years old;6’1/185cm

Hathor loves sincerity, and with his specialized military and magical training he can tell with near certainty if a person is lying to him.

Even through drastic means, Hathor has never been able to rid himself of his paralyzing fear of heights, this single weakness nearly cost him his career as an Artimi Royal Guard, his saving grace was the young heiress Freja who was adamant that she would accept no personal guard save for Hathor; he has been hopelessly loyal to the heiress ever since that moment.

He escaped his home planet with Freja, Marcus, and the then unborn Kamila when Horde Prime attacked. Rather than rebuilding their monarchy Freja insisted on seeking asylum in Ardglass and living as ‘regular townsfolk’, of course she had never wanted to rule, only Hathor knew this fact, and he would take that knowledge to his grave. One of the first townspeople Hathor met was the young librarian, Sojan who helped him greatly in adapting to civilian life. He and Sojan married a few years later and now have twins, Odilon and Anne.

Sojan [soh-han]; Librarian

Species: Ziad

Born October 21, 36 years old; 6’5/196cm

Like many of the Ziad species, Sojan loves to be warm and in turn loves the summer months.

On the contrary, he hates the winter and being cold.

Abandoned outside the towns gates as a baby, Sojan has no known family and was raised by the people of Ardglass as one of their own. When Freja, Marcus, and Hathor arrived in the town he took it upon himself to help the group as the townspeople once did for him. While Freja and Marcus adapted easily to civilian life, Hathor struggled and they ended up spending countless hours together, talking about everything and nothing. After falling for the man, Sojan finally confessed, then had to explain what love was. Not long after that they were married and now have the twins, Odilon and Anne.

Odilon [oh-dey-lon]; Villager

Species: Mixed, Artimi/Ziad

Born July 6, 9 months old; 30”/76cm

Odilon loves apples and pears and despises waking up. He will sleep all day if at all possible. He was born in Ardglass and lives with his twin sister, Anne, and parents, Sojan and Hathor.

Anne [an-nee]; Villager

Species: Mixed, Artimi/Ziad

Born July 6, 9 months old; 25”/64cm

Anne loves squash and is terrified of thunderstorms. She was born in Ardglass and lives with her twin brother, Odilon, and parents, Sojan and Hathor.

Mina [mee-nah]; Scavenger/Shopkeeper

Species: Xiomara

Born November 7; 18 years old; 6’3/188cm

Mina loves scavenging and travelling the Whispering Woods, but she hates math, so she spends little time in her store that was passed to her and Sorina after their mothers passing. She lives in Ardglass with her sister, Tecla, and brother, Sorina (the triplets).

Sorina [sore-in-nah]; Scavenger/Shopkeeper

Species: Xiomara

Born November 7, 18 years old; 6’0/183cm

Sorina loves things to be organized, a trait that was much needed in their home as Tecla and Mina are “absolute slobs” as Sorina states.

He is a solitary creature, hates crowds with a passion which goes hand in hand with his love for scavenging and exploring the Whispering Woods. He lives in Ardglass with his sisters, Tecla, and Mina (the triplets).

Marcus; Messenger

Species: Artimi

Born May 12, 27 years old; 6’3/191cm

Marcus loves large gatherings, family, and humour, he loves to joke around and put smiles on everyone’s faces. He says his love for laughter comes from the lack of it in his childhood. As the crowned prince he was to never speak or show any emotion unless explicitly instructed to do so.

He hates being bored and will always be doing something if he can help it, that being the main reason he was recommended to be the messenger for the village keeping him busy for days on end with the travel between the villages.

He escaped his home planet after it was attacked and destroyed by Horde Prime with his sister, Freja, her unborn daughter, Kamila, and a Royal Guard, Hathor.

Crash Landing

Chapter Summary

After being attacked by strange white spires, General Adora of Base Grayskull crash lands on a strange planet known as Etheria, due to the lack of technology on the planet, she would never be able to return to the base. While fixing her ship she meets a strange local, then she travels to a nearby village once repairs are complete. What will she do when she realizes that the people of the planet have problems of their own?

"Darla, take us into that asteroid field, it will allow us to hide from their scanners."

"Yes, She-ra. Autopilot system starting."

Moving from the piloting controls, Adora began the process of cloaking their location from all galactical scanning systems. "Initiating stealth mode, Darla, turn off all accessory systems." Adora sat back down in her pilot's chair switching on manual flight.

"Yes, She-ra."

Watching as the spires receded from her location she eased her way out of the asteroid field and checked her systems, the numerous silenced alarms and flashing warning lights did not bode well for her. "Darla, can I get a status update on all major operational systems?"

"Yes, She-ra. Weapons system; offline. Thrust and stabilization systems; offline. Autopilot and flight systems; offline. Communication system; 60% capacity. Ship status; currently circling the outer gravitational pull of an unknown planet. Chance of return to Base Grayskull; 12% rate of success. Suggested course of action; shut down all accessory systems to allow the Darling Star *to be pulled in by the gravitational force of the unknown planet. Tests suggest the atmosphere is habitable to Eternians."*

Flipping open her communication line she hailed the base Communications Officer. "Grayskull, this is General Adora, call sign: She-ra; Princess of Power. I am calling in distress, the *Darling Star* has taken multiple critical hits, chances of safe return calculated at 12% success."

"*General, this is Grayskull. We have received your distress signal. Give me a complete status update."*

The garbled voice of the Command Centre Communications Officer came through Darla's system after a few tense minutes. "Grayskull, this is the Commander of the *Darling Star,* General Adora, call sign: She-ra; Princess of Power. Status update: critical. Hull integrity 26%, shields are down, weapons offline. Crash landing has been calculated at 87%; I am in the gravitational field of an unknown planet; atmosphere is hospitable to Eternians."

"*Understood General, your landing site has been authorized and your profile will be purged from the database. Peace be with you."*

As the line went silent, she heard Darla's voice ring out *"Communications with Base Grayskull have been severed. You have one incoming message 'Final Orders' from an unknown source, would you like me to accept?"*

"Patch it through for me, Darla."

"Adora, this is Force Commander Mara, call sign: Hope. I am so sorry; I have failed to protect you. You are on a collision course with a planet called Etheria. This planet does not possess any significant technological development so you will likely never return to Base Grayskull. I am truly sorry. I love you, my dearest niece; peace be with you."

Frowning, she let the silence wash over her. . . This mission had been just as any other; she had received her orders: she was to leave on a stealth mission, no contact was to be made with anyone. She had been on her 13th and final day and heading back to the base when a foreign force had closed in on her, the strange white spires a curious sight in the open universe.

~~ Earlier ~~

"Surrender immediately and we will not engage. We do not wish for violence, but should you refuse us we will have no choice but to attack."

"I will not surrender to you; you do not own empty space. Leave me be and I will not engage."

"One last chance, surrender and provide the name and location of your leader."

"No."

~~ Present time ~~

At her steadfast refusal to cooperate they had attacked.

Narrowly escaping she had evaded their tracking systems by entering an asteroid field, but in doing that she had sustained too much damage, returning to the base without a rescue team was nearly impossible, and so she had sent out a distress signal eliciting her current situation; floating aimlessly in open space in the outer edge of the gravitational pull of the planet Etheria.

"Hey, Darla. You can shut down all systems for a while, conserve some power for repairs. What is the estimated time frame for our collision with Etheria?"

"Collision with Etheria estimated to be 7 days. System shutdown initiated; goodbye, She-ra."

Standing up Adora headed to the back of the ship opening the door to the stables and turning on the light. “Hey, Swifty how are you doing back here, any permanent damage?”

“Oh my gods, you are a *terrible* pilot, Adora. What did you do?”

“Just some technical difficulties, we ran into some unknown adversaries. I am afraid this is not the end of the rough ride. We are going to be crash landing in about a week. Sorry buddy”

“Whoo! A new planet! I can’t wait to meet some new people! The officers at the Command Centre were so *dull*.”

“Ha-ha, I am glad you are pleased Swifty. You can wander around now, there should not be too much more excitement until we hit the troposphere of the planet.”

~~ Roughly 7 days later ~~

Adora woke to a violent shaking of her ship, *it is time to land, we have hit the troposphere.* The shaking ended abruptly as they hit the inner atmosphere and began a free fall to the ground. Jogging to the pilots chair she turned on the manual flight system and steadied the ship then weaving through a forest to land roughly in a small field. “Darla, are you there.”

“Yes, She-ra.”

“I need status updates on all major operational systems.” As the systems began to turn on she observed the number of warning lights and alarms that came alive, one by one.

“Weapons system; offline. Thrust and stabilization systems; offline. Autopilot and flight systems; offline. Communication system; 20% capacity.”

“Understood, pull up the weapons system manual for me, please. Its time to fix the ship up a bit”

~~ Roughly 2 weeks later ~~

Adora wiped her hands off on her jumpsuit as she carefully extracted herself from the weapons repair lock and climbed into the ship heading for the kitchen. Opening the storage cooler she took inventory. o*nly about a month’s supply of food left, just enough time to finish repairs and explore the area. Hopefully there is a town nearby.*

“Darla, can you pull up a map of Etheria, please.” When the map popped up in front of her, she zoomed in on her location taking notice of a number of sparsely populated areas all within a few hours walk from her location. “Great. Thank you. Have you been able to analyze the language used to communicate on this planet yet?”

"Yes, they are speaking Etherian; it is very similar to what you are speaking now, but the syntax is quite different. Currently you will be able to interact, but there will be a slight communication barrier as some phrases will have differing meanings."

"Understood. Right. Back to work, then."

~~ Roughly 1 week later ~~

"Hello there, dear."

"Wah!" Jumping at the sudden voice behind her, Adora wacked her head on the edge of the flight systems control panel. "Ouch," rubbing the back of her head she pulled out of the repair hatch to look down at the peculiar woman with wild white hair and thick glasses. "Oh, hello."

"My, my, I'm sorry for scaring you, dearie. What brings you to the Whispering Woods?" The woman flitted her hands around her face, broom moving wildly as she talked.

"Oh, no, no. It is alright Miss; I should have been paying more attention. I landed here about a month ago and am stuck for the time being. How about you Miss, what brings you to this part of the woods? From what I have seen there is nothing near this area." Jumping down she stood in front of the woman calling upon She-ra's vision to assess the threat level. While she did not seem

threatening, she had been able to sneak up on Adora, a feat unattainable to many.

This was an odd woman indeed, though she carried only a broom, the amount of magical energy she possessed was impressive and rivaled that of herself. *Interesting, I wonder if all Etherian's possess this level of magical energy?*

"Ah, I'm here to pick berries, dearie. Would you care to join Madam Razz? I'll be baking pie later."

Before she could respond Madame Razz wandered away. *She's an odd one, but I don't really want to leave her to wander alone.* Turning to the ships entrance she called out to Swift Wind, "Hey, Swifty. I am going to wander for a bit, I should be back by tonight." Hearing a grunt, she took it as an acknowledgement of her departure.

Jogging to catch up to Razz she fell in step with her. "Oh, hello dearie. Glad you decided to join me."

"Hello, Madame Razz. It is my pleasure, so. . . where are these berries you speak of?"

"They are right over there, dear."

Looking to where she pointed Adora saw a large. . . ruin? *Interesting, I wonder what used to be here*.

As they walked closer she noticed some writing on the stone; writing she recognized, Eternian script. It was too degraded to make sense of, but the dialect was an ancient one, one she had not seen since she had scoured the libraries of Eternia as a child. *Interesting, I wonder why there was no information on Etheria in the system? There must have been a colony on this planet at some point in history.*

Putting that thought aside, she began to remove small, spongy balls from the overgrown bushes, 'berries', as Madame Razz had referred to them. "May I ask you a question, Madame Razz?"

"Of course, dearie, what would you like to know?"

"Are the people of this planet aware of the immense magical energy all around them; its flowing through this planet quite powerfully. I am surprised at the level of magical energy that is contained in such a small area. If I were to assume, from only meeting you, the people of this planet must all have a strong connection with the magic I can sense."

"Ah, no; many are aware of its existence, to an extent, but most don't have the means to utilize the magic of Etheria. There a few who are able to use magic at will here and are known as 'Princesses', elemental princesses have runestones which contain an enormous amount of magical energy and help them concentrate and use the magic of the planet allowing them to

possess magical powers. Non-elemental princesses are basically the same, but they don't possess runestones to help them concentrate the magic and are therefore not as powerful, depending on what you need. We also have a few sorcerers, but they are not nearly as prevalent as the princesses with only a small number of villages still dedicated to the teachings of sorcery."

"Ah, very interesting. Thank you."

"Right, that's enough berries! Time for pie!"

Turning she followed Razz to a small wooden shack deep in the woods, the magical energy surrounding them was so much stronger than where Adora had been for the past month. It seems as though the deeper she ventures into these 'Whispering Woods' the stronger the magical force flowing through the vegetation and wildlife became. And just as the wildlife around her, the magic flowing through Razz fluctuated as she wandered around her hut fetching ingredients for her 'pie'.

"Madame Razz, can you tell me what this 'pie' is that you speak of? Is it a type of nourishment?"

"Yes dearie, pie is a dessert, you eat it. It's very good!"

"Very well, I will try this pie."

Muttering as she went Razz used her magic to move her belongings around. "Sugar, sugar. . . sugar. Ah! Sugar!" Adora smiled at her excitement. Placing the pie in the oven Razz turned to face Adora, "well, dearie. The pie will be ready soon. Now, tell me, what is the Warrior Princess She-ra doing back on Etheria?"

"I'm. . . sorry? How do you know that? And what do you mean 'back' on Etheria?" Surprised, she looked at Razz, *how could she have found that out, I've barely said anything to her.*

"Oh, Dearie. I can feel her magic within you, I have felt it before when my Mara used to come and visit me."

"Wait. . . you knew my aunt?"

"If my Mara is your aunt, then yes. She came here, oh, many, many years ago now. I only saw She-ra once, but her magic is very distinctive and I can feel it within you, dearie."

"Oh-um, right, ok. I was attacked on a stealth mission and lost all function of my ship, as you could probably tell by the state of the *Star*. I ended up getting caught up in the outer gravitational pull of Etheria and sent a distress signal. With the lack of technological advancement on this planet, it would be essentially impossible for me to return to my base, and so I am no longer a part of their database. I am now an inhabitant of Etheria." She decided to leave the subject of Mara's past visit to Etheria, simply because Razz did not seem to be a person who could carry on a lengthy

conversation on any single subject. She switched subjects even faster than Swift Wind, a monumental feat in and of itself.

"Oh, you poor dearie. And what might your name be?"

"Oh, where are my manners, I am Adora."

"Adora. Nice to meet you, Adora dear."

"And you, Madame Razz."

"Well, enough of that dreary subject. Let's eat some pie!" Chuckling to herself at the exact line Swift Wind often used to change a subject she accepted a slice of pie and an odd, pronged utensil.

Taking a bite, she stopped, eyes widening. The taste was so *strong*. She had never in her life tasted anything so sweet; having lived on military rations since she was a child, this wasn't surprising. Coughing she searched frantically for a liquid which appeared before her in the hands of a giggling Razz.

"Oh my, dearie. Such a confident bite for a soldier, even my Mara dear took small bites. Here, take a drink; its milk, a mild tasting drink here, it will nullify the taste of the berries." Razz watched her as she took sips of the 'milk', despite its murky look, it was quite good. The dull taste a welcome one for her palate.

“Thank you. I have not eaten yet today; I did not realize this ‘pie’ you prepared would have such a strong taste to it. I think I shall be alright to try another bite now; I know now how strong it is.” Grasping the pronged utensil once again she took a much smaller bite, chewed, and swallowed; while strong, the taste was now bearable.

“Good, good, dear. I’m glad you like it!”

Heading back to the *Darling Star* Adora felt somewhat better, she was not as alone as she thought; though she had just met Razz, she felt as though she had known her for many years. Climbing back into the weapons control panel she got back to work.

~~ Roughly 3 weeks later ~~

“Swifty, I am going to go travel to the nearest village for some information, would you like to join me?”

“Yes! People! I’m in.” Jumping onto his back they headed North East to a small village about an hours walk from the *Darling Star*. “Hey, Adora. . . Do you think the people here know of you, or should I say, of *She-ra*?”

“Mara mentioned that this planet was not technologically advanced, I doubt there are more than old tales of the Eternian’s

and their legendary Warrior She-ra, protector of Grayskull. I think it would be best to hold my being She-ra close to us for now for simplicity. I do not know how the Etherian's will react to my magical powers, or yours for that matter. I have yet to come across a steed of your breadth in my travels, please be careful." *Razz knows who I am, but since she is likely the only one with intimate knowledge of She-ra, it is probably safe to assume no one else knows any pertinent details about my being She-ra.*

"Got it, no magical transformations in front of the locals."

Emerging from the edge of the forest she noticed a skirmish on the outer edges of the town. Curious, she dismounted signalling for Swift Wind to stay by the forests edge then she got as close as possible to the disturbance to gauge the risk level by watching body language and listening in on their verbal exchange.

"What do you want? We haven't done anything to the Horde."

"Silence. Hand over the fugitive and we'll leave you be, if you don't, we'll have to take them by force."

"There is no fugitive here, we haven't seen anyone in days."

"You have 30 seconds before we attack."

"But we don't have any fugitives, you have to believe us!"

Maneuvering closer she assessed the situation; she would not interfere if she was not needed. Evaluating the townsfolk, it was obvious they were not equipped to fight these soldiers. And so, as the soldiers advanced on the townsfolk she stepped out to insert herself between them. "Hello, what seems to be the problem here? As you can see, none of these folks are armed and a fight would be pointless and impractical."

"Our orders are to return with the fugitive. If not given willingly, we are to attack."

"Well, as they have been conveying so insistently; there is no fugitive here. You must be mistaken."

"Attack!"

Crouching low Adora took account of the number of soldiers coming toward her. There were 7 soldiers, young, unsteady on their feet; likely a new squadron. Most seasoned warriors would be hesitant to commence an attack with an unfamiliar opponent, she was a wild card, the townsfolk were obviously not trained to fight, but she was. Seemingly not picking up on this detail the soldiers initiated their attack with no apparent plan or harmonisation amongst themselves. *These soldiers are terribly trained, what kind of Commanding Officer would send untrained individuals to retrieve a fugitive?*

Glancing behind to see if there would be any aid she watched as all the townsfolk had either begun to cower or run, so no support will be provided on that front. Just as well, she could take these soldiers, even without the assistance of She-ra's full power.

Calling upon She-ra's sight a slight glow emitted from her irises and her vision sharpened allowing her to pick up every movement around her; *ah, there you are, an archer, these soldiers are not as foolish as I assumed*. *I should still try and inquire on their allegiance and specific orders; this is a very odd planet.* Signing to Swift Wind she pointed the archer out to, instructing him to take them down as she engaged the squad.

Ducking the first blow she called upon her sword, morphing it into a staff and swiping at the feet of the soldier nearest her. Lifting herself she took down the second and third with a hard blow to their temples by slamming their heads together, a fourth she tripped then compressed their windpipe until they passed out. The last three faltered as she stood to face them, "I will allow you to leave, if you so choose, so long as you do not trouble these villagers again and you answer 2 questions for me. As for your archer, who you are obviously waiting for, they have been incapacitated."

She watched as the soldiers processed the information then the leader, she assumed, nodded to her, "what are your questions, Warrior?"

"Who is your Commanding Officer, and what are your orders, the *exact* wording?"

“Our Commanding Officer is Shadow Weaver, Second in Command of the Horde Armies. Our exact orders are ‘Collect the fugitive known as Catra and bring her to me’ as instructed by Shadow Weaver herself.”

Nodding to the soldier she processed the information, *what business would the Second in Command of an army have with a fugitive, very interesting*. “Very well. You may go if you so choose.”

They ran to gather their downed members and fled into the Whispering Woods. Turning to the village entrance once she was sure they were gone she searched for a villager to speak with. “Hello? Is everyone alright? The soldiers have vacated, you are safe now.”

Now in the center of the village she stopped and waited. A few minutes later a small child emerged from behind a barrel. “Hello, stranger. Thank you for saving us.” The girl was green skinned with webbed ears, fingers, and extremely curly dark hair.

“Hello, young one. What is your name?”

“I’m called Cara.”

“It is an honour to meet you lady Cara, where might your parents be at this time?”

Pointing to the barrel she emerged from Adora saw two larger heads peeking out, both green skinned with curly dark hair. Standing close together they emerged, they were wary of her. Holding her hands out, she allowed her staff to dissolve and removed her dagger from the sheath placing it in the dirt.

"I mean you no harm. I am new to this planet and wish only to ask some questions. My name is Adora and my steed is called Swift Wind." She gestured over to Swift Wind who had begun to wander toward them.

"O-oh, Hello, Miss Adora. I'm Frieshia, this is Connlan. We're happy to answer your questions, please come with us."

Ardglass

Chapter Summary

Adora meets the people of Ardglass and is unusually popular.

Nothing much exciting happening here, I'm just setting up the plot and introducing necessary characters; I'm thinking of getting into more exciting travels in the next few chapters

~~ Recap ~~

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~~ Present time ~~

Now sitting in the living room with Cara and her parents, Adora had been meeting the other villagers for the past 20 minutes. "Hi Miss, thank you so much! I'm Tecla! Your horse, Swift Wind is welcome to stay with me while you're here, the village stables are beside my home!"

"Oh, thank you so much for the offer Tecla, but Swift Wind will not need to be stabled, he will not venture far from myself."

"Oh, alright. Just give me a shout if he changes his mind about the stables!"

Adora watched as the dark furred woman bounced away ears flicking as she went. Turning to the next villagers in line, a family, the mother and children a soft fawn colour, the father more of a caramel colour walked up to her. The children had tiny antlers

coming in, likely to grow to match their fathers impressive set. She smiled as they approached, “greetings, what are your names little ones?”

“I’m Sayyida, and this is my little brother, Thane!” the larger of the two proclaimed as he stepped forward, puffing out his chest slightly.

“Ah! Such wonderful names for two strong young men. Your parents must be proud.” Ruffling Sayyida’s hair she glanced up at their parents.

“That we are boys. Go on home now, we’ll be there in a moment.” Sayyida clasped his brothers hand and they skipped out at their mothers request. “I cant thank you enough for what you did Miss. I’m eternally grateful. My name is Lyla, and my mate, Elke. I am one of the town seamstresses, if you need any repairs, please allow me to help, it’s the least I can do for you.”

“Its an honour to meet you both. I will be sure to come to you first Lyla, thank you for the offer.”

Lyla kissed her mate on the cheek, waving as she walked off to corral her children, Elke approached her and held out his hand, standing to shake it Adora smiled at him. “Adora, I have another favor to ask, if you are willing?”

“Of course, please.”

“Would you be willing to teach some volunteers to fight? We have a few adults, and some grown young who, watching you fight to protect us, were inspired to learn self-defence to keep our village safe. We would be eternally grateful to you and would allow us to protect our families from harm; the Horde has been known to raid villages in order to recruit children into their forces. Its sickening really.”

“It is a sickening thought; I would be honored to teach you, when would you like to begin our training? It may take some time, and plenty of patience to learn the art of the fight; everyone is different.”

“We were thinking maybe tomorrow? We’d be happy to put you up for the night. There are a few empty homes you can use while we train.”

“I shall take you up on this offer, thank you Elke.”

Turning back to the last family after shaking his hand once again she smiled at the shy little girl hiding behind her mother. “Hi Miss. I’m Freja, and this is my daughter, Kamila.”

“It is a pleasure to meet you, Freja, Kamila.” Holding her hand out to the small pink skinned girl with pin straight purple hair, she softened her expression.

Seemingly satisfied that Adora was not a threat, the girl emerged from behind her mother and placed her hand in Adora's. Curiosity lit in her eyes as she moved her hand to check the size difference. "Woah! I hope my hands get this big when I grow up! What are these rough spots?"

"Those are calluses, I have quite a few as I have been a soldier for the majority of my life. Your hands will likely not callus this much little Kamila."

"Aww. But your hands are *so cool*."

"Fear not, Kamila, you will grow to be *much* cooler than I." Smiling at her mother, she picked up Kamila's hand, fingering her claws, "you see these beautiful claws, Kamila? You will become a fierce warrior in your own right with these claws and sharp mind."

"Cool! I love how you talk, I wanna talk to you again, is that ok?"

"I would love that, Kamila." Waving at the two as they left Adora felt a twinge in her heart. *I really am going to miss my family.*

Suddenly a weight in her lap startled her out of her train of thought. Looking down she saw 2 unruly heads of dark brown and purple hair, both in a fit of giggles.

“Well, hello little ones. What brings me the honour of your company?” wrapping her arms around the squirming girls to prevent them from falling she gave them a quick tickle.

“Hahaha, we just wanted to hang out with you! We thought you might be home sick, you looked sad.” Cara turned in her lap to wrap her arms around Adora’s neck, squeezing tightly.

“Yeah! You looked like me when I stayed with Aunty Free and Uncle Conny when my mommy had to go to Erelandia. I was all sads, I cried forever, Carrie hugged me a lot and made me feel better with hugs.” Kamila smiled as she too turned to wrap her pudgy arms around Adora’s neck, giving her a squeeze.

Eyes tearing slightly, Adora blinked rapidly, “thank you, it means a lot. You girls are very perceptive.” Her voice was strained.

“Can I call you Addy? Adora is too long!” Kamila’s face appeared before hers as she stood on Adora’s thigh.

Anchoring her, Adora placed her hand on her back, for balance. “Of course Kamila, you may call me what you like.” She smiled at the girl, calming down, pushing thoughts of her lost family aside.

“Great! Call me Kam! That’s what everyone calls me.”

“Yeah! People call me Carrie, I want you to as well!” Cara jumped up as well.

“Girls, girls! Don’t hurt the poor girl! You’re going to bruise Lady Adora’s thighs!” Frieshia rushed into the room and picked Cara out of her lap. Lifting Kam Adora moved her to sit in her lap more comfortably. “I really don’t mind Lady Frieshia, I have many young cousins just as excitable. And please, call me Adora, I do not carry a title.”

“Ah, good. I know they can be a handful.” She emphasized her point by letting out an exaggerated grunt as she sat Cara on her lap. “And please, Frieshia is fine, we aren’t formal here.” Standing up she placed Cara on the floor, putting her hands on her hips. “Now, you mentioned having questions earlier?”

“I do, but it is getting late and I should walk Kam home. I don’t want her walking alone, is it alright if we speak in the morning?” Adora stood, placing Kam on the floor, holding her hand.

“Of course, Adora; its past Carries bedtime as it is, though I don’t see her complaining about it. Freja actually offered to take you in for the night if you would like? We can set up a house tomorrow; I heard what you’re doing for Elke and some others, thank you!”

“Its no trouble. Everyone who is willing to learn deserves to have a teacher. I also think it would be wise to have some protection for the town.”

“Me as well! Have a good night you two.”

“Thank you, you as well.” Walking out the door she looked down at Kam, “lead the way Kam.”

“This way!” Marching in the direction of her home, Kamila led her to a large hut. Opening the door, Adora allowed Kam to walk in first, locking the door behind them. “Hey! Mommy, I’m back from Carrie’s! And I brought Addy!” Kam kicked her flats off and headed into the home.

Removing her boots and weapons, organizing them neatly Adora fixed Kam’s shoes in the process. Appearing in the doorway as she finished Freja smiled softly, “you’re too kind Adora, Kammy has yet to pick up the cleanliness ive tried to instill in her. She is ever a little ball of chaos.” Laughing, Freja beckoned Adora into her home. “Please, come on in.”

Adora smiled and stood, “thank you, Freja."

“Now, we do have a spare bedroom, but Kam is insisting that you stay in her room, she told me, and I quote, ‘Addy needs me, I don’t want her to be lonely’, she can be quite hard headed about things.” Freja winced slightly passing an apologetic look to Adora. “Is that alright? I can try to talk her out of it if you’re uncomfortable, please don’t feel obligated.”

At the sight of her panic, Adora smiled, “I don’t mind at all Freja, your daughter is wonderful.” A relieved look washed over Freja’s features.

“Oh, that’s wonderful. She’s become quite attached to you, I should probably warn you though, our species, Artimi, get extremely attached very quickly to certain people; we imprint, quite easily. If you ever feel uncomfortable, please let me know, Kammy seems to be imprinting on you; you aren’t in any danger though, you’ll just have an attachment in the form of a child. Heh, she hasn’t really done this before, with anyone but me.” Freja stopped and put a hand on her shoulder, “thank you for all you’ve done. I’m happy she’s found you.”

“I am pleased as well, she is a wonderful girl.” Freja opened the door to a *very* purple room. “Wow, I like your room Kammy. Where shall I be sleeping, then?”

“You can sleep with me, Addy! My bed is huge; it’s a canopy bed too!” Kam jumped up, Waving her hands excitedly at her bed.

“It’s a king bed, you can also sleep on the floor, or a cot if you’d like.” Freja glanced at her sheepishly.

“The bed is fine Kammy. We can have a sleepover, my cousins and I had these all of the time growing up.” Adora grinned, sitting on the bed.

“Yes! I love sleepovers!” Kam shouted jumping into Adora’s lap.

“You girls have fun; please get ready to sleep Kam! We don’t want to be sleepy tomorrow right? You want all your energy to show Adora around the town, right?” Freja questioned kissing Kam on the forehead.

“OK mom, night!” Kam jumped from Adora’s lap, running to her bathroom with pajamas.

“You can change in the bathroom across the hall if you’d like? Do you have anything to change into? I have some clothing that should fit you.”

“I am alright, I wear my underclothes when sleeping, thank you for the offer.”

“Alright. I’ll see you two in the morning. Have a good night.”

“And you as well, Freja.” Following her out the door, Adora closed the bathroom door and stripped until she was in her undershirt and shorts heading back to Kam’s room she found the girl curled under her sheets. “Hello, Kam.”

“Addy, come on in!” Kam lifted the sheets and shifted over to make room for Adora.

“Thank you, Kam. Goodnight.”

“Night, night!”

***

“Um, Addy, I gotta question for you.” Adora felt Kam roll over and place a small hand on her back.

Rolling over to face her, Adora scrunched her face when light exploded from a flashlight under the covers, “what is it Kam? Did you lose something in the sheets?” She felt a clawed had grasp her cheek lightly before Kamila’s lyrical voice answered.

“Why are your eyes so sad? You’re happy on the outside, but your insides are sad.” A light glow began to emit from Kam’s eyes as Adora felt the magical energy around them shifting toward the girl. Curious, Adora allowed her eyes to emit the light of She-ra to help Kam control her magic.

“I didn’t know you were able to use the magic of the planet Kam, are you reading my emotions?” Guiding the magical energy Kam had been unconsciously channeling, Adora watched as the glow emitting from Kamila’s eye brighten until they were nearly white; matching her own glow as She-ra.

“Yep! Mommy says we can feel the emotions of other people, mostly at night though. I don’t remember the name of it, but my eyes get all glowy. I can’t do it when I want to though, it doesn’t work yet.” Grinning, Adora allowed She-ra's magic to disperse along with Kamila’s.

“I think you mean empath. Your magical power will mature with you, so long as you work hard and practice, you will master your powers in time.” Brushing Kam’s bangs out of her eyes, Adora switched off the flashlight as Kam fought off the sleep in her eyes, “let’s sleep now, Kammy, we can talk again in the morning.” Adora placed the flashlight on the bedside table and pulled the covers up to Kam’s chin.

~~ Morning ~~

“*-ora. . . Adora?* Adora?” Opening an eye, Adora saw a pair of legs standing in front of her, “I’m sorry, it’s so early but I have to leave for work. Are you ok to keep Kam with you today? She’s usually in class, but with the Horde attacking yesterday they’ve cancelled.”

“Not a problem, Freja. I will take her with me today, I am just teaching some villagers self defense.” Adora went to sit up, but noticed Kamila latched to her arm and thought better of it, settling on just angling her head up at Freja.

“Thank you! She’ll sleep all day, so just wake her up when you’re ready. She can show you where all the food is; Kam can make her own breakfast, so no need to worry about cooking. I’ll see you two later today.”

“Alright, enjoy your day.” waving as Freja shut the bedroom door she settled back onto the pillow. Glancing at the clock she saw it was almost 6am; plenty of time for a quick nap before getting up for the day.

~~ 8:30 am ~~

Waking with a start, Adora tried to figure out where she was; she definitely wasn’t on her ship, there was too much colour. Blinking, she looked around then noticed the purple hairball peeking over the covers and the small body wrapped around her arm; Kamila.

Extricating herself from Kam, Adora stretched out her muscles and put on her pants and long-sleeved shirt, forgoing her weapons, for now.

Heading back to the bed, Kamila had replaced her arm with the pillow Adora had been using. “Kam, it is time to wake up.” She shook the girls shoulder gently. In response she received a sleepy sigh as Kam burrowed further into the pillow. “Ah, sweet Kamila, you remind me so much of my young cousins, they do not enjoy waking either. Regretfully though, we must be going soon to see the other villagers, would you like to watch me teach?” Adora watched Kamila’s ears flick as she listened, but she was not yet convinced that waking was worth it, “perhaps I can teach you as well? Maybe assist you in controlling your empathic abilities?” Kamila’s ears flicked again and she smiled; *there she is, I have gotten her now*.

Kamila leaped up, squealing with delight. “Yes! I want Addy to teach me magic!” Kam rushed to her dresser, throwing on a white, puffy summer dress.

Heading to the kitchen, Adora watched as Kamila danced around grabbing bowls, spoons, a box and placing them on the table. Curious, Adora read the label on the box when Kamila ran to the fridge; *Cheerios?* Odd, she had never seen such a food before.

Returning with a carton, Kamila laughed at Adora’s confusion. “It’s cereal! Just try it, you’ll like it!”

Not one to disappoint a child, Adora pulled a bowl towards her and opened the box and bag to dump some of the oddly shaped cereal into the bowl. With the bowl now half full, Adora reached for the carton, “ah, milk; I know if this liquid.” Pouring the milk on her cereal, Adora smiled at Kamila, encouraging her to prepare her own breakfast before taking her bite.

Satisfied that Kamila would be fed, Adora took a bite. Unlike Madame Razz’s pie, the cereal strongly resembled the protein bars she had grown up with, it was, thankfully, bland in flavour, the milk adding a slight sweetness to the meal. *This is quite good, I think I shall be alright with the food served here;* as her food stores had nearly run out on the ship, she had hoped that the food on this planet would be similar to her tastes.

“I told you! You like it, right?” Kamila bounced in her seat as she munched her cereal.

“I do, Kam. It is very similar to a popular protein bar back home. Thank you.”

“I knew you would like plain Cheerios!”

***

“So, which way was your Aunt Frieshia's again?” Adora looked down at Kamila as they walked out of her home, not quite prepared for the hand that grabbed her and ran to the Mayor’s home.

Slowing to a stop in front of a soft yellow home, Kam knocked on the wooden door, “Aunty, Uncle! I brought Addy!”

“Hello girls, come on in.” Frieshia appeared in the doorway as it opened, beckoning them into the house, “hurry, hurry Kam, it cool outside this morning!”

Walking to the living room, Adora sat on a loveseat as the others got themselves settled for a chat; Kam decided Adora’s lap was irresistible, planting herself on Adora’s knee. Cara settled for the spot beside Adora, Frieshia on the chair opposite the loveseat. “Conn had to go into town this morning, but I should be able to answer your questions.”

“Well, I have asked most of my questions, but I am curious as to the purpose of yesterday’s scuffle, who is the Horde, and who are Shadow Weaver and Catra?”

“Well, let me give you the rundown; it’s a long story. As you know, this planet is called Etheria. Etheria was extremely peaceful before Hordak landed her, oh, has to be almost 20 years ago now, and created an army; the Horde. The Horde took over the Scorpion King’s Kingdom and adopted their runestone; the Black Garnet, the Scorpion King decided to join the Horde armies, and thus began the civil war we have been fighting for nearly as long as Hordak has lived on this planet. If I had to guess his intentions, I would say Hordak just wants to take over the planet; he wants to control the people of Etheria. They’ve just recently taken over a neighboring town Veritas, that’s what Conn was called in to discuss. We aren’t sure how much longer we can stay independent, the princesses no longer leave their Kingdoms to protect us and, as you saw, we have no soldiers either.” Cara moved to hug her mother.

“I am staying for now, I will help where I can for as long as possible. Elke as well as some others have volunteered to learn some basic tactics in defense, which will allow them to protect Ardglass and your independence from the Horde.” Adora ran her fingers through Kam’s hair to reassure the girl, and herself.

“Yes, I heard, we are extremely grateful for your help.”

“It is my pleasure. I was raised to respect any who wish to protect their own, and to teach anyone who so chooses to learn to defend themselves.” Adora smiled at Cara and Frieshia.

“And we are grateful for that, and your generosity. Your staying to protect us is much appreciated. As for Shadow Weaver, she is Hordak’s Second in Command, she adopted Catra as a child, but the girl left as soon as she was able and has been roaming the planet since. Shadow Weaver has been sending out search parties and Horde soldiers to every town that has housed her since, calling her a fugitive of the Horde. We took her in for a few days last week which is probably the reason the soldiers came yesterday.”

“Why did this Catra run from the Horde if they were all she knew?”

“No one knows really, she doesn’t talk with anyone farther than ‘can I stay the night?’, but she also doesn’t align herself with the Rebellion, so I think she just wanted to escape.”

“Rebellion?”

“Ah, the Rebellion are the few princesses who do come out to try and protect the villages, though, with the death of the King, many left the Rebellion, and no one stopped them. The Rebellions forces are nothing compared to the Horde, but those that are left refuse to give up, which is a good thing, I guess.”

“It is. These soldiers refuse to give up on their homes, it’s admirable. Thank you for explaining the situation. I should be heading to the Villages center; I have promised to meet Elke

there. Be seeing you, Frieshia, Cara.” Adora stood with Kam placing her on the ground.

“Oh, oh, oh, I wanna go with Kammy and Addy too! Please mommy!” Bouncing in her mothers lap, Cara began to pull her ears.

“Of course dearest, but make sure Adora is alright with it as well.”

Before Adora could react, a pair of arms wrapped around her neck as Cara’s small form slammed into her torso. Stepping back slightly, she was careful not to step on Kam who had latched onto her leg. “Addy! Can I? Can I please?”

“Oof. . . of course Carrie, I would love your company.” Waving to Frieshia, Adora stepped out onto the front path with one child on her leg, and the other wrapped around her neck. Adjusting Cara so that she was situated on her hip, Adora headed to the Village center.

“Wow, I haven’t seen that many children attached to a person since my boys were younger.” Adora turned as she heard Elke laughing at her situation. “Those girls have really taken to you, huh?”

“They have, though I am quite fond of them as well. They have definitely grown on me.” Adora patted Kam on the head as she approached the group of villagers Elke had been speaking with.

“Good, good. I brought my boys as well, they can entertain each other. . . maybe even learn a thing or two; I’m sure they would pick it up quickly, Kammy here is very quick on her feet, Cara as well.” Elke came to ruffle their hair as they giggled. “Let me introduce you to the others; everyone, this is Adora, she has kindly agreed to train us in self-defence.” A cheer rang out as the villagers turned to her. “Adora, this is Hathor, he tends to the livestock with his partner Stojan, over here.” The 2 men came to greet her, Hathor was a large male with dark skin and white hair, Stojan on the other hand was much slimmer with mocha coloured fur and sharp ruby eyes.

“Its good to meet you Adora, our twins Odilon and Anne would *love* your eyes, they’ve got a thing for blue eyes.” Stojan came over to give her a light hug over the girls, smiling at them. “You two are going to have to share her with the others you know?”

“Not yet!”

“Yeah, she’s mine!”

Laughing at Sojan’s reaction to the outburst from the girls, Adora looked to the next 3 people in the circle. “Next we have the triplets; Sorina, Mina, and Tecla. Tecla, you know is in charge of the stables. Sorina and Mina help out, but they are also the storekeepers that gather all our food and distribute it throughout the village.” The three of them came up to shake her hand, they all looked remarkably similar, but Tecla stood out with her ever-present chaps, whereas the other two wore more sedate clothing. “Next is Freja’s younger brother Marcus, he travels between

villages to carry on messages, but since the Horde has taken over many of the villages in the area, we need to give him something else to do, right Marc?" Elke ruffled the young mans hair laughing.

Facing her with a charming smile, Marcus held out his hand, "nice to meet you Adora, I'm Marcus."

"And you, Marcus."

"Adora!" She heard Sayyida and Thane cheer as they came around the corner with their mother running to her. Kneeling down to catch the boys, she adjusted Cara so that she wouldn't be hit. "Sayyida, Thane, good to see you boys. How was your night?"

"Good! We got to stay up late to play board games!"

"Wow, that sounds amazing! Are you boys here to watch us?"

"Yeah!"

"Well, how about you four go stand over there while we get started then? Maybe later I can show you some techniques, sound good" Making eye contact with each of the kids, she got a nod from all but Kam as they walked away. "Kam? Are you going to see Cara and the boys."

“No, I wanna stay with you.” Kam moved her arms from Adora’s waist to her neck to prove her point.

“Alright, I need you to hold tight though, I’m going to need my hands.” At Kamila’s nod, Adora stood to face the crowd. “Alright everyone, lets get started.”

~~ A couple hours later ~~

“We’re going to do some one-on-one sparring then break for lunch. I want Sojan and Mina, Tecla and Sorina, and Hathor and Elke paired up; Marcus, you can be my partner.” Adora spread the pairs out then stood across from Marcus.

“Are you sure you don’t want to put Kammy down first, Freja will kill me if a knock her accidentally. Shes terrifying, you know.” Marcus shuffled nervously as he thought about the wrath his sister would no doubt bring down on him if she found out he was sparring with Adora while Kam was there.

“No worries, Marcus; I will take the blame if she gets angry, besides, you won’t get a single strike close to your niece. I can guarantee that.” Smirking, Adora widened her stance and beckoned the sputtering man over. “Come now, have you never been insulted before?” Laughing Adora studied his form as he approached; *his feet are too close* together. Dropping low, she kicked out her leg and swept his feet from beneath him. “watch your stance, be sure to keep a wider stance to ensure balance, don’t put all your weight on a single foot. Use your wings as well, they are a great tactical advantage.” Rising again, she helped him

to his feet then scanned the others. “Tecla, Mina amazing form, keep your center of balance low, good. Hathor! Use you muscles, Elke may be taller, but you have more mass, use it to your advantage.”

Marcus had gotten up and was testing a wider stance, “the wider stance I get, but wouldn’t using my wings be unfair to you? Not only do you not have wings, your holding a child.”

“I may not have wings, but I have years of experience, which are more effective than any advantage you may get by the added weight of your niece on me. As a said before, you will not land a single strike.” Readjusting Kam she settled into a slight crouch.

“Oh, I like you; we don’t have many confident fighters here.”

Watching his stance she noticed the improvement, “yes, that’s right. Your center of gravity is different than mine, you do not want to copy my stance.” Blocking his kick Adora dropped again to take out his remaining foot, but instead of falling he righted himself using his wings. “Yes, there you go; use every advantage available to you.” Ducking his punches she rose slightly and hooked a foot behind his knee and pulled then swung her arm out to push down on his chest crumpling him to the ground. “you forgot, do not copy my stance, Marcus; my center of gravity is completely different than yours. You started copying me after using your wings”

Laughing Marcus made an angel in the sand as everyone finished up their sparring. “You were right Adora, I didn’t land a single hit!”

Laughing she held her hand out to him, “come on, lets get you up. I’m sure Freja would be unhappy if you were hurt.”

“Nah, she’d laugh. Heh, at least now she didn’t have to hurt me herself.” Grabbing her hand he pulled himself up, “anyway, I’ll let her know Kam is staying with you, I’m going to bring her her lunch now. See you.”

“I will be seeing you.” Turning to the others she said more goodbyes.

“We'll be brining by Odilon and Anne after lunch, my sister has to go to work.” Hathor put his arm around Sojan as he came up to her. “Sojan told you about Odilon’s thing for blue eyes, you may just have 2 kids hanging off you later. I don’t think I could be so graceful with a child hanging off of me.”

“Haha, it’s a skill, you’ll learn.” Walking over to Sayyida, Thane, and Cara, “hey guys, what do you say we get some lunch?”

“Yes! Mom said she left a bunch of food in the fridge!” Sayyida jumped up excitedly grabbing her hand to pull her to their house. “Let’s go!”

“Careful now, Kam has fallen asleep.” Making sure to grab Cara and make sure Thane was following she allowed Sayyida to pull

her to his house.

~~ After lunch, back at the village center ~~

“Alright kids, who wants to learn a fighting stance while we wait for everyone?”

“Yes!” At the cheer Adora shook Kamila’s shoulder, “Kam, wake up.”

“Hmm? Addy?” Bleary eyes met her own as Kam lifted her head from Adora’s shoulder.

“Good morning sleepy. You want to learn a fighting stance?” Brushing Kamila’s bangs from her eyes Adora watched as life returned to the girls’ eyes.

“Yeah!”

Letting her down Adora joined the circle the kids had made, “ok, now I want you guys to place your feet shoulder width apart; like this.” Widening her stance she bent her knees slightly, “now bend your knees a little, like this. Good! Now bring your hands up like this; protect your core.” Adora brought her hands up to demonstrate. “Yes, there you go, Sayyida bring your elbows in a bit. Cara, your fists are too high, you need to be able to see. Thane, widen you stance a bit, you are taller than the others, your

stance will need to be wider. Kam, good form, can you spread your wings for me? It'll make your more intimidating and people with think twice before messing with you." Ruffling her hair she looked up to see the adults beginning to trickle back.

"Hey everyone, look who've come to join us!"

"Ah, this must be Odilon and Anne." Turning to Hathor and Sojan she felt 4 small bodies cling to her legs. "May I?"

"Of course." Handing her his son Hathor laughed at the children clinging to her, "you seem to be very popular with the kids here; I have never seen them all cling to one person; not at the same time anyways."

"Haha, its pretty normal for me, there were a lot of children in my family." Placing Odilon on her hip she smiled down at him, "hey little one, are we a little tired today?"

Tired green eyes blinked slowly at her for a minute, then he brought up his hands to grip her face "Ah!" Putting a hand over one of her eyes he bounced on her hip, "ah!"

Laughing Hathor clapped her shoulder, "he likes you! Be careful of his claws though, he might poke your eye, he loved my eyes as a babe, now all he needs is to see blue eyes and he's mesmerized."

“Well he’s got some lovley green eyes of his own. And who is this beautiful young lady, Sojan?” She turned her attention to the small child napping on Sojan’s shoulder while Odilon discovered her hair, running his fingers through the strands.

“This is our daughter Anne, Odilon’s twin sister. She doesn’t take to new people nearly as quickly but she’ll come around; especially once she sees your eyes; like Odilon, she loves her fathers blue eyes.”

Sounds of laughter and fighting caught everyone’s attention as Tecla, Mina, and Sorina came around the corner playfighting. “Come on Sorina, I thought you said you were the big, strong man in the family, you can get out of a simple headlock, no?”

Struggling against Tecla’s hold, Sorina smiled, “yeah, yeah, Tec, but I didn’t mean over you; everyone knows you’ve got the muscles big sis.” Pouting at Tecla, Sorina gave her his best pathetic look. “Let me go? Please big sis?”

“No! Don’t let him go, then he’ll come bug me!” Minas voice came from behind the two, but she was nowhere to be seen, until Tecla turned slightly and Minas form was revealed hanging off the back of her sister lazily.

“It seems I’m not the only one with children hanging off of me today.”

“I guess not, Adora. But at least your children aren’t *whining* like babies!”

Adora and Tecla snickered as a chorus of ‘heys' arose from her siblings. “Alright everyone, lets get back to it, I’ll take the kids over here, I want you all to spar for a while, but pick uneven groups rather than pairs; you won’t always have even numbers.”

Handing Anne off to Sayyida Sojan joined a group as they began to spar; Adora watched as she resumed her teachings with the older children. “Great kids, Kam, come over here let me show you some exercises I used when learning to use my own magic.”

Catra

Chapter Summary

Everybody say hi to Catra, and some catradora tension 😏 😏

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~~ 6 years later ~~

"Be safe you three! Make sure they make it back Swifty." Freja waved to Adora, Kamila, and Swift Wind as they headed out of Ardglass for some training. It had been 6 years since Adora had landed on Etheria and the situation with the Horde had gotten significantly worse which was the reason for their trip into the Whispering Woods to continue Kam's magic training, no more could be done in the village and so they were now headed to stay in Adora's ship for a week.

"Yes ma'am, I swear I will bring them back in one piece-uh. . . two pieces? Never mind." Laughing awkwardly he turned bidding farewell to the villagers.

"Bye mom, we should be back in a week so don't worry. I'll stay with Adora the whole time, promise." Holding a hand over her heart Kam put the other on Adora shoulder.

“Bye everyone, my ships only a few hours away from here, we'll return if we need to.” Wrapping an arm around Kam’s shoulder Adora turned to leave giving the girl a squeeze, “ready to go Kam?”

“Yes! This is so exciting! I’ve never left Ardglass before, it’s too dangerous now.” Kam reached out to stroke Swift Winds wing beside her as she tried to stamp out the fear rising in her, though she could still see her mother Waving them off, she had never been this far from her mother before and she was already home sick. “Is this how you felt when you landed on Etheria? My heart hurts, I miss everyone already. . .” Turning to eye Adora, Kam noticed a sad expression cross her features.

“Yes, I wish I could tell you it passes, but the hole in my heart still persists and I don’t think it’ll be easily healed. As for the homesickness; ive never really felt homesick as I grew up a soldier and was often away from home, but that’s normal as well, it should pass with time.” Giving Kam’s shoulder a squeeze she smiled softly then looked over to Swift Wind, “but, if you’re lucky, you’ll find someone like Swifty here who’ll do everything in their power to show you that even though you may be sad, and you may be hurting, you still deserve to feel happiness and love. And if you’re *really* lucky you’ll find someone like yourself; a person, though young, sees you right down to your soul and begin to mend a wound you didn’t know existed.” She smiled when Kam lifted her hand to hold Adora’s on her shoulder. “Do you remember what you said to me that first night, after you and Carrie jumped into my lap?”

“Heh, yeah. . . We were worried you were sad and homesick so I asked Cara to come with me to cheer you up. I told you that you looked like I had felt when my mom visited Erelandia and I stayed

with Cara. She'd made me feel better by hugging me, then we hugged you for a long time. . . until Auntie busted us for using you as a jungle gym."

"Yes, and that night, your hugs made me feel so much better." Falling into a comfortable silence, they continued their trip.

***

"Um, Addy, are you sure you and Swifty are the only ones that were on your ship?" Slowing her pace, Kam studied the ship that looked a little. . . lived in. . .

Rummaging through her pack, Adora hadn't yet looked at her ship, it should still be cloaked, but at the odd note in Kam's voice she looked at the girl. "Yes, I came here last week to make sure everything worked correctly. . . why do you ask?"

"You might want to look at your ship. . . I thought you said it would be cloaked and I wouldn't be able to see it until you uncloaked it?"

"Yes. . ." Looking to where her ship was parked, she hoped she saw nothing and Kam was messing with her, she was disappointed to see her ship sitting in the clearing, uncloaked, the door open. Turning back to Kam she lifted her onto Swift Winds back walking to look him the eye. "Stay here." Dropping her pack she extended her staff and unclipped her daggers sheath jogging over to the

ship. “Hello? Who’s there? Please slowly walk down the ramp, I don’t want to hurt anyone, please just exit my ship.”

Now standing at the end of the ramp Adora looked into the darkness of the doorway scanning for movement, with nothing to note she called upon She-ra to access her heightened vision and the darkness cleared and all movement around her came into focus. To her right there was a family rabbits wandering about and to her left she could see Swift Wind, a matching glow emitting from his eyes as he chatted with Kam. In front of her she locked onto a small movement in the ships entrance, it was a small flicking movement and kind of looked like a. . . cats tail? “I’m coming up the ramp, I see your tail.” Stopping halfway she watched the tail disappear and the lithe form of a small cat-like woman round the corner out of the shadows in the entrance.

Eyes opening, heterochromatic turquoise and golden glowing eyes met her own as a mischievous smirk curled on her lips, “your ship, huh? This is an odd place to park a cloaked ship y'know Princess, people generally don’t want to walk right into an invisible hunk of metal you know.” The women began to make her way down the ramp walking in a manner that was nothing short of pure seduction, hips swaying invitingly and tail swishing almost in an impatient manner and her left ear flicked in the most adorable way when the wind blew a tuft of hair across it. Speaking of hair, the sun hit the woman’s *mane* in the most alluring way setting of the hickory colour by shining in golden highlights. Her locks were held back by a red metallic headpiece that framed her alluring face, a sea of freckles covering a button nose an a cute mouth; though the mischievous smirk and sharp look in her eyes were meant to intimidate, Adora found them undeniably attractive.

~~ Catra ~~

She was on the verge of complete relaxation during her afternoon nap when she heard it; people talking. Listening in she noticed the peoples tone were light, so not soldiers.

"Hey, Addy look what I can do!"

"Wow Kam, you finally figured it out! Now you've got to get the back flip and you'll be able to show up Marcus."

The first voice was definitely a child's, but the second was feminine and husky and rolled through her sending a tingling sensation down her spine and her ears perked up.

"Come on kid, show me your back flip. I'm sure you can do it, no sweat."

"Fine, fine Swifty I'll try. . . oof."

"Awww. . . that was a great try kid. Don't tell your mom I suggested it; blame your uncle, it's funny to watch him get beat up."

"Swifty. . . honestly I can't contradict that, it s hilarious."

"Um, Addy, are you sure you and Swifty are the only ones that were on your ship?"

Damn, she's gonna have to talk her way out of this.

"Yes, I came here last week to make sure everything worked correctly. . . why do you ask?"

"You might want to look at your ship. . . I thought you said it would be cloaked and I wouldn't see it until you uncloaked it?"

"Yes. . . Stay here."

"Shit. . ." muttering to herself she sat up and looked for a cubby to squeeze herself into to hide.

"Hello? Who's there? Please slowly walk down the ramp, I don't want to hurt anyone, please just exit my ship."

Peaking around the edge she saw the figure of a tall woman standing at the base of the platform.

"I'm coming up the ramp, I see your tail."

“Damn,” guess it was a day for confrontation, taking a deep breath she turned around putting a smirk on her face strutting out to the top of the platform narrowing her eyes at the woman. “your ship, huh?” Finally focusing on the woman behind the alluring voice she’d heard; first thing to catch her attention were the arctic blue eyes that glowed nearly white. They were striking and Catra nearly choked on her tongue; they were absolutely stunning. “This is an odd place to park a cloaked ship y'know Princess, people generally don’t want to walk right into an invisible hunk of metal you know.” Finally ripping her eyes from the woman’s ethereal stare to her golden locks pulled into a tight ponytail and the cutest hair poof, moving down she saw a light layer of freckles above a pretty pout. She was tall too with long legs, layered with muscle. . . now that she looked, the woman’s entire frame was layered with muscle; she was *exquisite.*

“Hey, are you just gonna stare each other down or. . .?” Blinking, Catra realized she’d been staring. Turning to glare at the man who’d spoken to her her eyes widened when all she saw was a *very* large, very confused looking horse with a child gripping his mane tightly, a worried expression on her face.

“Did. . . did the horse just *insult me?*” Scrunching her face Catra let out a noise of disgust.

The mysterious woman answered without a very feminine giggle which drew the attention of everyone causing a pretty blush to explode over her cheekbones when she noticed their stares.

~~ Adora ~~

The cat-like woman raked her eyes down Adora's body, likely searching for hidden weapons, the ever-present smirk adorning her lips. She brought a hand up to rest lazily on her hip, giving an almost bored look about her, but Adora could sense the tension in her muscle; she was ready to move at a moments notice, that fact kept Adora on edge.

"Hey, are you just gonna stare each other down or. . .?" Blinking as if she'd forgotten there were others the woman glanced over to Swift Wind and Kamila; she could kill that horse, he just brought this woman's attention to himself and Kamila.

Not taking her eyes off the woman she watched as surprise turned to curiosity, then realization, her mouth opening slightly the woman's tone dripped with disbelief and exasperation, "Did. . . did the horse just *insult me?*" Scrunching her face she let out a noise of disgust.

The look of disbelief paired with the woman scrunching her nose and letting a out grunt was too much and Adora laughed, well not so much laughed as *giggled*. The slight noise made by Swift Wind and Kam turning to give her wide-eyed stares shifted her attention to them, their looks combined with the realization that she just *giggled* caused her face to heat.

Whipping her head back to the woman, she hoped she wasn't getting the same stare from her. Much to Adora's disappointment, it was evident in the woman's wide eyes and shock that she too had heard the giggle and Adora's cheeks heated even more.

Calming herself, Adora let She-ra's magic fade, “why are you on my ship?”

The woman scoffed, “well, when I walked straight into a hunk of halfway cloaked metal I decided I deserved a nap at the expense of the owner.” Not paying particular attention to the story, Adora let the woman’s husky, low tone wash over her, she never heard such a mix of feminine and rough; it was beautiful. . . “y'know you’re supposed to cloak the ship *and* keep it from being walked into, s'just common courtesy.” Letting her eyes wander again, Adora noticed the woman’s outfit, it suited her perfectly. A mixture of feminine and practical, a tight body suit, lightly armoured and accented with silver plates and covered by a dark cloak, a simple headpiece and braids held her mane in check. . . “why are you looking at me like that? I didn’t take anything.” Forcing her gaze back to the odd golden and turquoise eyes she cleared her throat that had gone dry.

“I know. There’s nothing on the ship to take, I haven’t been here in years. Apologies about the cloaking, the system must’ve shorted and landed the ship, are you injured?”

“Haha, you’re so serious. Nothings broken, princess. Where are you from anyway; your accent is not from any Etherian dialect?” Looking utterly bored the woman lifted a clawed hand to gesture at Adora.

“A planet that no longer exists.” Even though the woman looked to be harmless, she had dozens of weapons hidden in the folds of her suit and her cloak appeared to be lined with weapons as well, but she had yet to make any threatening move towards her or Kam so Adora retracted her staff and re-latched it to her belt then

re-clipped her daggers sheath and un-crouched to stand at her full height. “I’m Adora, this is Swift Wind and Kamila of Ardglass.” Waiting for a response, Adora kept an eye on their surroundings; she’d learned early on that it was considered rude on Etheria to demand a person provide their name and instead wait for the person to introduce themselves, and so she waited.

~~ Catra ~~

A pretty blush covered the woman’s cheeks and her eyes were wide, the ethereal irises nearly white in colour as they continued to glow then almost as if they’d sprung a leak, the light faded and all that was left was the prettiest shade of pure blue. Clearing her throat the woman spoke, “why are you on my ship?”

Filing the eye colour change for a later time she scoffed as she remembered walking through the forest the night before watching for Horde soldiers when she’d smacked face first into a cloaked ship, “well, when I walked straight into a hunk of halfway cloaked metal I decided I deserved a nap at the expense of the owner.” Catra watched as the woman’s eyes dropped to give her a once over, the woman leaning forward slightly as if she were listening intently to her voice, “y'know you’re supposed to cloak the ship *and* keep it from being walked into, s'just common courtesy.” When no response came she got rather annoyed. She wasn’t entirely sure why, but this particular person ignoring her irked her to no end; odd, “why are you looking at me like that? I didn’t take anything.” Going immediately back on the defensive, Catra decided it was time for some confrontation; the woman’s silence was really bugging her.

Smirking, the woman lifted her eyes to capture Catra's once again, the look saying she knew exactly why Catra had gotten defensive. "I know. There's nothing on the ship to take, I haven't been here in years. Apologies about the cloaking, the system must've shorted and landed the ship, are you injured?"

Fighting the blush that threatened to rise at the woman's ability to read her so easily Catra forced a bored expression on her face and waved her hand dismissively. "Haha, you're so serious. Nothings broken, princess. Where are you from anyway; your accent is not from any Etherian dialect?" Her ears perked, determined to hear the woman's answer, it was unconscious, *of course*, she didn't *actually* care.

"A planet that no longer exists." The ambiguous answer confused Catra greatly, why would this woman, who appeared for all intents and purposes to be a former galactic soldier turned babysitter, be hiding the planet from which she originated? Thinking back to her eyes, she wondered if the two were related, she had a feeling they were.

After yet another once over, the woman suddenly lifted her staff, Catra tensing in response, then retracted it hooking it onto her belt, then clipping a leather sheath that appeared to house a very intricately designed dagger then dropped her hands to hang loose at her sides. Straightening the woman rose to her full height a friendly smile appearing on her lips, "I'm Adora, this is Swift Wind and Kamila of Ardglass." The silence rang out as Catra debated introducing herself; they didn't look like they were from the Horde, firstly, the Horde didn't ask questions first, they just attacked. Second, the child didn't seem to have any combative training as she had seemed to have gotten bored during their exchange and was now playing with a swarm of magical spores

making delighted noises. Thirdly, she'd never seen a Horde soldier with a horse, let alone protect 2 other beings, being in the Horde meant you fended for yourself, with a group of other people who also fended for themselves.

Making up her mind she sent Melog a telepathic message to stand down, for the moment, but to stay ready. "Catra."

"Good to meet you, Lady Catra, can you please call off your friend over there, I am liable to attack if they get much closer to the horse and child."

Surprised she'd noticed Catra spoke with Melog again; '*you've been made bud, come on out, don't make a move for the horse or child.*'"He only got here a few minutes ago, and he wasn't going to hurt them."

"I'm aware, but I do not take chances."

"Understandable." When Melog trotted up to her she held her hand out to give him a pat; *'thank you.'*"This is Melog, he can understand you, but only I can understand him."

"Noted. Are we going to continue this stand off, or can we go inside and have something to eat? We've been walking for a few hours; Kam is probably hungry." Waving Swift Wind over she slowly took a step forward. When Catra did nothing, she

continued up the ramp and passed the woman heading to the control room of the ship.

Flipping on all the power switches as she went, “hey, Darla. How are we doing for power?”

‘Hello, She-ra. Power level is stable, there was a short in the cloaking system, problem is being fixed now.’

“Thank you, Darla.” Pulling off her pack she took out some food and placed them in a circle.

“So, She-ra? A nickname?” Catra walked into the control room, Melog and Swift Wind not far behind.

“Sort of. A story for another time.” Standing up Adora helped Kam off the horse. “Alright everyone, time to eat.” Sitting beside Kam, Adora opened up her sandwich and took a bite.

“Hey, Addy, where did the lady go? She looked hungry.”

Looking around Adora noticed that both Catra and Melog were gone, “I’m not too sure Kam. Stay here and keep Swift Wind out of trouble will you?”

“Yes ma’am.” Saluting her with her sandwich Kam giggled.

“Hey! Don’t you mean *I* should be keeping *her* out of trouble?”

“No way Swifty! You get into way more trouble than me!”

Leaving them to their bickering Adora left the control room, poking her head through the various doors branching out of the hallway. “Catra? Melog?” A faint meow pulled her attention to the entrance of her ship. Jogging over she caught the silhouettes of Catra and Melog as they passed through the brush of the Whispering Woods. “Hey, wait up! Catra!”

“Huh? Did I leave something?” Stopping, the woman turned slightly sporting a confused look.

“Uh, no. . . I thought that you might stay for some food?”

“Why would we do that?”

“Well because you smacked into my ship that wasn’t correctly cloaked, and someone who sleeps in a powered down ship generally has nowhere else to go. At least that’s been my experience with it. I also happen to know who you are; when I first came here I was told the watered-down version of your life’s story and there is always more to the story than what others

know.” Sighing she held up her hands, “I know I am overstepping, but will you have dinner with us? Please?”

“Um. . . ok, uh thanks.” Still sporting the confused look Catra began to walk back to her ship, Adora falling into step with her.

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“Hey Kam, why don’t you get ready for bed? Its getting pretty late, we can do some training tomorrow.” Turning to the girl Adora sent her a pointed look; she’d already stayed up a lot later than her mother generally allowed.

“Fine, fine. Only cause we get to train tomorrow though! Whoo! C’mon Swifty, let’s have a sleepover!” Jumping up Kam tried to push Swift Wind towards the door.

“Alright, alright, no need to push.”

“She’s got a lot of energy, that one.” Catra muttered as the two of them left the room.

“She does. But she’s a really good kid, strong.” Looking back at the woman, she noticed a myriad of emotions passing through her, anger, sadness, hurt, but most of all, envy. From what little Adora knew, this woman had not had an easy life, ever. “So, I have a proposition, if you’re willing to listen.”

Raising an eyebrow her expression flattened once again as she brought her focus back to Adora, “go on.”

“Id like for you to stay with us for the week, maybe help me train Kam, she could use someone else nitpicking her form. After this, you can stay on the ship if you’d like, I can give you clearance, Darla can control all of the ships systems, anything you need.”

“Why-why would you do this. . . for me?”

“Well, everyone deserves a place to live; everyone deserves a safe place.”

“Um, sure. That. . . sounds good.” She said looking utterly confused

“Well, I have an extra cot, you can stay with me, there’s not too many rooms here, sorry. Do you think Melog will want to stay with you or. . .” Standing Adora held her hand out to Catra.

“He’ll just wander until he gets tired.” Taking Adora’s hand Catra pulled herself up; she really didn’t weigh much. “Thanks.”

Now that Adora noticed, Catra was extremely tiny, she had such a large presence that Adora hadn’t really noticed. She also noticed

how soft Catra's hands were, the fur was extremely fine, and her hand was incredibly warm. Shaking her head she let go of Catra's hand, "alright let's get you set up then."

Won't You Stay (With Me)?

Chapter Summary

Some light Catradora!!!!!!
TW - light desc of abuse by SW//Horde Cadets

"Why-why would you do this. . . for me?"

"Well, everyone deserves a place to live; everyone deserves a safe place."

"Um, sure. That. . . sounds good." She said looking utterly confused

"Well, I have an extra cot, you can stay with me, there's not too many rooms here, sorry. Do you think Melog will want to stay with you or. . ." Standing Adora held her hand out to Catra.

"He'll just wander until he gets tired." Taking Adora's hand Catra pulled herself up; she really didn't weigh much. "Thanks."

Now that Adora noticed, Catra was extremely tiny, she had such a large presence that Adora hadn't really noticed. She also noticed how soft Catra's hands were, the fur was extremely fine, and her hand was incredibly warm. Shaking her head she let go of Catra's hand, "alright let's get you set up then."

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Following Adora down a curved hall, presumably to the back of the ship where the captain's barracks was usually located, Catra slowed slightly taking in the design of the ship. Unusually shaped lamps lit up as they made their way through the ship - they almost looked right out of a mural she'd seen in her travels - then turning off behind them, but they weren't the only light source, there was odd script emitting a light glow along the walls, Catra had never seen such a language before, it was peculiar – the characters were angular, but beautifully structured, the words strung into sentences using lines, as if written in cursive. The more she saw and learned about the odd woman, the more questions she had.

'Why was Adora on Etheria? Why didn't she just leave, she was obviously not from the planet?'

'Why was she with an Artimi child; generally this species never strayed far from their families?'

'Why was she being so understanding; so nice?'

Adora was surely an enigma, and Catra was intrigued. Further than her curiosity, Catra couldn't explain why she was so *attached* to Adora. Why did the thought of Adora leaving *hurt*? "Hey, Catra? Are you alright? You seem to be troubled by something?" snapping back to reality, Catra whipped her head back to Adora, her eyes gravitating toward Adora's ethereal blue ones – you could almost say they glowed.

“Nothing. What language is this? I don’t recall ever seeing this script before.” Avoiding the uncomfortable question Catra turned back to the glowing scripture tapping a nail on a particularly intricate character that seemed to appear frequently, Catra watched the luminesce flow toward her nail, as if it were aware of its presence on the character. She furrowed her brows before turning back to look at Adora with a questioning stare.

“Ah, that’s Ancient Eternian Scripture – the people I was born to. The character you are referring to is my name.” *Well, not her name per say, it was She-Ra’s title, her name only appeared when her family wrote to her, but that’s not something she was going to tell Catra.* While she liked the woman - she had a fire in her that Adora admired - her past ties to this ‘Horde Army’ and the fact that she was a complete stranger made Adora weary of telling her too much about her and her people. “Its understandable that you don’t recognize the script, while I have seen numerous ruins with Eternian scripture on Etheria, they use a very old dialect that does not tie in well with the modern structuring.” Adora smiled, it had been a while since anyone had been curious about her people; it was refreshing. She gestured to the door they had come to stand in front of, “here is my room, we will have to share while Kam and I are here, but its all yours once we leave.” Allowing Catra to walk into her barrack, Adora flipped on the light and watched her explore the space. Catra’s nose twitched in the most endearing manner, as if she had smelt something, then Adora watched as the woman *sniffed*, to her credit it was discrete, but the act tore a laugh from Adora.

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There it was again, the pang in her heart at the mention of Adora’s departure. Pushing the hurt from her mind she entered

the room – it was a good size, maybe half as wide as the control room, and a third of the length. Sniffing lightly she breathed in Adora's scent; a pleasant mix of lavender and earth, it was comforting and Catra could feel her muscles relaxing in response. She could feel her eyelids getting heavy until she was startled by another utterly feminine giggle from Adora, mirroring her earlier outburst causing Catra's muscles to tighten with cautious surprise, "huh?"

"Sorry, sorry. Its just –" another giggle escaped her when Catra's nose scrunched again, this time in confusion, "its – haha, when you sniffed, your nose scrunched and it was just *adorable*." Wiping a stray tear Adora looked over at Catra who, by all accounts, looked appalled.

Catra could feel the hair on her nape prickle as her tail poofed at the comment, "I am *not* adorable!"

Trying to hold in her laughter, Adora distracted herself, "ok, ok. So. . . what were you trying to sniff?" Pushing off the wall where she'd been leaning, Adora approached the woman who suddenly seemed. . . *nervous*.

"I-I was. . . uhm. . ." walking backwards as Adora approached, Catra bumped into the wall behind her, the cool surface helping to focus her mind, "Your room. . . smells like. . . you." A blush exploded over her cheekbones, shooting up from her neck as she flattened her body completely onto the wall hoping she could somehow sink further into the cold, unforgiving surface and disappear from this moment – even in her 20's Catra had never been in such a situation before, rather she had never even bothered with another person in her life. But she couldn't, for

some godforsaken reason, stay away from this woman. Just looking at her made Catra's knees liquid but being close as she was now Catra could smell her soft scent – it filled her nose, intoxicating her.

Adora's eyes widened and her step faltered at Catra's answer. . . *that* was not what she expected to hear. Deciding that was a thought for another time, she smirked, "smells like me, huh?" bringing her hand up she rested her palm just above Catra's shoulder and leaned in closer still, careful not to overwhelm the woman who seem to be standing only by sheer force of will, "do I smell good then, Catra?"

Her face getting hotter the closer Adora got, she missed the question as her eyes focused on the movement of Adora's lips, focused on the feeling of Adora's breath sweeping over her face, focused on the sensual tone of her voice, "w-what?" unconsciously, at least she hoped it was unconscious, her chin raised, bringing her lips mere inches away from Adora's. She had to place her palms flat on the wall for fear of toppling over into an ungracious lump, this moment was becoming unbearable, her mind was buzzing, intoxicated by Adora, her legs were quickly becoming useless, and her breathing was quick and uneven which was certainly not helping her light-headedness.

Sweeping the fingers of her free hand down Catra's arm lightly, Adora listened to Catra's breath quicken even more matching her own, felt her sleek fur prickle at her touch, watched as Catra's eyes focused intently on her lips as her breathy answer was forced from her throat before the tip of her tongue darted out to lick her lips, "I said, *do I smell good?*" Their lips now only inches apart, Adora watched as Catra blinked slowly, processing.

"*Yes*," her voice was rough, clearing her throat, Catra tried again, "you smell like lavender and earth. Its. . . comforting." Feeling bold as Adora processed, Catra brought a hand up to cup Adora's jaw, her other arm pushed off the wall, propelling her body softly into Adora's, bringing their torsos flush, then resting her hand on Adora's hip, holding them together tightly, "you smell like home." Closing the gap between their lips - quickly so as not to allow herself any time to talk her way out of her decision - Catra lightly brushed Adora's lips, testing them. Her mouth was warm, soft, and oh so good, she brought her lips back, more pressure this time.

Letting Catra take the lead, Adora closed her eyes, enjoying their soft kisses. Bringing her hand up to cup Catra's cheek, she stroked softly. When Catra pulled back to breathe, Adora opened her eyes and watched her expression; still a bit cloudy, but now had some confusion mixed in, as if she, just as Adora, had never felt such a feeling before, this fascination with another person, the excitement of their first kiss, the exhilaration of feeling another body pressed tightly against their own. They were both soldiers, albeit from different planets, but a soldier was a soldier, they were trained from children and were meant only to fight, no feeling; feelings made you weak. And yet, here they stood complete strangers, and yet so connected. Despite not knowing anything about the woman in her arms, all Adora wanted was to kiss her again. And so she did.

When Adora kissed her, she could *feel* her, it was as if she were feeling the same confused exhilaration, and so Catra allowed herself this one indulgence, she so rarely felt safe, what was the harm in allowing herself to feel wanted?

Pulling back, reluctantly, Adora cleared her throat, "while this has been nice, I need to grab some extra blankets and check on Kamila and Swift Wind. You can have the bed, Catra." Shivering at the loss of contact Adora brought her forehead to rest on Catra's.

Catra's head cleared when she heard Adora speak, then she noticed that she had almost entirely surrendered her weight to Adora whose arm was wrapped securely around her back. Placing her hands on Adora's shoulders she tested her balance, her legs felt like liquid. When she was ready, she removed her hands from Adora's shoulders, rubbing their noses lightly before pulling her head back. Adora waited until Catra gave her a nod before she removed her arm from Catra's waist then stepped back to observe her, almost as if she worried that Catra may topple over. "Thank you, but are you sure you want me in the bed? It is your ship." Taking in the woman before her, Catra noticed that Adora's hair was mussed and her lips were swollen, a small part of her felt satisfied, triumphant, at her state; *mine*. Putting *that* thought in the darkest corner of her mind to be avoided at *all costs* Catra raised a questioning brow, waiting for Adora to change her mind and have Catra sleep on the floor – or tell her to leave, neither answer would surprise her.

Adora had to step away from Catra, she really wanted to kiss her again, but she also knew it was probably a bad idea – *what did she really know about this woman besides her unbelievable attraction to her*? "Yes, please. I don't want you to be uncomfortable." Turning to leave before Catra could notice her blush, she rushed out of the barrack stopping a few feet from the door to lean her head on the cool metal of the hallway and tried to collect her thoughts. That was certainly *not* how she expected that to go, though she was quite pleased with herself, and as she walked away she couldn't help but notice a spring in her step – she just hoped Swift Wind wasn't paying attention, their sacred bond would allow him to feel her emotions, which would allow

him to fill in the blanks of what just happened. She wasn't quite ready to share this with anyone – not just yet she wasn't sure what it was herself.

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Bringing her fingers to her tingling lips Catra walked herself back until she found the wall again and slid down until her knees met her chest, only one thought on her mind; *what just happened?* Growing up in the Horde it was common knowledge that you weren't to touch the other cadets aside from one-on-one combat, and you were to never, under any circumstance, become romantically involved with another Horde soldier. With anyone. There was no family in the Horde, all soldiers were introduced to the militant lifestyle as orphans, taken after their parents were killed, or simply taken from their villages.

Further, Catra was Shadow Weavers ward, which just caused the other cadets to avoid her at all costs, if they were caught socializing with her they were reprimanded by Shadow Weaver herself; an experience Catra wouldn't wish on her worst enemy, she still bore the scars from the years of abuse endured before she'd finally escaped the sorceress.

The memories of Shadow Weaver proving to be the best wet blanket in existence, Catra rose, a bitter taste in her mouth, her brow furrowing in anger. She would *not* allow that woman to ruin this for her, she would escape the evil ideals forced on her as a child. Steeling herself she moved over to the bed, it was a typical soldier's bed; double size mattress, neatly tucked sheets, and a pillow sitting perfectly centered at the top.

Sighing, Catra slipped off her cloak and the plated armour cuffs covering her forearms and placed them neatly into one of the many cubbies surrounding the bed then leaned down to release the cuffs protecting her shins and ankles. Straightening she placed the shin guards into the same cubby before looking around for any prying eyes and listening for any approaching footsteps. When she was convinced no one was around, Catra loosened and slipped off her bodice and trousers, leaving only her undergarments. . . and her scars. Keeping her eyes firmly locked on the light switch as not to accidently catch a glimpse of herself anywhere, she switched off the light, slipping quickly under the sheets pulling them up to her chin.

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After checking that Kam and Swift Wind were comfortable Adora stopped in the kitchen to grab 2 bottles of water, then a linen closet to grab some comforters and sheets for herself – she hadn't lied, but she had fibbed a little, there was no cot on the ship, but she could make a pallet from the extra comforters, so she didn't see any need in allowing Catra a reason to deny a warm place to sleep. Even if that meant Adora would be uncomfortable for a few days.

"Hey, Darla."

'Yes, She-Ra?'

“Can you shut down all auxiliary power and make sure the fuel crystals are powered up? I need the ship to stay operational when Kam and I leave.”

‘Yes, She-Ra’

“Thank you.” Hurrying back to her room Adora knocked lightly as not to disturb Catra, the lights had been switched off inside the room, “Catra, is it alright if I come in?”

“Yes.”

Slipping into the room quick as she could to avoid any excess light flowing in from the hallway that would disturb her guest Adora shut and locked the door, “sorry about the wait, you must be tired. Ill be quick. I brought you some water.” Placing the water beside the bed, Adora moved a few feet away to place down her arm of comforters and arranging them into a makeshift pallet. Kicking off her boots she placed them beside her own bottle of water then pulled off her shirt and pants before climbing under the sheets.

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Catra listened as hurried footsteps approached the door, then a soft knock came followed by Adora’s soft voice, “Catra, is it alright if I come in?”

Ensuring all of her was covered by the blanket she called out to Adora, “yes.”

The door cracked and Adora slipped into the room, quickly closing the door again behind herself, “sorry about the wait, you must be tired. I brought you some water.” After placing a bottle of water beside her, Adora moved a few feet away before placing the bundle she was carrying onto the floor. Now that she was paying attention, Catra noticed that the bundle was comforters, Adora was planning to sleep on the floor? Why would she—

Her mind going blank mid-thought Catra watched as Adora slipped her fingers under the waist band of her pants, untucking her shirt before lifting it over her head. Catra’s mouth went dry as her eyes landed on Adora’s abdomen. It wasn’t as noticeable under her shirt, but Adora was extremely muscular, her abdominal muscles prominent even now when they were stretched taunt. When her thumbs hooked into her pants Catra looked away, her blush from before had returned with a vengeance. Once she heard Adora slip under the covers she turned back to watch the woman’s form as she tossed and turned trying to find a comfortable position.

“Are you not tired anymore, Catra?” Jumping Catra realized she been staring, “your eyes, they glow in the darkness?”

“Sorry, I can keep them closed,” flushing once again she squeezed her eyes shut; she’d gotten too comfortable, why would she think Adora would be any different than the cadets in the Horde. Her heart squeezing tight as her eyes, she brought her knees up to

her chest squeezing them with her arms as she fought off the memories of the Horde.

‘”How dare *you speak out to me Cadet. You will pay for your insolence!” Catra knew better than to answer the sorceress, even if she hadn’t said anything out of line she would be punished. Something had set off the woman’s temper and as the Second in Command she couldn’t have a temper tantrum in public and so she sought out Catra to be the scapegoat of her frustrations. . . every time. Taking a deep breath Catra emptied her mind of any thought and tried to ignore the rising fear in her gut as her arms were unwillingly stretched above her head by Shadow Weavers magic, the red tendrils of electricity channeled through the Black Garnet flicked and snapped all around her sending a strong, pulsating pain throughout her entire body as the Commander began her attack on the child. . .’*

‘”Get up mongrel, you’re late for this morning’s training exercises. I’m going to have to punish your fellow Cadets for this infraction.” Silently, Catra unfurled her limbs from her position on the concrete floor and stood on shaky legs as the pain returned full force. Staggering out of her cell Catra rushed to the Cadets barracks to quickly change into her training gear doing her best to ignore the newly puckered lacerations crisscrossing her body.’

“What’s your excuse now, Catra? Huh?” Ignoring the probing questions Catra continued into the barracks, avoiding all the prying eyes – of course, they all thought that Shadow Weaver had taken her yesterday for a ‘personal day’ and she’d had the time of her life and was having such a ‘good time’ that she had lost track of time and been late to training which then resulted in an extra hour’s one-on-one combat training as punishment. “So what, you’re just gonna ignore us then? Figures.”

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"No, no. . . I like them," when Catra stayed silent Adora shifted out of her pallet and kneeled at the edge of the bed, placing a hand on Catra's shoulder. Every muscle in her arm was tense. Worried, Adora placed her hand on Catra's cheek hoping to rouse her from whatever hole she'd found herself falling into, "Catra? Hey, Catra. . . Look at me."

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When a soft hand landed on her cheek Catra tensed more, then she felt the thumb rub her cheek bone rhythmically, back, and forth. . . back and forth. . . back and forth. Definitely not Shadow Weaver, she had never consoled Catra in her life – not even as a kitten, so when the rhythmic rub continued, Catra calmed slightly, the buzzing in her ears lessened as did her grip on her legs. "-tra? Hey, Catra. . . Look at me," at Adora's soothing tone Catra opened her eyes, blinking to clear her vision.

"Catra, I don't know where you just went with my comment, but I didn't mean anything ill of it. I like your eyes, the colouring is beautiful, and the glow in the dark is endearing; I like them. Besides, mine do too when I allow it, see," calling upon She-Ra's vision, Adora allowed her eyes to glow brightly, filling the area with soft light before allowing her magic to fade.

Catra watched as Adora's eyes filled with light morphing from calming blue to near white, and when Adora looked at her a tingle rolled down Catra's spine – this wasn't just Adora looking at her, there was something more in her gaze now, something, no. . . *someone* ancient observing her. Before she could think better of it, Catra let her walls crumble completely, in front of a complete stranger. A stranger who had shown her more kindness and compassion in mere hours than people she had known for years. A stranger that had made her feel. . . normal. For the first time in her life, the fact that her eyes glowed wasn't an anomaly – no one was calling her an alien. And so she burst into tears, because it was all too much; why did Adora like the things about her that caused her endless pain all throughout her childhood?

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When Catra burst into tears Adora didn't even think, she peeled the covers back, sat on the edge of the bed and pulled Catra into her arms holding her tightly with one arm, the other hand cupping her cheek continuing her stroking, hoping to help calm her. Singing an old Eternian lullaby, Adora began to rock them slowly.

When Catra's muscles had loosened considerably and her panic attack had subsided Adora allowed herself to stop rocking them but continued to sing as she looked down at her, Catra appeared to be asleep. Ending the lullaby, Adora tried to plan her extraction without disturbing Catra, somehow during her panic Catra had crawled fully into Adora's lap, her arms clung tightly around Adora's waist. With no other option Adora swiped her thumb harder across Catra's cheek hoping to rouse her, "Catra, are you awake?"

“Hmm?”

“I’m going to lay you down now, is that alright?”

“Hmm.”

Taking that as a positive, Adora hooked an arm under Catra’s knees angling her onto the mattress rather than Adora’s lap. When Catra’s grip on her torso didn’t loosen, Adora tried again to rouse her, “Catra? You’ll need to let me go if I’m to get up.”

“Mmh, no. Stay. . . *please.*”

Mornings With You

Chapter Summary

Some more Catradora fluff - the ending is kinda a cliffhanger but it would have droned on too long if I didn't end it there

With no other option Adora swiped her thumb harder across Catra's cheek hoping to rouse her, "Catra, are you awake?"

"Hmm?"

"I'm going to lay you down now, is that alright?"

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Taking that as a positive, Adora hooked an arm under Catra's knees angling her onto the mattress rather than Adora's lap. When Catra's grip on her torso didn't loosen, Adora tried again to rouse her, "Catra? You'll need to let me go if I'm to get up."

"Mmh, no. Stay. . . please."

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Slowly, Catra came into consciousness, she was so warm, so. . . comfortable. That feeling alone caused her eyes to whip open; Catra had never been comfortable in her life, especially when waking up. She only ever slept for a couple hours at a time, and even then it was never a fitful rest, but right now she felt as if she had slept for a week. Taking in her surroundings she noticed she was facing a wall filled with odd luminescent scripture `. . . *that's Ancient Eternian Scripture – the people I was born to. . . ´*, Adora's voice echoed in her head as she reached out a hand to caress a character that seemed familiar, but her mind was still hazy from sleep `*. . . the character you are referring to is my name. . .´*, ah yes, her name; it was beautiful. Quirking a lip Catra rolled over, languidly stretching out her back as she went, she must have been overly relaxed as when her eyes opened again she came face to face with Adora who was no more than an inch away, sleeping deeply. At that moment, everything came into hyper-focus, she finally notices the arm thrown over her waist, the cushion under her head that held her neck and head perfectly wasn't the pillow as she had previously assumed, but Adora's bicep and forearm that she had bent at an odd angle – as if more for Catra's comfort than her own. But the more focused her mind became, them more she noticed that the embrace was not completely one-sided, her tail was wrapped securely around Adora's upper thigh, where Catra decided, it was alright to leave it. She also decided that she quite liked being hugged by Adora and slowly wrapped an arm around Adora's waist and wedged her free hand between Adora's hip and the mattress, intertwining their legs in the process. Now laying flush against Adora from her toes to her chest she nestled her nose into the crook of her neck and breathed deeply.

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Some time later Catra's eyes opened once again, blinking sleepily she tried to wipe her eyes, but her arms didn't budge; her arms

were pinned. Panicking momentarily her eyes widened as the sleep washed out of her mind, then she saw it – a bare neck where her face was pressed; the reason she had trouble breathing. Memories flooded back to her;

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'"w-what?" licking her suddenly dry lips Catra waited for Adora's question.

"I said, do I smell good*?" Blinking, she processed the question, more of a proposition really. One Catra was more than willing to take on.*

"Yes," her voice was rough, clearing her throat, Catra tried again, "you smell like lavender and earth. Its. . . comforting." Feeling bold as Adora processed, Catra brought a hand up to cup Adora's jaw, her other arm pushed off the wall, propelling her body softly into Adora's, bringing their torsos flush, then resting her hand on Adora's hip, holding them together tightly, "you smell like home." Closing the gap between their lips - quickly so as not to allow herself any time to talk her way out of her decision - Catra lightly brushed Adora's lips, testing them. Her mouth was warm, soft, and oh so good, she brought her lips back, more pressure this time.'

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Adora, still sleeping, pulled Catra closer lowering her head to cuddle into Catra's hair, the arm cradling Catra moved her head closer to Adora's chest. A section of Adora's hair slid down her shoulder landing on Catra's fists. Curiosity filled her at the sight of

the golden locks falling across her clenched fists, she'd only ever touched her own hair, and not often – her mane was impossible and she had long since given up on it. But Adora's hair. . . it looked so soft, so inviting, Catra uncurled her fists and let the strands fall into her palm; it was soft, light, and so different from her own rough, heavy clumps of hair. It was mesmerizing, before she could think better of it Catra reached her hand up to stroke the section of hair from root to tip, the strands sliding between her fingers, gliding along her claws.

*****

'"Are you not tired anymore, Catra?" Jumping Catra realized she been staring, "your eyes, they glow in the darkness."

"Sorry, I can keep them closed," flushing once again she squeezed her eyes shut; she got too comfortable, why would she think Adora would be any different than the cadets in the Horde. Her heart squeezing tight as her eyes, she brought her knees up to her chest squeezing them with her arms as she fought off the memories of the Horde.

Falling into a full-blown panic attack, Catra was lost to the memories of the Horde Cadets poking fun at her, pulling her hair, and crushing her hands berating her with questions on why her eyes glowed? Why were her nails so sharp? Why was her hair so unkempt. Why were they ridiculed for her shortcomings? Shadow Weaver loved to lock her in her cell until she was late for training, then blame it on her when the cadets were punished for her tardiness, they would in turn take out their frustrations on her after training, and so went the cycle, day in, day out.

When a hand fell on her cheek she tensed waiting for the searing pain of a slap or nails digging in down to the bone, but the pain never came, instead there was a steady, firm finger stroking her

cheek, back and forth. . . back and forth. . . back and forth. . . "-tra? Hey, Catra. . . Look at me," that voice. . . she knew that voice, this wasn't Shadow Weaver, she had never bothered to comfort Catra, not even as a kitten. Opening her eyes she saw soft, ethereal blue eyes staring back at her full of patience and. . . worry? Adora*. . . "Catra, I don't know where you just went with my comment, but I didn't mean anything ill of it. I like your eyes, the colouring is beautiful, and the glow in the dark is endearing; I like them. Besides, mine do too when I allow it, see," Catra watched as Adora's eyes filled with light morphing from calming blue to near white, and when Adora looked at her a tingle rolled down Catra's spine – this wasn't just Adora looking at her, there was something more in her gaze now, something, no. . .* someone *ancient observing her.*

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Frowning, her hand faltered at the base of Adora's skull; what, or *who* should she say, had been staring at her through Adora? While the person comforting her the previous night had definitely been Adora, there was a definitive difference between Adora's soft blue eyes and the nearly white iridescent gaze that had observed her in that moment. Pondering that Catra began to lightly scrape her nails along Adora's scalp while she continued her mindless massage drifting back to unconsciousness.

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Adora woke to the feel of a body pressed against her own, Kam generally overheated during her sleep and wouldn't have cuddled up to Adora, who also tended to run hot at night, opening her eyes her vision was filled with Catra's sleeping face, she looked so

young now that there was no guarded expression on her features that made her look beyond her years. Sometime in the night Catra had rolled toward Adora and was now snuggling her contentedly, one hand cupping her head, the other resting between their bodies. Their bodies were completely flush all the way from their intertwined legs to Catra's face buried in the crook of her neck. Closing her eyes once again she called upon She-Ra to connect with the nature surrounding the ship to gauge the time of day, Kamila wouldn't wake up until midday so she wasn't worried on that front, but Swift Wind would certainly come looking for her much earlier, but by her reasoning it was still early morning.

"So, are you some kind of Princess, Adora? Is that why your eyes glow like that?" Catra's voice rang out muffled slightly by her neck, but Adora could feel the vibration of her voice. Letting out a small squeak of surprise she opened her eyes to see Catra looking up at her, chin still tucked into the crook of her neck.

"I would assume that would be the terminology for my magic on this planet, though I'm not entirely sure. I haven't met any of these princesses you speak of, so I can't be certain." The room was still dark so Adora could only see Catra's eyes and her immediate vicinity without calling on She-Ra, so she looked into Catra's eyes waiting for a response.

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Catra had been drifting in and out of consciousness for a while when she felt Adora lift her head to look down at her, waiting for a moment after she stopped moving Catra opened her eyes and looked up slightly. Adora seemed to be focusing intently on

something when the peculiar glow from the previous night returned to her eyes peaking out from under her eyelids.

Deciding she was curious enough to speak up Catra cleared her throat, "so, are you some kind of Princess, Adora? Is that why your eyes glow like that?" a squeak of surprise came from Adora before her eyes locked with Catra's, the white irises morphing back into their usual blue.

Adora's brow furrowed slightly as if she were choosing her words carefully, "I would assume that would be the terminology for my magic on this planet, though I'm not entirely sure. I haven't met any of these princesses you speak of, so I can't be certain," clearly avoiding the question Adora's eyes never left Catra's as she waited.

It wasn't her place to pry into another's life, she certainly wasn't about to open up about herself, her past, so instead she resumed brushing her fingers through Adora's hair, "alright, I wont pry." When Adora's hand came up to so the same, starting at her scalp then stopping at the knotted mess that was Catra's mane, "heh, probably should have warned you about that, I don't think I have ever brushed my hair, no one has really cared enough to try. . ." wincing slightly at her slip up Catra sat up, extracting herself from Adora bringing her knees to her chest and squeezing her eyes closed.

***

Catra’s hand resumed brushing through her hair and Adora relaxed, her muscles turning to liquid under the attention from her hand, “alright, I wont pry.” Closing her eyes momentarily to enjoy the moment Adora lifted her own out of pure curiosity, Catra’s mane was a mystery to her. The locks highlighted in the dull light of Catra’s eyes. Her hair was rough, but at the same time it felt soft, not so much unkempt as it was maintained but otherwise left alone. Sinking her fingers in to massage Catra’s scalp lightly she went to brush her fingers through, but her fingers didn’t move a millimetre in the matted locks. “Heh, probably should have warned you about that, I don’t think I have ever brushed my hair, no one has really cared enough to try. . .” as if a switch had flipped at her comment Catra’s face fell and she retreated from Adora’s embrace, sitting up and bringing her knees up to her chest, wrapping her arms around them tightly. The position seemed to bring her comfort as every time she had gotten upset around Adora she assumed this position and squeezed her eyes shut, her arms mirroring the action around her legs, squeezing so much that she heard a joint pop.

Sitting up Adora mirrored her position, sans the tightly wound arms, sitting close enough to allow their shoulders to brush, not too much, but just enough to let Catra know that she was there, “hey, I don’t know what happened to you in the past, but I can tell you right now that you now have someone that cares about you. I’m not going to ask you what happened, but if you need to talk, I’m here.” Placing her fingers on Catra’s chin Adora pressed lightly, a silent request for Catra to look at her, when she complied Adora held her gaze, “alright?”

Catra’s eyes searched hers as if she were looking for any reason at all to disavow Adora’s claim, when she apparently found none she sighed, “alright.”

“Alright.” Smiling Adora dropped her hand, “now, its getting on and I promised Kamila we would practice today. You can stay in here as long as you want, we’ll be just outside the ship.” Standing Adora stretched out her muscles before switching on the light and heading over to her pallet to dress, “If you need anything, or get lost just say ‘hey, Darla’ –“

‘Yes, She-Ra?’

“and Darla, the ships interactive system, will assist you. Hey, Darla please allow Catra administrator clarence to all of the ships systems, please.”

‘Yes, She-Ra. New administrator, Catra, please confirm voice prompt.’

Turning to a confused Catra she elaborates, “just say something, like ‘hey, Darla’ for instance, she just needs to analyze your vocal patterns and add you to the system database as an administrator.”

“Uhm, ok. . . hey, Darla.”

‘Thank you. New Administrator, Catra, added to system database.’

That name that only the ship seemed to use for Adora was bugging her, what was the significance of it; Adora didn’t seem fazed by the use of it either, answering to it as if it were second

nature, “so, She-Ra?” Catra turned to observe Adora, watching her pull on her pants and shirt, her tail flicking impatiently behind her.

Flicking her eyes to meet Catra’s her hands stopped, her midriff still exposed, “She-Ra was my call sign.” Not willing to go down that hole again so early in the morning Adora finished dressing and walked to the door, “do you need anything? I can grab you some food if you’d like?”

“No, thank you though,” she gave Adora a small smile before she left. Laying back Catra stretched out languidly, ensuring to stretch out every muscle before laying comfortably on the bed, but her relaxation didn’t last long as she came to realize that she was wearing only her underwear and Adora had just seen her. . . all of her. . . including her scars.

***

“Adora! Well good morning sleepy head! We thought you were going to sleep through the day.” She could hear the sarcasm dripping from Swift Winds tone as she entered the kitchen. He could probably smell Catra on her, he had a weirdly astute sense of smell, probably something to do with his magic.

“Yeah! I was gonna go and get you after breakfast!” Seemingly not picking up on Swift Winds sarcasm Kamila looked up from her oatmeal a blindingly bright smile plastered on her face.

“My, your up early Kam, don’t tell me Swifty woke you?” Sitting down she scooped herself some oatmeal, taking a bite.

“Nah, I was up already.” Giddy, her foot was tapping restlessly, excitement was *oozing* off the girl, “where’s Catra? Is she still asleep?”

“Yes, she was extremely tired. I’m sure she will join us later to give you some pointers.” At the mention of training Kamila jumped out of her seat.

“Can we start now?”

“Yes, yes, don’t hurt yourself.”

**** a few hours later ****

Finishing up their combative training they had stopped to re-hydrate, “you’re getting really good Kam, you almost landed a hit this time.”

“Oh, don’t lie to me, we both know I wasn’t even close.” Kam waved her off, in a huff after hours of trying to hit a small pin on the center of Adora’s chest. . . and failing.

“She’s right you know,” Swift Winds deadpanned reply came from where he had been laying for their entire session, a peanut gallery as Kam would put it, poking fun at Kam at every chance he could find.

“Oh, Swifty, you’ve never landed a hit on me either.”

“Pshh, no ones ever landed a hit on you, Adora, not even as a Cadet. You’re just weird.”

“Not true, Mara has landed a hit on me.” Smirking at a comment that was sure to start a fit she walked back into the center of the clearing beckoning Kam to follow her.

“Wow. . . the great Force Commander has been able to land a hit? I am *shocked*.”

“Ah, quit your mumbling Swifty. Why don’t you go find Melog, make a friend with another magical creature?”

“Fine, fine. Ill get outta your hair,” picking up on the hint Swift Wind made himself scarce, when using She-Ra’s magic they would often amplify each others magic to a dangerous extent. Good in a fight, not so good in training, especially with a novice like Kamila around. She could barely control her magic as is.

“Aww, I’m still tired Addy, can’t we take a longer break? I’m not ready for more one-on-one,” shoulder slumping, Kam looked a little worse for wear, the novelty of training worn away hours ago.

“We’re not doing one-on-one training anymore. We’re going to move on. . .”

Waiting for Kam to process and follow her trail of thought she watched as the tired expression on her face morphed into excitement. “Magic!”

“Yes. Alright as we practiced, reach down. Fell the magic within you and the magic around you. It’ll be easier than normal; the magic of the planet is much stronger in the woods.” She watched as Kamila took a deep breath before her eyes began to glow, lightly at first brightening as she felt the magic around them swell. When the balance began to shift and Kam was losing control, short hot beams releasing from her outstretched hands she called upon She-Ra to help guide and balance out the magic before it became too much for the girl.

She could feel as the magic flowing from Kam crested and her normally hidden markings began to glow, her hair fell from her wings as they were extended fully, white markings appearing, criss-crossing down the length of them. “Alright Kamila, now I want you to channel all this energy you’re feeling into your hands. Can you do that?”

When she began to feel the magic move, concentrating on Kam’s hands she released her hold slightly allowing the girl to control

her magic completely. “Now when you’re ready, I want you to read my thoughts. What am I thinking?”

Rather than speaking out loud she felt Kam’s voice echo in her head “*You’re thinking about lunch and. . . Catra?*” blushing she closed her minds barrier, gently.

“Yes, that’s right. Now, release your magic, slowly.”

As her magic dissipated she blinked quickly, “Gah! I wish I didn’t have to keep my eyes open when I use the magic. . . mom doesn’t.” Pouting Kam plopped onto the ground.

“You will get it in time, just as your mother did, you’ll have to learn your abilities, and master them.”

“From what I saw, you’re doin’ alright, kid.” Startled Adora whipped her face to meet a mismatched gaze and a cocky smirk, “mornin’, Princess.”

Scars - Happy Birthday Adora!!

Chapter Summary

Will She-Ra reveal herself to save a new friend after a training mishap?

Chapter Notes

Bonus update for Adora's birthday!

Everyone say Happy Birthday 🔪 🔪

That name that only the ship seemed to use for Adora was bugging her, what was the significance of it; Adora didn't seem fazed by the use of it either, answering to it as if it were second nature, "so, She-Ra?" Catra turned to observe Adora, watching her pull on her pants and shirt, her tail flicking impatiently behind her.

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"Shit." Her relaxed mood ruined Catra climbed out of the bed and began to pull on her clothing. Every piece she put on her body made her feel a little better; her pants covered the large burn mark left after a 'training accident' when she was 14. Her bodice covered the scratch marks left on her stomach by fellow cadets, as well as the numerous welts on her back from Shadow Weaver. Her ankle cuffs secured her foot coverings over the scarred bottoms of her feet. Her leather arm bands and forearm cuffs covered numerous other scars, but the one piece of clothing she never went without was her headpiece. She hated the thing with a passion - it was the only material keepsake from the Horde shed bothered to maintain - but it covered a large scar that followed her hairline and curled all the way down her chin, another 'training accident' when she was 12, so she made sure it was intact. What wasn't covered by her clothing she hid behind her cloak when around others. It was a good system. She'd been able to avoid questions from people she'd met for years, until Adora. She'd laid nearly naked with the woman without feeling the slightest bit self-conscious, she had even forgotten about her scars for a time. *Why hadn't Adora mentioned her scars?* It wasn't as if they were hard to miss. Odd indeed.

"Catra?" jumping slightly as her head was filled with Melog's voice she headed to the door, surprised to see that Adora had locked it for her after leaving. A small private smile curled onto her lips as her heart floated in her chest. *"Catra?"*

"Yeah, Yeah bud, I'm comin', one sec." Unlocking the door she opened up to see not only Melog, but the large horse as well, Swift. . . something.
~~~

"Swift Wind."

"Oh, well aren't you the smart one, huh?" she knew she was being rude, but for some reason she was feeling snarky.

"Huh?" looking utterly confused by her outburst the horse screwed up his face.

"I was talking to Melog. Can you show me where the kitchen is?"

***

It had been a while since Swift Wind had announced 'you two are even more boring than Base Command! I'm gonna go find Kamila. At least she cracks a joke now and then!', he didn't seem to share their love for doing nothing; she and Melog had curled up in the corner of the kitchen after eating breakfast. But alas, Catra was beginning to get bored as well. She was wide awake and had picked at and sharpened her nails twice already. "Well hello sleepy heads!" Hissing at the sudden intrusion she and Melog readied themselves. "Wow! You two look like you're ready to kill someone." Swift Wind continued into the room as if he hadn't a care in the world, or that two creatures were poised to attack in the corner. "Anyways, Adora is going to be practicing some magic with Kammy so I had to vacate the area. I was ordered to *'make a friend with another magical creature'*.

His whining was really beginning to get on her nerves, she didn't know how Adora could stand him, "*ugh, Melog. Its you he wants to make nice with. I'm gonna go outside, ok?"* at their nod Catra wandered out of the kitchen and immediately faced the decision, left or right? Turning right she began her quest to find the ships exit.

"Magic!"

The faint cry caught her attention, she must be heading in the right direction. Continuing her stroll she didn't quicken her pace when she heard Adora's voice, *she did not.* Just like her ears didn't perk up at the husky tone hoping to catch every syllable she could, *they didn't*. *"Yes. Alright as we practiced, reach down. Fell the magic within you and the magic around you. It'll be easier than normal; the magic of the planet is much stronger in the woods."*

Adora's voice got louder as Catra turned the next corner and spotted the large entrance, open allowing fresh air and soft afternoon light pour through it. And just as she didn't quicken her pace or perk her ears, she also didn't let her eyelids fall to the sound of Adora's voice as she continued talking the little girl through her magical training. Turning the corner to peek out at them she wasn't expecting a blast of magical energy to whiz past her head. Her hair fizzing she held back a hiss when she noticed Adora's eyes begin to glow as if she were helping the girl control the magic leaking from her outstretched palms. Spreading throughout Adora's body until she glowed as brightly as Kamila, so bright that Catra had to squint before she blinded herself. "Alright Kamila, now I want you to channel all this energy you're feeling into your hands. Can you do that?"

At Adora’s command, the glow she was emitting began running towards her palms and whit markings appeared on her face, hands, and wings. While Kamila’s glow brightened, Adora’s lessened until It was only her eye once again. “Now when you’re ready, I want you to read my thoughts. What am I thinking? “Yes, that’s right. Now, release your magic, slowly.” Now that was certainly odd, the girl hadn’t said anything out loud, but Adora had begun to blush and answered an unasked question; must be telepathy.

As her magic dissipated Kamila blinked quickly, “Gah! I wish I didn’t have to keep my eyes open when I use the magic. . . mom doesn’t.” Quirking a lip at something she had thought constantly growing up she stepped out from behind the wall as the magical blasts seemed to have been nullified.

“You will get it in time, just as your mother did, you’ll have to learn your abilities, and master them.” Catra was mystified, how far did this woman’s patience go? Any time she had been caught lacking in some way. . . she didn’t even want to think on it; this wasn’t the Horde and Adora wasn’t Shadow Weaver.

“From what I saw, you’re doin’ alright, kid.” Wide eyes met her own when Adora noticed her standing there, smirking she decided to mess with her a bit, “mornin’, Princess.”

Ah, what a pretty blush she has, “ah-ahem, good morning Catra. How did you sleep?” the sweetest smile spread on Adora’s lips as she regained her composure, a smile that caught Catra off guard rendering her voice box useless as they stared at each other.

“Awkwaaaarddd. . .”

“Ah, shit! God dammit, make some noise when you move!” Whipping around to face the horse Catra’s hackles rose, he was right behind her. *How had he gotten so close to her? Was she so wrapped up in her own mind that she allowed someone to approach her from behind.* She needed to get a hold of herself.

“Wow, you really do poof when startled. . . *interesting*.” She didn’t like the look the horse was giving her, just what exactly was he alluding to? Was he planning something?

Before she could probe his intentions Adora spoke up, “don’t you dare, Swifty! I know what you’re thinking!”

“Oh come on, It’ll be funny!”

“It will not!”

“I’m gonna do it!” When he turned to walk back into the ship she heard Adora stomp her way over and grab his tail.

“Swift Wind! If you so much as go *near* the kitchen when its not mealtime I will shave you.”

“You wouldn’t dare!”

“Bald.”

As they continued to bicker about the horses supposedly scandalous intentions she walked over to the Artimi child, “Kamila, right?”

“Yes, but you can call me Kam! All my friends do it. . .” *friends?*

“We’re friends?”

“Of course. I like you. You’re really nice,” *oh.*

“Oh, um, thank you?” turning back to the bickering she spoke again, “so what’s up with them then?”

“Oh, they share some kind of ‘sacred bond’, I don’t really understand. Their magic is connected somehow and they can feel each others’ emotions, kinda like me.” She watched the girl look up at her in her peripheral vision, when she looked down to meet Kamila’s eyes she gasped as she felt her mind being *probed*. “Why are you so sad, Catra? Your emotions are all over the place. You feel as though you don’t deserve my friendship, why is that?” She

felt a soft clawed hand cup her cheek gently but for some reason, she didn't *want* to pull away.

"Woah there Kam. You can't just read peoples emotions like that, its quite rude." She heard Adora, but she just couldn't tear her eyes away from Kamila's. When the hand was dropped from her cheek a moment later it was like a spell was broken and they both blinked rapidly. Blinking she shook her head slightly, her thoughts were all muddled up, she was beginning to panic.

Suddenly her vision was filled with Adora; her soft blue eyes, her golden hair, her light skin, her perfect mouth that was. . . moving? Listening intently she could hear a faint voice, "*Catra? Are you alright? Look at me.*" Lifting her gaze at Adora's request she focused her eyes onto Adora's grounding herself, fighting the rising panic.

***

"You will get it in time, just as your mother did, you'll have to learn your abilities, and master them."

"From what I saw, you're doin' alright, kid." Startled Adora whipped her face to meet a mismatched gaze and a cocky smirk, "mornin', Princess."

A blush exploded over her face at the look in Catra's eyes, "ah-ahem, good morning Catra. How did you sleep?" shaking off her

embarrassment she smiled at the woman; she knew Catra resorted to throwing people off when she felt uncomfortable or threatened, it was a classic sign of past abuse. Judging by the amount and depth of the scars she had seen on her last night Catra had obviously been abused constantly as a child, by more than one person by the variations in size and shape of the wounds and so she smiled at her, hoping to ease the stress she was feeling.

"Awkwaaaarddd. . ."

"Ah, shit! God dammit, make some noise when you move!" Catra whipped around to face Swift Wind as her hackles rose causing her to *poof,* all of her was standing on end and her tail was easily twice its normal size, she had to choke down a giggle tapping Kam's shoulder when a giggle escaped the girl. Catra looked absolutely baffled.

"Wow, you really do poof when startled. . . *interesting*." Adora didn't like the look that Swift Wind was giving Catra. What was he planning? Through their sacred bond she could feel his emotions, and to some extent read his thoughts, and the thought at the forefront of his mind didn't bode well for any of them of he were to execute it, especially Catra.

"Don't you dare, Swifty! I know what you're thinking!"

"Oh come on, It'll be funny!"

"It will not!"

"I'm gonna do it!"

When he turned to disappear into the ship, no doubt heading to the kitchen, Adora rushed up the ramp and grabbed his tail, "Swift Wind! If you so much as go *near* the kitchen when its not mealtime I will shave you."

"You wouldn't dare!"

"Bald."

"Adora! How could you even suggest that!" a movement from behind her suggested Catra had walked down the ramp to socialize with Kamila.

"Its no worse than *spraying Catra with water*!" lowering her voice to a harsh whisper she hoped Catra wouldn't hear, the thought alone would probably get Swifty shaved, by Catra.

"I-I was not. . ."

"Do not lie to me Swift Wind."

As they stared each other down she caught the butt end of Kamila and Catra's conversation, "so what's up with them then?"

"Oh, they share some kind of 'sacred bond', I don't really understand. Their magic is connected somehow and they can feel each others' emotions, kinda like me. . . Why are you so sad, Catra? Your emotions are all over the place. You feel as though you don't deserve my friendship, why is that?"

Oh no, she'll hurt Catra if she continues; she can't control her magic yet. Letting go of Swift Wind she broke their stare and ignored the whoop he gave at his victory to rush down the ramp and place a hand on Kamila's shoulder as not to startle her. If Kam were to retract her magic from Catra too fast she could do some irreversible damage. "Woah there Kam. You can't just read peoples emotions like that, its quite rude."

When Kam dropped her hand blinking Adora rushed over to Catra, catching her frame before she crumpled to the ground. She had to get her speaking, or at least responsive. When she grabbed her Catra looked at her, but she was too distant for Adora's liking, almost as if she were looking at her from afar. "Catra? Are you alright? Look at me."

When Catra lifted her gaze to focus on hers she saw the rising panic, this wasn't good. If she were to panic now it'll hard to get her out of the trance.

Scooping Catra into her arms she turned to Kam, “hey, can you go find Swift Wind? He should be in the kitchen.”

Looking a little loopy herself, Kam looked up at Adora with tired eyes, “yeah. . .”

Rushing up the ramp she made sure Kamila turned the right way for the kitchen, then went the opposite way to her room, locking the door when they arrived. “Hey Catra? I’m going to place you on the bed, ok? You’re alright. Don’t panic. Ill get you out of there, alright?”

There was no verbal response from her, but Catra’s eyes were still locked on hers, a silent affirmation. Laying her on the bed Adora stood, summoning her sword she spoke the ancient transformation words of her people, “for the honour of Grayskull.” She felt the distinctive tingle spread through her body as She-Ra took form, her muscles stretched and her joints popped as her limbs extended. She felt the cool metal of her armbands and tiara form, her clothing dissolved before the white bodysuit covered her. When done she knelt before Catra gently lifting her into a sitting position, placing her forehead against the other woman’s.

While she could heal without calling upon She-Ra fully, this type of magical healing was too advanced and would be much safer for her to perform as She-Ra. “Alright Catra, bare with me, it’s been a while.” Reaching within herself she pooled hers and the planets magic into a small ball and brought it up and through her forehead pushing into Catra’s.

When she opened her eyes she was in a dark chamber she didn't recognize, *this must be what Catra is re-living*, wandering around she didn't see anyone until she rounded a corner, there was a large red runestone mounted in the center of a large room and off to one side was her Catra watching something, ensuring she was de-transformed so Catra would recognize her, she approached watching the scene unfold before them.

'"How dare *you speak out to me Cadet. You will pay for your insolence!" The young girl, Catra she assumed, stayed quiet, as if this were a normal occurrence.* Why was a grown woman throwing a temper tantrum in front of a child? *The child, ever silent, took a deep breath before closing her eyes seconds before red tendrils thrown from the woman's hands wrapped around the girl and her arms and legs were ripped apart, spread eagle. She could feel the panic rising in the child as well as the woman standing rigidly beside her, turning away as the woman began to attack she banished the vision leaving only blank space around them, though she was sure that even if the image were banished, Catra was re-living the memory all the same.*

"Catra. . . Catra, look at me." The look she got was empty, she may be looking at her, but Catra wasn't there, she had to rouse her somehow.

***

She was vaguely aware of that she was lifted into someone's arms and carried to another room, but lost consciousness somewhere along the way, when she came too again, Adora was speaking to her, "hey Catra? I'm going to place you on the bed, ok? You're alright. Don't panic. Ill get you out of there, alright?" Though her

voice didn’t seem to be co-operating, Adora apparently got the message, before she lost consciousness again she heard Adora mutter the most unusual thing, “for the honour of Grayskull.”

When she opened her eyes again, she didn’t see Adora’s soft hair, her blue eyes, or her bright smile, all she saw was her worst nightmare come to life.

She was standing in Shadow Weavers Black Garnet Chamber, *shit*.

‘”How dare *you speak out to me Cadet. You will pay for your insolence!”*

Her head whipped over to the voice she dreaded the most in her life only to realize she wasn’t talking to her, well she was, but not to her now. No, what she was witnessing was a recurring nightmare of hers, only this time she was outside her body looking on to the situation.

Her younger self stayed quiet, she’d known better than to answer the sorceress, even if she hadn’t said anything out of line she would be punished. Something had set off the woman’s temper and as the Second in Command she couldn’t have a temper tantrum in public and so she sought out Catra to be the scapegoat of her frustrations. . . every time. She’d taken a deep breath, emptied her mind of any thought and tried to ignore the rising fear in her gut as her arms were unwillingly stretched above her head by Shadow Weavers magic, the red tendrils of electricity channeled through the Black Garnet flicking and snapping all

around her sending a strong, pulsating pain throughout her entire body as the Commander began her attack on her younger self. . .'

Then it was gone, but even when the image vanished, the beating she had received that day replayed in her brain, over and over. . . and over again.

"Catra. . . Catra, look at me." The voice was faraway, but so close at the same time, turning she noticed a blurry figure standing next to her, *who?*

***

Doing the only thing she knew to work she lifted a hand to stroke Catra's cheek softly, rhythmically. When life started to return to Catra's eyes Adora tried again, "Catra?"

"Mmmh. . . Ad- Adora," her voice was rough, weak, but the hand that gripped her wrist was strong.

"Catra, you need to wake up, ok? *Wake up*." Catra's eyes searched her own before her form dissipated.

Looking around at the blank room one more time, Adora too extracted herself, retracting her magics hold on Catra's brain, but left their heads together. "You have 3 seconds to tell me who the hell you are before I attack." Pulling back at the dangerous note in

Catra's tone, Adora realized she hadn't de-transformed, *shit.*
"Wait. . . those eyes. Adora? Is that you?"

"Um, yes. . ."

"So, are you gonna explain your. . . uh. . . size?"

Letting her transformation fade she felt herself shrink until her eyes were level with Catra's chest rather than eyes, "its, uh. . . a long story. . . heh."

"I bet." Catra shifted so that she could run her fingers through Adora's ponytail, her face held a look that said she had more questions, but she refrained.

Sighing Adora laid her arms across Catra's thighs leaning her head on her arms, reveling in the attention to her hair, "well, long story short, the magic I possess is not technically my magic. Well. . . some of it is, but its. . . boosted in a way by magic that is passed through the daughters of my lineage. The magic of She-Ra, Princess of Power."

Catra tugged the elastic from her hair and ran her fingers through a few times before answering, "well, I certainly wasn't expecting *that*, but y'know in a way it makes total sense, given the circumstances."

“What circumstances do you mean?”

“Well, first of all you’re out here with a daughter of the Artimi Queen teaching her how to control her magic and when she lost control of that magic you were able to venture into my head and fish out my conscious.”

“You do have a rather valid point there at the end, but I’m training Kamila, not because I possess She-Ra’s magic, but because she and her mother asked me to train her. The people of Ardglass do not know of my being She-Ra. Only you and Swift Wind know this fact.” Looking up she caught the surprised look on Catra’s face, her jaw slack.

“You revealed yourself to save me?”

“Not necessarily. My being She-Ra is not a secret, more of an unknown fact. I haven’t needed to use She-Ra’s full power yet in my years on Etheria and none have asked the origin of my magical abilities.”

“So, why did you need She-Ra now?”

“My healing abilities aren’t nearly as strong in my body as they are in my transformed state, I felt the situation warranted my full power.”

“Um, thank you,” a pretty blush spread onto Catra’s cheeks. Adora smiled before rising, offering her hand to Catra.

“Are you feeling up to helping me finish Kamila’s training? I think we’ll finish off the day with some more combative training.”

“Sure.”

***

“You’re not serious are you? You’re pulling your punches Kam; Adora can take a punch you know, let her have it.” Catra stood off to the side watching the sparring match between Kamila and Adora. While it was obvious she was a beginner, Kamila had some amazing core knowledge of fighting that the Horde often skipped as it ‘took to long to teach and would impede on their physical training’. But it seems Adora had taken her time with this one, her footing and core movements were executed perfectly, but her attacks were fumbled and weak willed. “Kam, I know from your movements that you are trying not to hurt Adora, and its scary, the thought of having to hurt another person, but think of it this way; there may be a time in your life where these teachings could save you. Remember, the Horde comes closer to taking Etheria each day, one day, you’ll have to fight someone trying to take you from your family.” She looked into the girl’s eyes when she stopped sparring to listen. “Fight as if your life depends on it now, because someday it might.”

“Ok, ill try.” When Kamila turned back to Adora, steadying herself Catra caught Adora giving her a worried glance.

**** A few hours later, Adora's barracks ****

Catra had been laying awake since they had retreated to the bedroom to sleep. Adora had been tossing and turning on her pallet, her movements mirroring the roiling thoughts that had been bombarding Catra's brain all day. She had so many questions, but she really didn't want to push Adora away by asking the wrong one. She'd been so *happy* lately she just didn't want to ruin it. When she heard Adora let out a sharp sigh she turned toward her pallet, opening her eyes, "hey, Adora. . . are you awake?"

She could here shuffling before Adora's eyes came into view, "yeah, haven't really been able to sleep."

"Same here." The silence lingered, it was obvious both had something to say, but neither knew how to say it, "can you. . . can you maybe come and. . . sit with me?" her voice sounded small and she hated herself for it, "y-you don't have to-" stopping she heard Adora shifting before soft footfalls came toward her. Lifting the sheet as an invitation she scooched backward until she was flat against the wall.

"Do you want me to lay on top of the sheets? You don't seem very comfortable."

"N-no its fine. I was just. . . um. . . cold." They both knew it was a lie and yet she felt the bed dip when Adora laid down, the sheet

tugged slightly as she covered herself, then they were silent again. It was unbearable, and so she asked the question she just couldn't seem to let go of. . .

"Why haven't you asked about my scars?"

Jealousy is an Oddity

Chapter Summary

Time to brush the cat!!!

Get ready for some extreme fluff and an exciting finish!!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Same here." The silence lingered, it was obvious both had something to say, but neither knew how to say it, "can you. . . can you maybe come and. . . sit with me?" her voice sounded small and she hated herself for it, "y-you don't have to-" stopping she heard Adora shifting before soft footfalls came toward her. Lifting the sheet as an invitation she scooched backward until she was flat against the wall.

"Do you want me to lay on top of the sheets? You don't seem very comfortable."

"N-no its fine. I was just. . . um. . . cold." They both knew it was a lie and yet she felt the bed dip when Adora laid down, the sheet tugged slightly as she covered herself, then they were silent again. It was unbearable, and so she asked the question she just couldn't seem to let go of. . .

"Why haven't you asked about my scars?"

~~~ a few days later ~~~

“Melog really is soft. . . in an odd, hairless sort of way,” Adora was sat in a soft, sunny patch of grass not far from her ship stroking a very content Melog who was splayed over her lap. Kamila and Swift Wind Had curled together on her right and Catra sat across from her looking rather put out.

“He sure is.” Adora’s comment only seemed to increase Catra’s annoyance as she barked her reply, eyes beginning to bore holes through the hand that was stroking Melog. Huffing as if making her mind up about something, Catra collapsed onto her back stretching out languidly.

She was an odd one indeed, Adora had to wonder what had piqued her annoyance. The longer she watched Catra stretch out the more she pieced together the problem. . . “Catra, are-are you jealous of Melog.”

“What? No! What would I be jealous of?” There it was, a hot blush rushed onto Catra’s cheeks, Adora had been right.

“Do you want me to stroke you?” she kept her tone innocent, but her expression conveyed her intent well enough.

Catra spluttered before stuttering, “w-what do you mean by *that?*”

"Oh, nothing nefarious. Just what I said; would you like me to *stroke* you?"

Rather than answering, Catra hesitantly rolled onto her hands and knees, slowly crawling towards Adora, "lift your arm."

"Of course, my lady," lifting her free arm she smirked when Catra's nose twitched in annoyance, but she didn't comment on the pet name, instead she managed to fit herself between Melog and Adora before grabbing Adora's hovering hand, placing it on her cheek.

They sat like that for a long time, Adora stroking down Catra's side, cheek to hip, occasionally altering her course to massage Catra's scalp lightly before returning to her cheek. Her other hand continued to stroke Melog absently. Despite losing the feeling in her legs and the full-body vibration caused by their purrs, Adora was incredibly happy, content.

Some time later Melog got up to stretch and left to, presumably, find another place to sleep. A memory had been tugging at the edge of Adora's mind for some time now, but she wasn't sure how Catra would react to her proposition:

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Catra's hand resumed brushing through her hair and Adora relaxed, her muscles turning to liquid under the attention from her
~~~

hand, "alright, I wont pry." Closing her eyes momentarily to enjoy the moment Adora lifted her own out of pure curiosity, Catra's mane was a mystery to her. The locks highlighted in the dull light of Catra's eyes. Her hair was rough, but at the same time it felt soft, not so much unkempt as it was maintained but otherwise left alone. Sinking her fingers in to massage Catra's scalp lightly she went to brush her fingers through, but her fingers didn't move a millimetre in the matted locks. "Heh, probably should have warned you about that, I don't think I have ever brushed my hair, no one has really cared enough to try. . ." as if a switch had flipped at her comment Catra's face fell and she retreated from Adora's embrace, sitting up and bringing her knees up to her chest, wrapping her arms around them tightly. The position seemed to bring her comfort as every time she had gotten upset around Adora she assumed this position and squeezed her eyes shut, her arms mirroring the action around her legs, squeezing so much that she heard a joint pop.

~~~

"Hey, Catra. . ." sliding her fingers into Catra's mane she pulled softly to rouse her.

"Hmm?"

"I have an idea. . ."

"Hmm?" she must've piqued her interest because Catra opened an eye lazily to focus on Adora's.
~~~

“Could I maybe. . . brush your hair?”

***

She was angry, but it was different than normal, this wasn’t pure and hateful rather she *wanted* to be Melog in this moment and she hated him for the attention he was receiving from Adora. “Melog really is soft. . . in an odd, hairless sort of way,” they were sat in a soft, sunny patch of grass and Adora was stroking a very content Melog who had splayed himself over her lap.

“He sure is.” Scoffing she flicked her tail before looking away to chew on her lip, she knew she was acting like a child, but she couldn’t help it. Whipping her head back she glared at the hand stroking her friend, her head itched.

She could *feel* Adora’s stare, but she couldn’t bring herself to meet it rather she huffed and collapsed onto the ground hoping to forget just how much her body ached to be stroked by Adora. “Catra, are-are you jealous of Melog.”

Her fur pricked along her spine as her pride took a huge blow, “what? No! What would I be jealous of?” she’d been caught, *shit*. She felt a hot blush rush up to her cheeks before she could hide her face.

“Do you want me to stroke you?” Adora’s tone was light, innocent even, but the proposition was anything but innocent.

“W-what do you mean by *that?*”

“Oh, nothing nefarious. Just what I said; would you like me to *stroke* you?” *Yeah, right. . .*

Despite her every instinct fighting against her, telling her to run. What she was about to do was a dangerous thing, she would be exposed, more exposed than she had ever been before. Yet, despite herself she began to move, crawling over to Adora and demanding attention from the surprised woman, “lift your arm.”

“Of course, my lady,” the pet name irked her, but she decided that she would get her back for that later, right now she was willing to let nearly anything slip so long as she got the anticipated attention. Before letting herself go completely she allowed one last glance toward the sleeping duo before collapsing between Melog and Adora settling quickly, melting into the curve of Adora’s torso. She allowed Adora exactly 10 seconds of surprise before snatching the hand hovering tauntingly above her and placing it on her cheek.

They sat like that for a long time, Adora stroking down Catra’s side, cheek to hip, occasionally altering her course to massage Catra’s scalp lightly before returning to her cheek and Catra in a state of mild euphoria at the new, pleasant, *terrifying* feelings coursed through her. She was mildly aware of Melog wandering away, grumbling in her head about being heavy, but she was too

blissed out to care, “hey, Catra. . .” she felt a hand pass over her scalp, pulling on her conscious.

“Hmm?”

“I have an idea. . .”

“Hmm?” the excitement in Adora’s tone was enough to force one if her eyes open to lightly focus on the woman.

“Could I maybe. . . brush your hair?”

What? “Um, why would you want to do that?”

“I-um, well, I just really want to. . .” she watched as a hot blush coloured Adora’s cheeks, her eyes avoiding Catra’s. “I’m sorry, you don’t have to if you don’t- “Catra cut off her rambling placing a finger on her lips.

“I’m not exactly saying no, I’m just surprised you want to try?”

Adora’s head cocked thoughtfully, thinking. Dropping her hand to pick at the grass before her, she allowed Adora to sort through her thoughts, “your hair, its. . . hard to explain, its mesmerising. I

can't help but *want* to brush it, and I can assure you I am an expert hair brusher – just ask Kamila."

Tilting her head, she studied Adora. . . she seemed sincere enough, and there was an underlying curiosity in her gaze as her eyes darted between her hair and eyes, almost as if she couldn't quite bring herself to tear her attention from the hand still massaging Catra's skull. "Alright, fine, but I can leave at any time. Ok?"

"Agreed. If you are feeling uncomfortable, or even just want to stop just tell me, or tap my wrist twice, ok?"

"Ok. . . so, where is this brush, do I need to get up for this?" she watched Adora menacingly; she *really* didn't want to get up.

"Nope. . ." a smile graced her lips before a blinding light burst from her palm leaving as quick as it came, leaving in its place a white hairbrush with odd, swirling blue highlights and golden bristles, "I have one right here. Can you sit up for a second?"

Sitting up Catra watched as the girl shifted to rest her back on a tree before patting her lap, beckoning Catra over. *Ah hell, we've gotten this far, might as well.* At that thought Catra crawled over placing her arms across Adora's thighs and resting her head, curling the rest of her body until her knees all the way to her toes were flush against the other woman.

***

Adora watched as Catra curled into her lap purposefully leaving her mane on display, tapping her cheek she waited for Catra to open her eyes before placing her fingers on the edges of Catra's mask, "may I?" She watched the war of emotions cascade over Catra's face before her expression steeled and she nodded her permission. Gently lifting the mask free from Catra's ears she was careful not to react to the scar revealed across her forehead; she had so many questions, but she knew the answers would only hurt Catra, she had many scars of her own that she dared not think of for fear of falling down the rabbit hole.

Placing the mask to the side she grasped a tightly woven braid, working her fingers through the knots to free the twisted hair, she let her mind drift:

***

She looked over at Catra whose muscles drew taught beneath her skin, "do you want me to lay on top of the sheets? You don't seem very comfortable."

"N-no its fine. I was just. . . um. . . cold." She knew Catra was lying, but she didn't seem uncomfortable with the thought of Adora laying next to her, more so that the question itself was the source of her discomfort. Deciding not to prolong the moment she laid her self carefully beside Catra, keeping mind not to touch the woman; if Catra truly was feeling overwhelmed with the thought

of laying next to another person, Adora would wait for her to initiate contact as well.

They lay like that for a long time, she could almost believe that Catra had fallen asleep save for the fact that she continued to shift and twitch, and her breathing was uneven. "Why haven't you asked about my scars?"

The question had thrown her off, and she had laid there for a long time, frozen. Now that she thought on it, it was probably best that that had been her reaction, she was sure that Catra would have pulled away all the same at any reaction, but her lack thereof seemed to have at least saved Catra some embarrassment. . .

"I-I mean. . . I don't. . . nevermind." She felt Catra pull her legs up to her chest as her breathing went completely out of control.

"Catra. . . Catra. Listen to me, alright?" She waited for her eyes to open, the dull glow lighting up the space between them. "I don't ask about your scars because you don't ask about mine. I know you've seen them; I see it in your eyes. You already have the answer to your question, you just don't want to believe it." The indecision in the woman's eyes told her all she needed to know; she had known the answer to her questions, she just either needed help to see it, or didn't want to believe it. "May I touch you?"

"Yes. . ." it was only a whisper, but the longing in her tone had Adora shifting closer before wrapping her arms tightly around Catra.

They hadn't talked after that. They didn't need to.

***

Coming back to reality as the last braid came loose in her fingers, she gripped the handle of the brush before sectioning Catra's hair with her free hand hoping to make the process easier. When she was satisfied with her sectioning, she glanced at Catra's face, if her outburst days ago was anything to go by, this whole process was likely an uncomfortable one; it was obvious no one had cared about this woman before, she would often notice Catra observing her and Kamila with a look of wonder on her face, as if she were curious what a casual conversation looked like. But Catra looked relaxed, and her muscles had loosened while Adora had been sectioning her hair, and so she brought the brush to the end of the first section, making sure to hold above where she brushed so as not to pull on Catra's scalp.

A few hours later, Adora was nearly half way through Catra's mane when Kamila and Swift Wind began to stir beside them, without pausing in her strokes she signaled to Swift Wind to stay quiet. This, though, didn't work as Catra tensed in her lap almost as soon as the two began to sneak off to the ship. Detangling her free hand from the section she'd been working on she placed it on Catra's cheek, "its alright Catra, they're just leaving.

***

She was hovering on the line between sleep and consciousness, she'd never felt so at ease as she did in this moment, Adora's forearm was rested near her ear and she could feel the light tug of the brush as Adora worked through her mane. When she heard a noise, she was almost tempted to ignore it. . . *almost*. . . perking her ear so she wouldn't miss any noise approaching her she tensed, ready for a fight. When a hand landed on her cheek she jumped slightly before hearing Adora speak to her softly, "its alright Catra, they're just leaving." She stayed alert until she heard the second set of footsteps enter the ship, then let herself relax again."

~~~ *some hours later* ~~~

"Hey, Catra. . . is it alright if I brush your scalp now?"

"Mmh, uh-sure?"

"There's going to be some tugs and a lot of stimulation, just remember, two taps on the wrist, ok?"

"Sure thing, Princess."

~~~ *some time later* ~~~

Adora had been right, they'd had to pause multiple times as Catra got overwhelmed by the sensation of the brush on her scalp, but

now she lay again, content while Adora continued to run the brush through her hair for no other reason than to brush her hair, and Catra decided, that she liked having her hair brushed. By Adora.

"Addy! Addy! Can we train now? It's been *forever*!" *Great, the kid just had to ruin it.* Stretching out her body, Catra used Adora's legs for support to roll onto her back and look over at the woman.

"Well, guess that's the end of that, huh?"

Adora laughed before handing Catra a hair tie, "you may want to tie up your hair, it kinda. . . poofed?"

Check out the comic I drew for this dialog!!!

Running her fingers through her hair that was easily 3 times the size it had been that morning, Catra sent a glare to Adora, "you better be able to fix this, Princess." Sitting up she handed the elastic back to Adora, "could you?"

"There is a stream not far from here, we can soak your hair there, it should help control it." She could hear the giggle in her tone as she turned away, allowing Adora to scrape her newly minted afro into a knot at the back of her head. "There. Perfect."

Scoffing Catra stood to face the kid, “alright kid, lets test your agility.”

“Go easy on her, Catra.”

“Who, me?” Adora sent a half-hearted glare to her as she moved to the side to allow Catra and Kamila room to spar. Snorting at the look she beckoned Kamila, who looked a little weary, to attack, “c’mon kid, I don’t bite. . .”

***

“Uh, Adora. . . that’s a lot of stray magic. . .”

“I know, I know. Kam? I need you to release your magic alright, we can try again in a minute- “a stray blast whizzed past Adora’s eyes, right into a. . . *person*? Not far from where they were, there was a man strolling into the path of the magical blast, “hey! Watch out!”

***

“Hey! Watch out!” Glimmer glanced up when she heard the cry just in time to see a blast of magical energy hit Bow in the shoulder.

“Bow!” Rushing over to him she saw that he was out cold, but breathing, *thankfully*. . . she spared that one final thought before letting her anger take over, whipping her head up to see a person rushing towards them. Their mouth was moving, but Glimmer couldn’t hear them as she launched herself at the person, lashing out with her magic, “you. Hurt. My. Friend.” She punctuated each word with a blast of magical energy that knocked the woman back into the clearing, but somehow didn’t scathe her in the least. Leaving that thought for another time, Glimmer assessed the others in the clearing, a large horse, a cat-like creature, a young child, a short woman, and the taller woman she had blasted.

Muttering an incantation to search for the source of the magical energy she moved her hands to form the spell. When it zoned in on the child she took a step forward, then hesitated, she was just a child.

***

Rushing over to the downed man, she saw the woman leaning over him look up at her, rage blazing in her eyes before she rushed at Adora, “hey, is your friend alright? He was hit by some stray magic.” The woman either didn’t hear her, or was too angry to process her words because a flurry of magical blasts were thrown at Adora.

“You. Hurt. My. Friend.” Stumbling back into the clearing, she put a hand out to stop Catra from attacking.

“She’s just angry, Catra. Her friend was hurt.”

“No, shit. But look at the look she’s giving the kid. That was a sorceress’s incantation, she knows it was her magic, Adora.”

“Shit.” Catra was right, the woman was glaring straight at Kam, when she took a step though, Adora rushed in front to confront her while Catra stepped in front of Kam. “Hey. Your problem is with me. It was not her fault – oof, “a magical blast hit her square in her chest. She-Ra was rising to the surface, and it was getting difficult to hold her back, but this wasn’t the time, she needed to calm the woman down. Grabbing the hand that had punched her she tried again, “miss, can you please listen? I can heal your friend if you would just calm down.” When her hand began to glow, and the other lifted to hit her in the ribs she felt She-Ra take over as her vision sharpened and her limbs lengthened, her voice came of its own accord as she adjusted to the change, “*stop.*”

And she did. The woman froze mid-throw, her fists still glowing as her jaw dropped, “*She-Ra?*”

“Uh-yes, can you please let go?”

“Uh-sure. . . um.”

“If you’re done attacking, I can help your friend.”

Rather than answering, the woman huffed before hurrying back to her unconscious friend. When they made it to him, she dropped to her knees before placing his head tenderly in her lap, her face worried. “Will he be alright? Will you heal him?”

Placing her hand on his burned shoulder, Adora felt the depth of the wound, “yes, and yes. The wound is minor, just got the wind knocked out of him. He should wake up just as soon as I heal this up.” Closing her eyes, she pooled her magic deep within herself before allowing it to take form in the palms of her hands, pushing the energy out over the wound, feeling it mend.

As she let her magic fade, she heard the man cough before she de-transformed and stood, the woman spared her a sheepish look, “um, thank you. And, I’m sorry. . . for attacking you I mean.”

“No hard feelings, feel free to join us if you’d like, I’m sure everyone’s hungry.” Heading back to check on Kam and the others she heard the two begin to murmur. “Hey, Catra, how’s she doing?

Catra looked up at her, “she’s a little groggy but otherwise healthy.” She glanced at the two huddle together before locking gazes with Adora again, “so, are they just gonna sit there and talk about you all day or did you invite them over?”

“I invited them over, think you could go for lunch?”

“Sure, I could eat. Let’s go kid.”

Watching as Catra helped Kam to her feet and kept an arm around her shoulders to steady her, she couldn’t help but smile. They really had come a long way. Hearing footsteps behind her she turned to see the two heading over sheepishly, beckoning them to follow her she headed up the ramp and into her ship.

Chapter End Notes

Everyone say hi to Glimbow!!!
Hoping to get some story progression in the next few chapters - I've kinda gone completely off my original plan, but I think the story is shaping up despite this!!

The Queen and Her Archer

Chapter Summary

So much fluff and denial, so, so much.

Will Adora join the Rebellion? What will Catra do if she does?

Chapter Notes

Alright everyone, we're back for the next update! This one took forever to write/edit - hope you all enjoy!

Alright, some warnings - please be aware, this chapter contains: swearing (not too much), mentioned abuse, descriptions of scars, and mention of past violence. If any of these things are triggering for you, please refrain from reading or take the necessary measures to prepare yourself to read about them.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Shit." Catra was right, the woman was glaring straight at Kam, when she took a step though, Adora rushed in front to confront her while Catra stepped in front of Kam. "Hey. Your problem is with me. It was not her fault – oof, "a magical blast hit her square in her chest. She-Ra was rising to the surface, and it was getting difficult to hold her back, but this wasn't the time, she needed to calm the woman down. Grabbing the hand that had punched her she tried again, "miss, can you please listen? I can heal your friend if you would just calm down." When her hand began to glow, and the other lifted to hit her in the ribs she felt She-Ra take over as her vision sharpened and her limbs lengthened, her voice came of its own accord as she adjusted to the change, "stop."

And she did. The woman froze mid-throw, her fists still glowing as her jaw dropped, "She-Ra?"

"Uh-yes, can you please let go?"

"Uh-sure. . . um."

"If you're done attacking, I can help your friend."

Rather than answering, the woman huffed before hurrying back to her unconscious friend. When they made it to him, she dropped to her knees before placing his head tenderly in her lap, her face worried. "Will he be alright? Will you heal him?"

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As she let her magic fade, she heard the man cough before she de-transformed and stood, the woman spared her a sheepish look, "um, thank you. And I'm sorry. . . for attacking you I mean."

~~~
~~~

“Glimmer?”

“Bow! Are you feeling ok?”

“Weirdly. . . yes. My shoulder is sore, but tingly; kinda like right before you teleport. . .” he moved his shoulder around while sitting up, “so. . . are you gonna tell me what happened? All I can remember is getting hit by a ball of magic.”

“Well. . . um. . .” scratching the back of her head Glimmer glanced up at the strange woman that had de-transformed and left them to talk, “well, long story short, a child lost control of their magic, it hit you, I went on a rampage and attacked She-Ra, then she healed you and is standing over there.” Ending her rant, she finally took a breath, flinging her hand out to point at the clearing where the two women were now talking.

“Uh. . .” Bow gave her a *very* concerned look, “She-Ra? As in *Legendary* Princess of Power, She-Ra? Isn’t she just a legend your mum used to tell us about when we got scared?”

“I thought so too! But she had the sword and the hair and the height! Bow. . . she was like 8 feet tall!”

“so, are they just gonna sit there and talk about you all day or did you invite them over?” The snarky comment was from the shorter

woman who had raised her voice, letting them know they were being rude. . . and loud.

They both looked over to the clearing, "I guess we were being a lot louder than I thought. . ." she let out an awkward laugh, glancing at Bow.

"Glimmer. . . c'mon, you were practically yelling. You got *way* too excited about She-Ra. . . you do realize that the blonde is clearly *not* 8 feet tall, glowing, or even wielding a sword, right? I mean, that dagger is super cool, but clearly not the Sword of Protection from the murals. . ."

Glaring at him she stood, punching his 'good' arm, "I *know* that Bow! She transformed *into* She-Ra! And, I didn't see the sword; I think she was trying not to hurt me? She didn't look to pleased when she finally transformed. . . I don't remember exactly what she said-"

"You mean you weren't listening and just ran in and picked a fight with the first person you saw?"

Clucking her tongue at his knowing smirk she continued, "*I don't remember exactly what she said*, but she definitely wasn't fighting back until the very end."

"Ok, you're not making any sense at all, but I'm going to go ahead and give you the benefit of the doubt cause you've never

lied to me before, but I distinctly remember Angella saying that She-Ra was She-Ra, not another person who *transformed into* She-Ra. . .”

“Ugh, I *know* Bow! I just-huh, whatever, lets go. She invited us to lunch.”

“Yay! Food!” sighing in defeat she crossed into the clearing.

***

Waving the two over Adora turned to board her ship, heading to the kitchen. Opening the hatch she began the introductions, “so, I’m Adora, the child is Kamila, and this is-“

“Holy shit, that’s the Queen!” Catra cut her off, her mouth hanging open.

“I’m sorry, the *what*?”

“Remember the Princesses I was telling you about? Well, she is one of the strongest after her mother, and just so happens to be the Queen of Etheria.”

“Oh, uhm. . . interesting. . .” she jogged over to Catra to whisper, “I don’t know the Royal customs of this planet; I didn’t even know there was a monarch.”

Catra snorted, “oh Princess, you are weird. Who talks like that?”

“Hey!”

“I don’t *do* royal customs, honestly, I try to break as many rules as possible, cause catastrophe for all those in power. S’just how I am. Hey Sparkles, Arrow Boy, remember me?”

***

Following the woman onto her ship, they walked in silence until she hit a control pad and a door opened, “so, I’m Adora, the child is Kamila, and this is-“

“Holy shit, that’s the Queen!” The outburst brought all eyes to the short woman, who now that Glimmer was looking seemed. . . familiar. Her cat-like features pulling on a memory that she couldn’t *quite* remember.

“I’m sorry, the *what*?”

“Remember the Princesses I was telling you about? Well, she is one of the strongest after her mother, and just so happens to be the Queen of Etheria.”

“Oh, uhm. . . interesting. . .” She-Ra, or rather, Adora jogged over to whisper with the woman, presumably to ask about Glimmer.

The woman snorted before answering, “oh Princess, you are weird. Who talks like that?”

“Hey!”

“I don’t *do* royal customs, honestly, I try to break as many rules as possible, cause catastrophe for all those in power. S’just how I am. Hey Sparkles, Arrow Boy, remember me?”

Wait. . . she *knew* that voice, laced with sarcasm and barbs, and she called her Sparkles, only one person had ever called her that. . . “wait, Catra?”

“What’s up, *Princess*?”

Brushing off the veiled insult she tried to piece together what had happen all those years ago, “I thought you were dead! Didn’t Shadow Weaver catch you a few years ago?”

Catra visibly cringed before a dark look fell on her features, glaring at her and Bow, "Shadow Weaver is *weak*, there's no way she will *ever* control me again. Never mention that witch to me again." *Alright, so the subject was still raw.*

Glancing at Adora she noticed the concern – no underlying contempt for speaking ill of another, no negative reaction to the fact that she was yelling at a Queen even though she seemed highly concerned about the royal customs upon learning of Glimmers Royal title, she just seemed genuinely concerned about Catra - directed at Catra, and the way her hand lifted to gently rest on the woman's shoulder. She noticed the way Catra's shoulders loosened ever so slightly at the contact, as if Adora's presence alone calmed her rage. Neither if the women seemed to notice the gesture. . . odd indeed; what exactly was the nature of their relationship?

***

Glancing back at Catra, Adora noticed that the hair on her nape and tail had risen and she was stiff as a board, her fingers twitched; she wanted to touch her, calm her down. . . but how would Catra react? She had been receptive of her friendship thus far, but she was clearly not comfortable around the Queen and the Archer, despite her feigned familiarity with the two by using nick names. Lifting her hand she placed it lightly on Catra's shoulder, enough to let her know she was there, but also light enough that Catra could shrug her off; she didn't, "alright! Now that we've established that, Ill finish the introductions?" When no protest came, Adora clapped her hands together before gesturing to each person in turn as she introduced them, "as you already know, this is Catra, over here is Kamila and Swift Wind. And hiding somewhere around here is Melog."

“Dear gods, he’s *huge*!”

“Bow!” The Queen look mortified at his reaction.

“What? He is!”

“Maybe, but you don’t have to-“ finally looking at Swift Wind her eyes widened even more and her jaw fell slack, “he *is* huge!”

“Right?”

Swift Wind scoffed, “Hey, don’t talk about me like I’m not here!”

An inhuman noise came out of the Archer, “That horse can *talk?!*”

“Uh-heh, I. . . can’t explain that one, but weirdly, not the most bizarre thing that’s happened today.” The Queen looked bemused before pinching the top of her nose.

“Yes, I can talk, you have exactly 10 seconds to freak out.”

“Swifty! Be nice.” Adora scolded him while Kamila continued to stare at the Queen, and Catra stood stock still.

“What, that *was* nice!”

Sighing, Adora walked over to Catra, “hey, are you alright?”

Catra cleared her throat, but her voice came out strained, “yeah, just bad memories. Go on and socialize,” she looked up to catch Adora’s gaze, giving her a weak smirk, “I know you want to.” She obviously wasn’t ok, but Adora knew enough to know that she didn’t want to talk about her past, especially with the two newcomers who seemed to take some kind of role in it.

Giving her one last once over before nodding she headed over to stand by the Queen who was watching her friend fawn over Swift Wind who seemed more than pleased with himself at the praise he was receiving, “hi.”

“Hi. Sorry about earlier, I don’t always think things through.”

“No problem at all, no one was hurt. . . too badly, your Majesty. . .?”

“Haha, no need for formality, my name is Glimmer. Nice to meet you, Adora.”

“You too. . . Glimmer-”

Before she could say another word, Catra cut her off, “alright, foods ready.”

~~~ after lunch ~~~

“So. . . can I ask you a question, Adora?” Adora glanced over at the Queen who had been sneaking glances at her for the entire meal, she’d known this was coming.

“You want to know if I am the same She-Ra, Legendary Princess of Power from your planets legends?”

“Uh-yes?”

“In short, yes. Though I am not the same She-Ra from your legends, I am the *current* host of She-Ra’s magic.”

“Ah, ok. I do have another question though. . . would you be willing to join the rebellion?” Catra’s head snapped up from where she had been staring a hole through the floor, her gaze now focused intently on Adora. “Don’t get me wrong, I don’t know who you are and I don’t know if I can trust you. . . but, the only way I can see the rebellion facing the Horde with any sort of success is with the help of Etheria’s legendary hero.”

She looked over at Catra, their eyes locking briefly, but Adora couldn't see what she was thinking. Her face was completely impassive. "From what I've heard, there isn't much of a rebellion left. If it wouldn't offend, may I ask what your plan for me is?"

"Well, I don't have a solid plan really, I was thinking more along the lines of taking you to meet my mother. While she can no longer be the Queen, she is still my head advisor and extremely familiar with the history of She-Ra. And please, I don't really think of myself as the 'Queen,' I'm just another Etherian, you don't need to be formal with me."

"Yeah! Go ahead and offend her, I do it constantly." The Archer spoke up, seemingly having been paying some attention to their conversation as he marveled over Swift Wind.

"Bow!" her head whipped to glare at him.

"What? I do," glancing between the two as they bantered, she realized just how close the two must be. Rather than her earlier assumption that he was simply a bodyguard, or possibly distantly related, the two did seem to know each other extremely well, much of their communication was silent through body language and gestures only they seem to understand.

Their banter was concluded when she cuffed the Archer on the side of the head, "go back to marveling at the horse, Bow! The grown ups are talking."

“Oooh, sick burn, Glim.” At her fierce glare he lifted his hands in defeat, “fine, fine. Ill leave you to it.”

Suddenly the Queen was facing her again, “sorry about that! Anyways, as I was saying, I want to take you to see my mother, would you be willing?”

“While I’m not saying an outright denial, I am going to have to hold off on any more travel until Kamila is safely back in Ardglass, where we were planning to return to tomorrow.” She glanced at Catra, “there is also the matter of your knowing where my ship is located; can I get your word that you will not send any soldiers here once I am gone?”

“Why would you want that?”

“I don’t presume to know her motives, but Catra has chosen not to align with the Horde or the Rebellion and I can no longer guarantee her safety on my ship if you do not promise me this.”

The Queen glanced at Catra, her expression didn’t change but her eyes grew confused, “will Catra not follow you?”

“That is her choice. She is welcome to do as she likes.” Glancing at Catra she caught the unguarded surprise cross her expression before it fell flat once again.

“Sorry, Sparkles. I can’t stand people who think they own me; can’t imagine the people of Brightmoon just accepting me. S’just easier to avoid everyone.” Grunting Catra stood picking up hers and Kamila’s empty plates.

“Catra. . .”

“Don’t, you know I’m right. Your people would never trust anyone from the Horde, and that’s exactly what they see me as, an enemy. I fight off just as many Rebellion soldiers as I do Horde soldiers.”

At that Catra placed the plates in the sink before disappearing from the room. “She’s right, y’know.” They all looked at Bow who had apparently finished gushing over Swift Wind and was now looking at them grimly. “They would never say it around you, Glim, but I’ve heard some guards and other rebels boasting about fighting Shadow Weavers daughter. One was even a party where they were regaling about all the times they were able to get a blow in on her; some where really gruesome.”

“What! Who?”

Standing, Adora left them to their conversation before wandering, seeking out Catra. If what Bow was saying was a fact, then she really would have more to think about before considering assisting the Rebellion. She knew that even the ‘good guys’ where never truly good, but what the Archer confided was downright cruelty, especially since he had most definitely only recited the watered-down version to spare his Queen the details.

Walking down the corridor she idly checked each nook and cranny where shed seen Catra wedge herself in the past week. Nothing. As she came to the end of the hall where her barracks were located she gently knocked on the door, "Catra? Are you in here?"

Silence

Not holding out much hope Adora pushed the door open and looked around the room, nothing appeared to be out of the ordinary. . . save for the lump under the covers of her pallet. Cocking her head she walked over to the pile of comforters, "Catra. . . is that you under there?"

". . . no."

Gently lifting the edge of the blanket Adora caught Catra's troubled gaze, "won't you join me on the bed? It is much more comfortable than my pallet."

"But. . . the bed doesn't smell like you. . ."

***

". . . would you be willing to join the rebellion?" Catra's body stiffened instinctually as she whipped her head up to see Adora's

reaction; she wasn't really sure what she wanted the answer to be. Yes, she hated the Horde and desperately wanted them, specifically Shadow Weaver, taken down, but she had been attacked with just as much, if not more malice by Rebel soldiers than with Horde soldiers. The main difference being; Horde soldiers were ordered to take her in, using as much force as needed. The Rebels attacked her simply because she was raised in the Horde. The only time she had ever felt truly safe, accepted, was here on this ship. "Don't get me wrong, I don't know who you are and I don't know if I can trust you. . . but, the only way I can see the rebellion facing the Horde with any sort of success is with the help of Etheria's legendary hero."

Adora's eyes met her own and she kept her expression blank, she would not be an influence in this decision; it was simply not her place. Seemingly realizing this point, Adora turned back to Sparkles, her tone formal, "from what I've heard, there isn't much of a rebellion left. If it wouldn't offend, may I ask what your plan for me is?"

"Well, I don't have a solid plan really, I was thinking more along the lines of taking you to meet my mother. While she can no longer be the Queen, she is still my head advisor and extremely familiar with the history of She-Ra. And please, I don't really think of myself as the 'Queen,' I'm just another Etherian, you don't need to be formal with me."

"Yeah! Go ahead and offend her, I do it constantly." Arrow boy spoke up, tirning away from the horse for the first time since meeting him.

"Bow!" Sparkles sent him an annoyed look.

“What? I do,” when they started going back and forth she stood up to start getting the food ready; the sooner everyone was fed, the sooner she could slip away.

She heard a smack, then Sparkles smug voice, “go back to marveling at the horse, Bow! The grown ups are talking.”

“Oooh, sick burn, Glim. . . fine, fine. Ill leave you to it.”

Sorry about that! Anyways, as I was saying, I want to take you to see my mother, would you be willing?”

“While I’m not saying an outright denial, I am going to have to hold off on any more travel until Kamila is safely back in Ardglass, where we were planning to return to tomorrow.” Adora glanced back to her, their eyes locking a moment before returning to the Queens, “there is also the matter of your knowing where my ship is located; can I get your word that you will not send any soldiers here once I am gone?”

Her eyes widened in surprise, she hadn’t expected Adora to go so far as to *request* something from the Queen *for her*; though at this point, she was starting to get used to the generosity. . . Starting to.

The question also looked to catch the Queen completely off guard, her eyes widened, “why would you want that?”

“I don’t presume to know her motives, but Catra has chosen not to align with the Horde or the rebellion and I can no longer guarantee her safety on my ship if you do not promise me this.” If Adora’s request hadn’t surprised Catra before, this certainly would have. Even though they had had many discussions, they were still virtual strangers. Catra was not a ‘good person’ as many people put it, she was simply a person who lived on the planet; not aligning with the Horde, but also not associating with the Rebellion. She simply didn’t care; she was going to live her life on her own terms; she would never again be at the mercy of another. *Never*. But most surprising to her was the fact that Adora seemed to grasp this concept completely, not showing any contempt over the fact that Catra was not aligned with the ‘good guys’, rather she just accepted Catra for what and who she was.

The Queen glanced at Catra, her expression didn’t change but her eyes grew confused, “will Catra not follow you?”

Before she could tell the Queen exactly where she could shove *that* notion, Adora spoke up again, “that is her choice. She is welcome to do as she likes.” Her jaw dropped before she could catch herself, her eyes going soft when Adora caught them once again. But only for a moment. Catra would never again be caught vulnerable in a room with strangers. Especially the strangers she was currently in the company of.

She dropped all emotion from her voice before she cleared her throat, ripping her gaze from Adora’s to look at the Queen menacingly. “Sorry, Sparkles. I can’t stand people who think they

own me; can't imagine the people of Brightmoon just accepting me. S'just easier to avoid everyone." She stood, grabbing hers and the kids' plates, ending the conversation.

Or so she thought, "Catra. . ."

Hissing she whipped her head to glare at the Queen, "don't, you know I'm right. Your people would never trust anyone from the Horde, and that's exactly what they see me as, an enemy. I fight off just as many Rebellion soldiers as I do Horde soldiers."

Placing the plates in the sink she stormed out of the room, seething. With no particular destination in mind, just away from there; away from them, she wandered aimlessly in the ships corridors. Before she was out of earshot she heard Arrow boy whisper to the others, "she's right, y'know."

Punching the controls to open the door to Adora's barracks she stormed into the room, stopping in the middle, her breathing heavy. Glancing over to the bed, she took a step before her eyes caught the pile of comforters Adora had slept on for *most* of the night. . . she looked back at the bed then made her decision. Turning on her heel she switched direction heading for the comforters and diving underneath, burying her face into the pillow and breathing deep.

Her mind filled with Adora, her intoxicating scent. Catra's muscles relaxed, but *only* because she had finally stretched out. It had absolutely *nothing* to do with Adora. *Nothing*.

She stayed like that for a long time, not quite relaxed, but safely refraining from re-living the memories of the last 12 years. A soft rapping came from the door – *Adora!* Her ears *did not* perk, and her heart *did not* flutter.

"Catra? Are you in here?"

As much as she wanted to answer she would *not* allow herself to. *She would not become dependant on another person. Ever.* And so, she clamped her jaw and curled into a ball under the covers.

The door opened and soft footfalls came in, then stopped, as if she were searching the room. Catra stayed silent, held her breath, hoping that by some miracle Adora wouldn't see her and she wouldn't have to talk about it. "Catra. . . is that you under there?"

Shit. ". . . no."

Adora walked over to her, then lifted the edge of the blanket that was covering her face and held her eyes for what felt like forever before glancing at the bed, "won't you join me on the bed? It is much more comfortable than my pallet."

Double shit, there really wasn't any normal excuse for her to be here rather than the bed. *The truth it is, I guess.* "But. . . the bed doesn't smell like you. . ."

“Oh!” Adora’s eyes widened, “um, you can lay your head by me if you’d like? I would just like to sit with you and that’s not really possible here.”

“Fine.” Adora held a passive hand to her and she debated, *hard*. Taking her hand wouldn’t be the same as relying on another person, it was just polite. She wasn’t considering it only to have an excuse to touch Adora’s soft, warm hand. No. There was a logical reason for what she was about to do. Placing her hand in Adora’s she allowed her to lift them up before walking over to settle on the edge of the bed.

***

When Catra made no move to get closer, Adora tapped her shoulder in invitation. She didn’t know anything about Catra’s species, maybe another person’s scent soothed them? It likely had nothing to do with Adora herself. . . she just wished the fluttering in her heart would calm. “I don’t presume you want to talk about it, and I don’t want you to if you are uncomfortable. I am happy to just sit in silence. I always found that after a hard mission, having another person with me always helped a little, even if I didn’t tell them what was going on. Simply leaning on another can help to no end.”

“. . . thank you.”

“Of course.”

~~~ some time later ~~~

"Hey, Adora?"

"Yes?" Adora kept her voice low, they had been sitting in silence for some time now, but in the last few minutes Catra had been fidgeting, working herself up to asking a, presumably, uncomfortable question.

"Earlier you mentioned a stream I could soak my hair in? Do you think we could do that now? My hair is giving me a headache, its too heavy all bunched up."

"Yes, of course. Give me a moment to grab some product left by my aunt; she had curly hair. It should help yours as well."

~~~ At the stream ~~~

"So, now that I think about it, maybe not. . ."

Glancing over at Catra, she noticed that she seemed extremely uncomfortable as she watched the stream flow, "whys that?"

“I uhm. . . I. . . don’t like water. I thought the stream would be a lot smaller and I could just dip my hair in. . .”

“I mean. . . we can try to just get your head in, but you’d have to rely on me completely and I know you don’t want that.”

“Yeah. . .”

“Here, ill go in first, how about that?”

“. . .ok.”

Taking off her shirt and pants she tried to ignore Catra’s stare, a light blush heating her cheeks. Stepping into the stream, she was pleasantly surprised, it was significantly warmer than when she had last used it, “its actually quite nice today; not too cold.”

She watched as Catra hesitantly peeled off her armour plates and headpiece, placing them by Adora’s clothing pile, “are you sure no one is around.”

Accessing She-Ra’s Hearing and sight Adora looked around, searching for any sign of life. “There is a family of rabbits about 150 metres that way, nothing else significant save for the ship about half a kilometre away.” Letting her magic fade she blinked before looking back to Catra. Who had begun to strip off her bodice. Quickly turning away, Adora dunked herself completely

under the water, it had been a while since she herself had bathed. . . Kamila too now that she thought on it. Pushing up she pulled her head back above the surface of the water in time to hear a soft hiss.

Turning, she saw Catra dipping her toe into the stream, “C’mon, its not that bad, is it?”

“. . . no.”

A slight crack caught their attention as the softened edge of the stream began to crumble under Catra’s weight, Adora rushed over, instinct taking over she grabbed Catra around the waist so she was standing in the stream rather than landing on her ass. Catra on the other hand also seemed to react on pure instinct, one hand grabbing Adora’s wrist, the other her shoulder, nails digging in hard enough to draw blood. “Catra,” she tried to keep her tone soothing as not to startle Catra further, “do you want me to take you out of the water?”

Catra’s eyes darted up to meet hers before her nails retracted and she pulled Adora tightly against her, “n-no. . . just need a second to breathe.” Catra dug her nose into the crook of Adora’s neck and tightened her arms even more.

A dull ache started in her shoulder and wrist, but she knew the wounds were shallow and would heal quickly so she paid them no mind as she held the trembling woman, stroking her spine softly.

*** Check out some art I made for this scene! ***

"I'm sorry," Catra's voice was muffled in her neck, but she continued, "I didn't mean to lose control, I just. . . water is one of the devices Shadow Weaver loved to use against me, 'nothing to clean up after' was her favourite saying back then."

"Its alright. Just a scratch." Doing her best to show no reaction to her confession, specifically no pity, she glanced down at a particularly old scar on Catra's back; a thin curved line puckered just above her tail. It could very well have been made by a blade or a claw, but also by water travelling at a high speed. . .

"I know you're lying. . . I can smell the blood."

Pulling back slightly she tapped Catra's cheekbone, "let me show you something," allowing She-Ra's healing magic to envelop her she felt the telltale burn as the wounds closed and her blood dissolved. When her magic faded Catra lifted her face from Adora's neck blinking, showing her her healed wrist Adora smiled softly. "Its really hard to hurt me, I'm used to pain, and I can heal most wounds."

Catra snorted, "fine, fine. . . thank you."

"So, how's the water now? Not too bad right?"

"Yeah. . ." letting go Catra knelt down and cut the tie from her hair. "So, what where those bottles you brought for?"

"Ah, Shampoo and Conditioner; one cleans your hair, the other moisturizes. . . I think. My hair is pretty manageable and I haven't ever needed this, but I've seen my aunt use them."

"Ok, you mind?"

Placing a hand on Catra's neck she dipped her head into the water, running her fingers through her hair, "alright, now bring your head back up." Squirting some of the shampoo into her hand Adora began massaging it onto Catra's scalp, they were silent for a long time but as Adora massaged, a light purr began to rumble in Catra's chest. Curious, her eyes flashed to Catra's ears, flicking slightly as the lather ran down past them, glancing back at Catra's face – her eyes were closed with an expression one *could* categorize as pleasure – she carefully passed semi-close to the base of her ear; no reaction. Trying again, this time she traced the outer edge carefully with her pinky, Catra's reaction was one she wasn't sure she was expecting. . .

~~~ *Back at the ship* ~~~

"Hey, Addy! Where've you been? I've been waiting *forever* to train." Jumping slightly when Kam appeared from behind the ship, Adora quickly dropped her hand from around Catra. Though she wasn't sure why she was embarrassed all of a sudden, she'd done this plenty of times in front of Kam; was this feeling somehow
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stemming from the fact that her display of affection was with Catra?

She had noticed that her interactions – aside from the kiss that first night, and the overnight cuddle sessions that had somehow become a regular occurrence – were somehow different than when she were to, say, put her arm around Mina or Tecla when they stopped by the bar. Her interactions with Catra often resulted in a light, airy feeling in her chest and her heart going a mile a minute; odd indeed, she just needed to figure out why. Perhaps she would ask Frieshia for advice upon returning to the village. . .

"Addy?" her train of thought interrupted she blinked, Kam and Catra were giving her an identical look; slight frown with a raised eyebrow.

"Sorry, Kam. We can train now if you'd like."

"Yes!"

Glancing at Catra she forced down a blush, clearing her throat, "did you-uhm, do you want to watch?" pulling on her shirts collar that had suddenly become too tight she smiled lightly trying to cover the awkward feeling.

"Uh-sure," returning her smile with one equally as awkward Catra sat back against a tree facing the 'training ring' as Swift Wind had dubbed it.

Turning she headed over to Kam to start their training, “so, what do you say to some more magical training? You’re still having a lot of trouble controlling your magic in its purest form.”

“Ok!”

“Now, you know what to do, show me what you’ve got.” She watched as the girl took a deep breath, focusing. Through She-Ra she could feel Kam pooling her magic, then pulling it up and into her hands, focusing it on the space between them. She heard footsteps as Swift Wind lead the Queen and the Archer out of the ship to watch their training. Not looking away, she continued to watch as a small sphere began to form between Kam’s palms; this was as far as she had ever gotten when trying to form a ‘crystal ball’ as Freja called it. It allowed the user to locate anyone they had ever used they’re magic on anywhere in the world, but as soon as Kam formed the ball she lost control, which is what had happened earlier when they had disturbed the Queen’s travels.

Just as she had thought, Kam’s magic began to de-stabilize and small blasts of magical energy began shooting from her hands. Placing her own over Kamila’s, Adora absorbed the magical energy, then allowed it to dissipate back into the woods. “You’re moving too slow, you know.” They looked over to the Queen who had spoken, “its almost as if you’re scared of completing the process. Your magic is similar to my incantations; if you work too slowly it’ll blow up in your face.” She walked over to them, “let me show you something, this spell is similar to the one you’re casting.”

***

Stepping back Glimmer began her incantation for a finder spell but purposefully casted it too slowly, and just as she assumed, the spell began to fall apart before her, "so, not quite the same, but I cast that way too cautiously and it fell apart; yours blows up, but it's the same concept." Lifting her hands once again she began the same spell but completed the incantation much faster. When an image of Bow came up she let the spell dissolve, "see how much faster and more confident I cast it that time? That's what you need to do."

"Ok, let me try again." Focusing, Kam pooled her magic, moved it to her hands, then formed the ball pushing her magic much faster than before. As the ball got bigger, a picture began to form and after a few seconds a clear image of Freja working could be seen. "Oh! Look I did it! Haha, Catra do you see this? I did it!"

"I see it kid, good job." Glancing over at Catra Glimmer noticed the small smile on her face. Now that she thought about it, the ever-present scowl she remembered always plastered on the woman's face hadn't made an appearance since they had come out to watch the training; peculiar, she'd have to keep an eye on that. What had changed in the few years since they had last seen Catra?

***

"I've gotta show mom! We're going home tomorrow, right?"

"Yes, we are. Now, disperse your magic just how I showed you, let it return to the planet, alright?" Smiling she watched as Kam bounced in excitement letting her magic disperse. When the ball faded she ran to the Queen, pulling her into a tight hug, then doing the same with Adora and Catra.

"I'm gonna go pack!" The girl disappeared into the ship, leaving them in an awkward silence.

"So, is it alright if we stay here the night? As long as you're still willing to come to Brightmoon to meet my mother, that is?" She saw the hope in Glimmers eyes at the prospect of the addition to her Rebellion, but she also noticed the subtle tightening in Catra's shoulders and how she turned away from the conversation opting instead to pick the grass at her hip.

She chose her words carefully, "I can't promise that I will *join* your Rebellion, but I am willing to meet your mother. If the planet is in the state you say, I am willing to fight the Horde." While her friends spoke very highly of the Rebellion, her loyalty remained her own and she did not give it freely. She was loyal to Base Grayskull because of her family. She was loyal to the town of Ardglass because the people had shown her love and friendship. She was loyal to Swift Wind because he had shown her unconditional loyalty in return.

She was loyal to Catra, and there was no simple reason for this loyalty; they were similar, both soldiers – brought up in opposite environments – their morals were the same. Further than that, she felt *connected* to Catra.

“Fair enough. Ill take what I can get. So, Bow and I will stay the night.”

“Would you like a room on the ship, or. . .?”

“No, no! We have all we need. We’ll just sleep out here. I love sleeping under the stars.”

“Very well. Just let me know if you change your mind.” Turning away from the Queen she collapsed next to Catra, laying her head on a patch of grass. “Hey. . .”

“Hey.”

“Can I ask you something?”

“Um, sure. What’s up, Princess?” Catra twisted to look down at her, confused.

“What do you think of the Rebellions purpose?”

Chapter End Notes

A cliffhanger once again, gotta keep everyone on their toes! What do you all think of the rebellion in this AU, with what

little information I've given?

Subscribe to get notified when updates come, or follow my Twitter @Samm_arts; I post a lot of fanart and 'sneak peaks' while I'm editing!

The Past Hurts

Chapter Summary

Fluff and denial, then fluff and partial(?) acceptance. . . . . then more fluff

Chapter Notes

This chapter didn't get nearly as much editing, so if there's a really obvious mistake, just let me know in the comments!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's eyes darted up to meet hers before her nails retracted and she pulled Adora tightly against her, "n-no. . . just need a second to breathe." Catra dug her nose into the crook of Adora's neck and tightened her arms even more.

A dull ache started in her shoulder and wrist, but she knew the wounds were shallow and would heal quickly so she paid them no mind as she held the trembling woman, stroking her spine softly.

"I'm sorry," Catra's voice was muffled in her neck, but she continued, "I didn't mean to lose control, I just. . . water is one of the devices Shadow Weaver loved to use against me, 'nothing to clean up after' was her favourite saying back then."

"Its alright. Just a scratch." Doing her best to show no reaction to her confession, specifically no pity, she glanced down at a particularly old scar on Catra's back; a thin curved line puckered just above her tail. It could very well have been made by a blade or a claw, but also by water travelling at a high speed. . .

“I know you’re lying. . . I can smell the blood.”

Pulling back slightly she tapped Catra’s cheekbone, “let me show you something,” allowing She-Ra’s healing magic to envelop her she felt the telltale burn as the wounds closed and her blood dissolved. When her magic faded Catra lifted her face from Adora’s neck blinking, showing her her healed wrist Adora smiled softly. “Its really hard to hurt me, I’m used to pain, and I can heal most wounds.”

Catra snorted, “fine, fine. . . thank you.”

“So, how’s the water now? Not too bad right?”

“Yeah. . .” letting go Catra knelt down and cut the tie from her hair. “So, what where those bottles you brought for?”

“Ah, Shampoo and Conditioner; one cleans your hair, the other moisturizes. . . I think. My hair is pretty manageable and I haven’t ever needed this, but I’ve seen my aunt use them.”

“Ok, you mind?”

Placing a hand on Catra’s neck she dipped her head into the water, running her fingers through her hair, “alright, now bring

your head back up." Squirting some of the shampoo into her hand Adora began massaging it onto Catra's scalp, they were silent for a long time but as Adora massaged, a light purr began to rumble in Catra's chest. Curious, her eyes flashed to Catra's ears, flicking slightly as the lather ran down past them, glancing back at Catra's face – her eyes were closed with an expression one could categorize as pleasure – she carefully passed semi-close to the base of her ear; no reaction. Trying again, this time she traced the outer edge carefully with her pinky, Catra's reaction was one she wasn't sure she was expecting. . .

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She felt Adora pull back and tap on her cheek, opening her eyes she squinted at her, "let me show you something." Adora gave her a small smile before she was engulfed in the odd blue light Catra now knew was She-Ra's magic. Tucking her face back into Adora's neck she tightened her arms, waiting for the light to fade. The magic radiating off Adora was almost warm, a tingling sensation forming where their bodies touched. It was. . . relaxing, oddly enough. Almost as if She-Ra were hugging her just as Adora was. Suddenly the warmth receded and Adora's fingers came back to her cheek, rousing her. Lifting her head she looked at Adora's, now healed, wrist, only the faintest indents in her flesh remained of Catra's outburst. Looking back to Adora's eyes, the faintest flicker of She-Ra swirled before she disappeared from Adora's gaze, she waited for an explanation. "It's really hard to hurt me, I'm used to pain, and I can heal most wounds."

Snorting she cocked an eyebrow, "fine, fine." She wasn't sure how to respond; how to voice the immense relief she was feeling. How could she tell someone that she was *relieved* she hadn't hurt them, she wasn't even sure she was able to process it herself. So,
~~~

instead of explaining she rubbed her cheek lightly on Adora's, ". . . thank you."

"So, how's the water now? Not too bad, right?"

Pulling back slightly she flexed her toes. Now that she had calmed down, the water wasn't so bad. . . it was actually kinda. . . nice. . . the stream flowed lazily around her calves, no pain radiating from the area in any form, just a soft comfort. "Yeah. . ." letting her arms drop from Adora's waist she stepped back before kneeling, letting the water flow around her waist languidly. *It. . . really isn't that bad.* Unsheathing her claws once again, she let the discomfort wash over her; she hadn't done that since she was a kitten, sheath her claws that is, she was surprised she'd even remembered how. She'd done it on pure instinct as soon as she'd heard the soft grunt of pain and the faint smell of blood from Adora. She could still feel the fear seizing her at the prospect of hurting the only person, save for Melog, to ever treat her, well, normal. That paralyzing fear had overridden the panic attack from falling into the stream, so much so that she had retracted her claws; her only effective weapons currently as all her blades were laying in a heap on the shore. . .

Snapping out of it she cut the tie in her hair. These feelings she was having, they needed to stop. They were too confusing. Adora was simply showing her kindness, there was no need to get attached. "So, what were those bottles you brought for?" looking

up at Adora she cocked her eyebrow again, wiping all emotion save for curiosity from her face.

"Ah, Shampoo and Conditioner." *What the hell are those?* "One cleans your hair, the other moisturizes. . . I think." *Oh,* "My hair is pretty manageable and I've never needed this, but I've seen my aunt use them." She hurried off to grab them from the grass.

Watching to make sure Adora was still turned away she lowered her hands into the water. She'd never dared to go near water since escaping the Horde, it was just too much, but now, now she was sitting in the middle of a calm stream watching, mesmerized, as the fine hair on her inner forearm floated around, flowing with the water. Cocking her head she turned her arm over revealing the large scar that covered it, bitter memories assailed her:

~~~ Fright Zone, Training exercise, 13 years old ~~~

"What do you think you're doing, Catra? You're late again!"

"Oh, can it, Lonnie. I'm here aren't I?" Catra stomped over to her locker, movements sluggish as she tried not to jostle the open wounds on her back.

"Uh-huh. Been missing a lot of training lately, another trip with Shadow Weaver huh?" She stayed silent; Lonnie would back off soon enough. She just had to make it through today. "Figures."

"C'mon, Lonnie. Just leave her be. We have to go."

--- Cadets to your stations, training exercise #185 will commence in 5 minutes. Cadets to your stations, training exercise #185 will commence in 5 minutes. ---

Slamming her locker, she hissed when her armored plates rubbed up on her cuts and bruises, "shit." Stalking out of the locker room she rushed to the simulation room where Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio stood awaiting instructions. Rushing to her place before they noticed she was late she immediately zoned out the Force Captain droning at them. Why did they have to do this every time, they always say the same thing. . .

Zoning back in as the room blacked out to signal the beginning of the simulation, she ran to the edge of the room to climb into the rafters. Watching intently as her 'teammates' battled the robots she looked for an opening.

The pain radiating from her back must have dulled her heightened senses greatly because she didn't hear the robot creeping in behind her until it grabbed her legs in attempt to pull her from the rafters, but her arms got caught up in the metal sheeting.

By the time they had shut down the simulation, both her arms and wrists had been broken. How did she know this? Well, she could see the jagged edges of her bones peeking out from the skin that had been peeled back as the robot pulled on her legs.

She had spent 6 months in recovery, the pinky on her right hand had never regained feeling; the nerve had been severed by the metal sheet. She now sported metal rods holding her bones together and 2 very large scars where they'd had to use skin grafts after setting her bones.

She had been in recovery for 6 months, then over a year of physical training before she was able to handle a weapon heavier than a feather without severe pain in her wrists. And for that year and a half she had only seen Shadow Weaver in passing, never speaking, never forced to go on a 'trip'. That year and a half of agony had been wonderful. Then she had recovered fully and was released from medical to be reintegrated into training with her original 'team', and the 'trips' had restarted as if nothing had happened.

~~~ Present time, Stream in the Whispering Woods ~~~

Jumping when the water was disturbed she whipped her head to see Adora re-entering the stream with the bottles of 'Shampoo' and 'Conditioner.' Taking her arm out of the water she wrapped it around her chest instead, "ok, you mind?" Her voice shook, but she chose to believe that Adora's feigned ignorance of it was real; she really didn't want to be pitied right now.

Rather than answering, Adora placed a hand on her neck, helping her lean back into the water getting her hair wet. "Alright, now bring your head up." Adora squeezed one of the bottles, a milky liquid fell into her hand, and once a substantial amount pooled into her palm she reached over to massage it into Catra's hair.

Closing her eyes she let the sensation of Adora's fingers on her scalp wash through her, it was pleasant, but also stroked a building feeling in her chest; though the feeling wasn't quite fear, her chest felt tight, but she didn't want to run, what she really wanted to do was purr and lean into Adora's touch. To turn her head and snuggle back into the crook of Adora's neck where her scent was strongest. She didn't even attempt to stifle the purr that rose in her chest, not that she could, she was just too relaxed. Suddenly a flash of pleasure flashed down her spine leaving her body buzzing, her purr stuttered as a strangled noise escaped from her throat. Opening her eyes, she tried to figure out what the hell had happened; her brain was at war with itself, on one hand she wasn't sure she wanted to feel that again, that feeling was. . . a lot. But, on the other hand, she wanted nothing more than to feel that overwhelming feeling again and again. . .

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Squirting some of the shampoo into her hand, Adora began massaging it onto Catra's scalp, they were silent for a long time but as Adora massaged, a light purr began to rumble in Catra's chest. Curious, her eyes flashed to Catra's ears, flicking slightly as the lather ran down past them, glancing back at Catra's face – her eyes were closed with an expression one *could* categorize as pleasure – she carefully passed semi-close to the base of her ear; no reaction. Trying again, this time she traced the outer edge carefully with her pinky, waiting, baited breath, for any sort of reaction.

Her purr faltered before a strangled noise erupted from her chest, surprised Adora's fingers halted on Catra's scalp when her eyes

flew open, catching her own, “Why’d you stop?” her voice was rough, a note that sent a shiver down Adora’s spine before she resumed massaging the soap into Catra’s hair, keeping their eyes locked.

Moving her fingers down to the base of Catra’s skull she worked away the tension, listening to Catra’s purr crescendo. Smiling to herself as she watched Catra’s muscles relax even more she continued to hold Catra’s gaze, her eyes glazed over as her eyelids drooped. The movement of Catra’s teeth piercing her lip caught her attention, she watched as a small bead of blood rolled along her lip.

“Catra. . .” leaning down she sucked Catra’s lip into her mouth, running her tongue along the blood trail, releasing her lip with a pop, she looked into Catra’s eyes again, “you need to be more careful, love.”

Catra’s hand trailed up her spine to snap her hair tie before fisting tightly in her hair, pulling her in and kissing her, “should I be?” *Kiss*, “why do you say that?” *Kiss*, “It had the desired effect, “ *kiss*, “ did it not?” *Kiss*.

Moving around so she was in front of Catra she placed her hands on each cheek, forcing eye contact, they needed to talk about this; she wasn’t sure what was happening, but she’d never felt this way before. This feeling, she couldn’t quite pin it down, she needed to discuss it, and at the moment, Catra was the only person around she could speak freely with on the subject. Kissing her once more, for no other reason than she *really wanted to*. “Catra. While I do enjoy your kisses. A lot. Perhaps we should talk about what exactly is happening before anything. . . extreme happens?” Placing one last kiss on her forehead, she pulled back

to search Catra's eyes, they were still guarded, as if she couldn't quite believe that Adora was being genuine, and she had to admit, that hurt. But she also knew now that this was the default for many soldiers, even herself; she would automatically shut down when any foreign feeling assailed her, it was something she had been working on since her arrival on Etheria, all those years ago. Something she still struggled with from time to time, even now. Something she had an entire village of support to overcome. Catra had had no such support in her life. And so, she tried to stamp down the hurt the disbelieving look shot through her, because it really wasn't personal.

"I don't know what talking will do. . . *I* don't even know what's happening here, Adora." Her voice sounded lost; as lost as Adora felt. "All I know is that when I see you, whatever may have been bothering me gets easier to process and my heart does weird things." She began brushing her hand through Adora's hair, "I just. . . this is all foreign to me. I just don't know." She tried to look away, the subject likely an uncomfortable one, but Adora didn't let her, they needed to face what was happening. No matter how uncomfortable the subject.

Finally realizing there was no escape, Catra's eyes returned to her own, but this time there was no guard. Raw emotion flitted across Catra's face, her eyebrows scrunched as her mouth pulled into a frown. "I don't know either, Catra. But we need to try, before everything gets too complicated."

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Catching Adora's eyes, she came down from the strange feeling, noticing Adora's fingers had stopped moving, "Why'd you stop,

Adora?” Her eyes darkened slightly before her fingers started up again, the radiating pleasure resuming along with her satisfied purr.

Licking her lips, her eyelids drooped when Adora paid particular attention to the base of her skull, rubbing purposefully. Refusing to break eye contact first, she bit her lip to distract her from the stimulation, the motion caught Adora’s attention as she broke her concentration on Catra’s eyes to observe the small bead of blood on her lips, “Catra. . .” that was all the warning she received before Adora lowered her head, licking at the cut on her lip, cleaning the blood, “you need to be more careful, love.”

Fisting her hand in Adora’s hair, she snapped the hair tie before pulling Adora in for a lingering kiss, “should I be? Why do you say that? It had the desired effect, did it not?” she panted between kisses, trying to form a coherent sentence.

Moving in front of her, Adora grabbed her cheeks, giving her a hard, yet somehow soft, kiss before pulling away, “Catra, while I do enjoy your kisses, a lot, perhaps we should talk about what exactly is happening here before anything. . . extreme happens?” kissing her forehead softly, Adora held her gaze, searching her eyes.

“I don’t know what talking will do. . . *I* don’t even know what’s happening here, Adora. All I know is that when I see you, whatever may have been bothering me gets easier to process and my heart does weird things.” Loosening her fist in Adora’s hair she smoothed out the knot that had formed, “I just. . . this is all foreign to me. I just don’t know.” She tried to look away, but Adora’s hands held firm.

Finally giving in as Adora's hands prevented her from turning away, she gave in; she let her guard down. Worrying her brows she searched Adora's eyes for answers. Anything that could ease her uncertainty. What exactly was she feeling?

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"I know. . ." Catra's voice sounded tired.

"Right, before that, we need to get this shampoo out of your hair and finish up." Pulling back she dropped one hand to grasp Catra's and pull her to the middle of the stream. Submerging herself to her shoulders she gave Catra an encouraging smile, "c'mon, love, take a dip with me."

Tsking, Catra joined her, tipping her head back to let the soap wash from her mane. When she lifted her head from the water her hair was significantly smaller, "gods, that's heavy. At least its not the same size as me anymore, huh?"

"Very true. Now for the conditioner, bottle says it supposedly gives your hair maximum 'moisture and frizz control.' Interesting." Squirting some into her palm she massaged the conditioner into her hair, "Your hair is much longer than it seems, Catra." Separating a small section of hair she brought it over Catra's shoulder, letting it fall past her hip, brushing her thigh.

"Huh, guess it is. I haven't had it sheared since escaping, I guess its grown significantly." Laying back into the water she rinsed her hair again before standing, facing Adora, "so, you wanted to talk huh? We've got time. I've got a feeling it'll take a while for my hair to dry."

Nodding, she gestured to the shore, "alright, lets go." Climbing onto the grass she held out a hand for Catra who, by all accounts, looked at her hand as if she were fighting a valiant war with herself, and she was Adora supposed. Catra was not one to rely on others, not even on Melog, whom Adora assumed had been travelling with Catra for some time. Leaving her hand out, waiting for Catra to make up her mind, she thought about what was happening between them. She knew of relationships, she also knew of the differentiating levels of relationships one could have with a variety of people. She was friends with the people of Ardglass, she was practically family to Freja, Marcus, and Kamila. There was also love on Base Grayskull, but she'd never understood the feelings of love shared between couples before; had never felt such a feeling, well, before Catra. That was the only explanation for these foreign feelings, the light heartedness, the sheer happiness, the innate need to laugh because she was just so inexplicably *happy* out in these woods with Catra. . .

"Hey, you there, dummy? You've got this faraway look. . ." Catra's face came back into her view, then her eyes fell to their intertwined hands – *when had she placed her hand there?*

Bringing her eyes back to Catra's, the dumfounded look caused the stupid smile that had found her lips grow even more, "nothing, nothing."

Pulling Catra up onto the shore she grabbed her binder and began to wrap it around her chest, Catra doing the same. Letting her eyes roam Catra's back, she took into account all of the scars that interrupted the soft, sleek flow of her fur – *a pang went off in her chest*, not pity, just sadness and anger. Pulling on her trousers, she opted to leave her top off until her hair dried. "Hey, Adora?" her back was still turned, her tail swished nervously, "do you feel it too? *Please* tell me you feel it to. . ."

Walking over she placed a hand on Catra's chin, urging her to look at her, "Catra," their eyes met, "what I feel for you, I've never felt before, and its terrifying. Feelings were never a factor in my training; my life until I was stranded on Etheria, and I'm told I'm still the same loveable robot now as I was when I came to live in Ardglass. I feel it too."

"Good." Catra wrapped her arms around Adora before moving to sit, taking Adora with her.

Stretching out her legs, she placed Catra between them, wrapping her arms around her back, tracing small circles on the skin while Catra dug her nose into her shoulder. "Catra. . . can I visit you again? I mean, after I travel to meet the Queen's mother?"

"I would be pissed if you didn't to be completely honest."

"Good." They sat in silence, just enjoying each other, until Adora heard a soft snore mix with her purrs, she smiled placing a light kiss on Catra's forehead.

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Catra jumped; she was too comfortable, there was no way she was this relaxed. Thinking Shadow Weaver had placed her under another spell she jumped up, pushing off whatever she'd been resting on, looking around frantically. This. . . wasn't the Fright Zone. . . she was in the Whispering Woods, and half naked.

"Catra?"

That voice. . . who was that? Looking over she saw blond hair, blinking, the person came into focus, "A-Adora?"

"Yes, love, I'm here. Are you alright?"

"Y-yeah." Pacing, she tried to calm her heart; slow her breathing. Adora stayed sitting, watching her carefully, and she was grateful for that, having another person around her would definitely only make it harder to calm down. Taking a deep breath, she noticed her bodice not too far. *Great, a distraction,* slipping it on made her feel a lot better. . . then she started to miss Adora. That fact freaked her out a lot more than her nightmare; while she was almost. . . happy about whatever was happening between them, it scared her, and yet, she missed her. Steeling herself she turned around, launching herself in Adora's lap, her arms squeezing as hard as possible, shoving her nose into her neck, her tail wrapping tightly around her thigh. Adora held her just as tight.
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~~~ Walking back ~~~

They walked in comfortable silence, both watching the shadows intently, as if someone were going to jump out at them at any moment. Adora wasn't sure why she was so on edge, she couldn't sense anyone near them per say. . . just the feeling that they were being watched. Catra must have felt it too because her tail began to swish impatiently, and she looked in every crevice they passed intently, her hand holding Adora's tightening slightly. . . then it was gone. The sick, ominous feeling in her gut dissipated and all that was left was the soft breeze brushing Catra's now clean hair along her arm. "Hey, Catra. . . do you-"

"Yeah, I felt it."

"Any ideas on what it was?"

"The last time I felt that presence was in the Horde."

Pulling her close, she wrapped an arm around Catra, tracing circles on her shoulder, "alright, ships only a minute or so away."

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“They’re going to start wondering where we disappeared to, and I for one am not ready to share this with anyone else just yet, love. What do you say we head back?” Adora’s hand continued to stroke her head, occasionally venturing to rub the base of her ear.

Leaning into the attention she lifted her head to look at Adora, “me too.” Reluctantly she stood from Adora’s lap and held out a hand for Adora with a smirk, “need a hand, Princess?”

“Ha! Sure, thank you, love.” Her laugh rolled through Catra bringing with it the innate need to smile stupidly, “so, why do you call me Princess? Is it because of my magical powers?”

“Hmm, nah. You just have that look about you. You look like you’d jump into fire for a complete stranger, like a lot of the Princesses I know.”

“Ah,” she thought on that, “I suppose if I had a rather good chance of getting them out-“

“Haha, I knew it!” She smacked Adora’s shoulder lightly, “anyway, I’m thinking I have another name Id like to call you. . .”

“Ah, really? And what might that be?” She looked up at Adora, her crooked smile, her messy hair that she’d left loose at Catra’s insistence, ‘you’re gonna go bald at 35, Adora!’, her eyes that somehow glowed even when She-Ra was nowhere to be found.

She looked at the face she had been seeing in her dreams; the Warrior who would save her from her demons. Her Warrior Woman. Catra smiled, placing a hand on Adora’s cheek before kissing the other, “you’re my Warrior Woman.”

Chapter End Notes

Alright, so Spring semester is starting soon, and I gotta get ready to move, move, then settle in, so there wont be an update until the end of April (probably); ill still be making art (occasionally) and posting on Twitter about the series - @Samm_arts

Ill update this note if anything changes, so stay tuned! [subscribe to the story to be updated when the new chapter comes if you don't have twitter!]

Also, if you have and suggestions/requests for something you want to see incorporated/answered in future chapters, let me know in the comments and ill see what I can do!

The Rebellion

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora had some things to work through, so this chapter is pretty much dedicated to them trying to figure out their lives, and how they fit into each other lives.

Chapter Notes

Be aware: mild descriptions of past abuse and swearing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, is it alright if we stay here the night? As long as you're still willing to come to Brightmoon to meet my mother, that is?" She saw the hope in Glimmers eyes at the prospect of the addition to her Rebellion, but she also noticed the subtle tightening in Catra's shoulders and how she turned away from the conversation opting instead to pick the grass at her hip.

She chose her words carefully, "I can't promise that I will join your Rebellion, but I am willing to meet your mother. If the planet is in the state you say, I am willing to fight the Horde." While her friends spoke very highly of the Rebellion, her loyalty remained her own and she did not give it freely. She was loyal to Base Grayskull because of her family. She was loyal to the town of Ardglass because the people had shown her love and friendship. She was loyal to Swift Wind because he had shown her unconditional loyalty in return.

She was loyal to Catra, and there was no simple reason for this loyalty; they were similar, both soldiers – brought up in opposite environments – their morals were the same. Further than that, she felt connected to Catra.

"Fair enough. Ill take what I can get. So, Bow and I will stay the night."

"Would you like a room on the ship, or. . .?"

"No, no! We have all we need. We'll just sleep out here. I love sleeping under the stars."

"Very well. Just let me know if you change your mind." Turning away from the Queen she collapsed next to Catra, laying her head on a patch of grass. "Hey. . ."

"Hey."

"Can I ask you something?"

"Um, sure. What's up, Princess?" Catra twisted to look down at her, confused.

"What do you think of the Rebellions purpose?"

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Catra just blinked at her for a moment, mind blank, "the. . . Rebellion's purpose?"

"Yes." Adora looked at her, eyes serious.

"Uh-well. . . um. I don't really know what to tell you Adora. . . I don't really have much of an opinion on the Rebellions purpose. A noble purpose doesn't change the fact that they hate my entire being simply because I was kidnapped as a child and raised in a volatile environment." Looking away from Adora she ran her fingers through the grass at her hip while Adora worked through her dilemma.

"Huh. . ." glancing back at Adora, she now had a hand on her chin, stroking thoughtfully while the furrow in her brow deepened. Her eyes fell on the muscles moving in her forearm and bicep as Adora stroked her chin and her throat went dry.

When Adora said nothing further, Catra reached over to smooth the wrinkles in her brow, "My sweet Warrior, you're going to get wrinkles at this rate, y'know." Smiling at the disproving noise from Adora she moved to begin spreading Adora's hair in the grass. "Don't take my opinions to heart, Dearest. I'm a bit biased."

"Catra, I *want* to take your opinions into account. No matter how biased." Adora tipped her head up to look into her eyes, "I care about you, Love. If you truly don't believe the Rebellion could ever accept you, simply because you were raised differently, then it

may not be the best decision to help them. So, please, tell me." Adora rolled onto her stomach, her left shoulder and chin resting on Catra's thigh as her hand trailed down her shin to her ankle, then back up again.

"Honestly, Adora, I truly don't have an opinion on the Rebellions purpose. My opinions have never mattered to anyone but myself and voicing them *always* resulted in punishment. And so, I stopped having opinions long ago." Before Adora could speak, Catra lifted a hand to stop her, "*but*, I can tell you that if it came down to it and I could no longer live my life freely, the Rebellion would be my choice over the Horde. Not a single thought of rejoining the Horde would pass over me. That is the only opinion I can offer you." She brought her hand up to swipe over Adora's brow just to do. . . *something*. For some reason she felt vulnerable, but unusual enough, she wasn't feeling the need to run. She just wants to touch Adora, run her hands through her hair, feel the curve of her cheek, trace the curve of her ear. . . just *feel* her.

"Thank you, Catra. I know the Rebellion has hurt you, greatly. I am going to go and meet the former Queen, as I have told the Queen, but I think I will refrain from joining as of yet. From the limited stories I've heard so far, I do not believe that I can, in good sense, join them. Possibly in the future I can reconsider." Threading her fingers with Catra's she looked up, catching the surprise on Catra's face.

"But-"

"That being said," she gave Catra a pointed look, "I am willing to assist them. The ultimate purpose is a reasonable one, and I wish

for this war to end. It has been waging much too long and I am growing tired of seeing fear in the eyes of the villagers. And I am tired of being afraid that I will one day wake up and the children of the village will be gone. I am tired, and so is everyone else."

"I know." Her voice was quiet, strained, "and I'm sorry. I just don't think I can bring myself to face them. Not just yet."

Adora planted her palms, raising herself so that they were face to face. Dropping her forehead so that it rested on Adora's, she let out a shaky breath, "I know, Catra. Its understandable. You are free to do as you please."

She stood, reaching a hand out to help Adora pull herself from the ground. "But I don't Adora. . ." she hated how broken her voice sounded, but it was just them, she could let her walls down. . . just a little; only with Adora was she safe enough to do this. She pulled Adora's face so that she could bunt their foreheads together.

"You don't?" her voice was full of confusion, but Catra wouldn't let her pull back so she could look her in the eyes. There was *no way* she was going to get this out if she had to look Adora in the eye; she was about to lose her nerve as it was.

"I don't want to stay behind. As much as I hate the thought of it. . . I don't want to be away from you. I don't know why. . ." finally loosening her hold on Adora, she let Adora lift her chin to look into her eyes.

“Catra. . .”

“Hey, Adora I can’t seem to find Melog anywhere, the Queen was asking about them, apparently she can feel their magic, but can’t pinpoint it. Have you seen Catra, maybe she’ll know?” Swift Wind popped around the corner of the ship, likely coming from the kitchen. Adora turned so that Catra was hidden completely behind her before speaking to her friend.

“I have not seen her Swift Wind; she may be sleeping so its probably best not to disturb her. Maybe try looking by the stream? I thought I saw Melog heading in that direction earlier.” Pointing to the stream Adora put on her best smile hoping he wouldn’t notice a stray hair or tail and figure out Adora had just flat out lied to him. She felt Catra lean her head along her spine and fist a hand in her shirt. For some reason, she just wasn’t ok with anyone else seeing Catra in this state; not only because she knew Catra would be uncomfortable with it, but also because, as she was quickly learning, *she* did not want people to see Catra like this either. The innate need to protect this woman startled her, but also felt natural at the same time; she was a jealous person only when it came to Catra, it seemed.

When Swift Wind was out of sight, she let out the breath she had been holding, then turned her head, but only catching a glimpse of Catra’s tail as it swished; *Catra really was tiny*. “Hey, Love? How about we head inside?”

They stood like that, questions hanging in the silence for a few minutes before she heard a muffled, “yeah,” come from her back.

Then Catra peeked around her arm to make sure no one was watching before walking quickly toward the ship, hiding her face from Adora.

"Hey, Catra?" and she was gone, turning toward her room. . . well *their* room she supposed. Following after her she tried to piece together what might have upset her? Was she even upset? As much as Adora would like to say she knew the woman. Even she, one who excelled in reading people, could not read someone who had perfected the art of supressing and banishing all feeling, someone such as Catra. Even the most well-trained galactic assassins she had tracked had not been able to throw her off so well. And Catra made it look effortless.

Taking the final turn into her hallway, she saw the tip of Catra's tail disappear into their quarters. . . Catra was running away from her, but she wasn't about to let her bottle up her feelings this time. They were going to talk about this, she wanted to know what Catra meant. . . she would not – *could not* – face the people of the Rebellion? but she also did not want to stay behind? Conflicting feelings such as those were not something Adora was willing to let Catra work through alone. Especially since, she presumed, she was the root cause of them. Making it to the doorway she assessed the room, not seeing Catra at first, but alas, the lump in her pallet had returned.

Smiling to herself she pushed off the doorframe, collapsing onto the floor beside her pallet, "well, see now, generally heart-to-heart talks don't end with magical 8-foot-tall horses walking in on a vulnerable moment. . . not that I've had any heart-to-heart talks before, but from what I've heard, that is not how they are supposed to end." Flipping over she faced the lump that she assumed was Catra's face, "now, can we continue, or has the

mood been completely ruined by my dear friend that will likely find himself rid of his colourful locks in the morning, hmm?"

A snort escaped one of the lumps before a hand, at least she assumed it was a hand, moved to lift the blanket from over her eyes, and Adora realized the reasoning for her quick departure. Her eyes were damp and ringed with raw, red circles; she had been crying, so silently that Adora hadn't even noticed. Careful not to react with anything resembling pity she lifted a hand to wipe a stray tear that had escaped, rolling down her cheek. "I guess we can-" sniff- "continue. . ." her voice was tight and non-existent by the end of her sentence.

"Catra, Love. I'm not going to ignore your being overwhelmed simply because I'm curious, c'mere," holding her arms open in invitation she allowed Catra to come to her if she so chose to accept her comfort. She really hoped she did. . .

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"Catra. . ."

"Hey, Adora I can't seem to find Melog anywhere, the Queen was asking about them, apparently she can feel their magic, but can't pinpoint it. Have you seen Catra, maybe she'll know?" Adora turned, hiding her from the horse, something she was eternally grateful for as the tears overflowed, falling from her eyes, despite lacking her permission. Wiping them furiously she stayed silent. Why the *hell* was she crying? She had no reason to be feeling. . . everything, and yet here she stood hiding from a horse, her knees

threatening to give out at any second. Leaning on Adora's back for support she fisted a hand in her shirt to steady herself.

Breathing deeply, Adora's scent alone calmed her to no end, her tears lessening from a small river to a few stray tears that fought their way past her stubborn tear ducts. "I have not seen her Swift Wind; she may be sleeping so its probably best not to disturb her. Maybe try looking by the stream? I thought I saw Melog heading in that direction earlier." She felt Adora's spine stiffen as the lie rolled off her tongue. . . well not so much as rolled, more like tumbled; Adora was a *terrible* liar. . . and yet the horse left none the wiser. They were certainly an. . . odd pair, indeed.

She felt Adora's muscles loosen as the horse walked away, she then leaned back into Catra before speaking, "hey, Love? How about we head inside?"

Shit. . . now to plan her escape. She knew, she *knew* Adora would never judge her for crying. She *knew* that, yet she found herself *needing* to get away before someone saw her. This utter weakness she was displaying. . . it was simply against her nature to let another soul in. She couldn't do it, and so she acknowledged Adora's suggestion, "yeah. . ." then walked as quickly as possible, craning her head to hide her face from any possible onlookers and headed straight for their room. . . *their room. . . oh.*

All she heard before rounding the corner of the ship was a very confused Adora, "hey, Catra?" and her heart broke all over again and the tears began to flow freely once again. . . *shit.* Finally making it to the room she didn't even have to think, she rushed to

Adora's pallet, covering herself so that no part of her pathetic form was visible.

She was feeling too much all at once. . . it was all too much. How could she have let herself open up to another person, she had been about to tell Adora to take her too. She *wanted* to go with Adora. No matter what the Rebellion thought of her, or the people who had attacked her, and the people who hated her. She really didn't care what they thought so long as she could just stay with Adora. She never wanted to let her go. . . and that *scared* her.

Now, her tears were nearly dried up, only strays escaping, but her body lay paralyzed, cold at the realization that she was, in fact, attached to, reliant on, and *needed* another person. Adora had wormed her way into a heart that hadn't beat since Shadow Weaver sneered at her and said, '*she'll do, at least she'll have the strength of a Magicat.*' After her kidnapping, her heart that had stopped beating in that moment out of pure terror was now beginning to beat once again as Adora's warmth enveloped her.

And so, there she lay, frozen as her heart beat furiously. She barely registered the thump beside her as her thoughts ran a million miles a second but stopped as soon as she heard the voice of her angel trying to ease her fears. "Well, see now, generally heart-to-heart talks don't end with magical 8-foot-tall horses walking in on a vulnerable moment. . . not that I've had any heart-to-heart talks before, but from what I've heard, that is not how they are supposed to end." Amid the rambling, she heard movement on the floor, and Adora's voice sounded closer; she had turned to face her, "now, can we continue, or has the mood been completely ruined by my dear friend that will likely find himself rid of his colourful locks in the morning, hmm?"

Despite the cold fear seated in her gut, and the tears still escaping her eyes, she smiled and let out a snort. Sniffing she lifted the sheet, purely based on her *need* to see Adora. To see those bright blue eyes that she was sure would cheer her immensely. She was sure they would cheer her, and yet, when she lifted the blanket free from her head and she locked onto those beautiful eyes, she felt a wave of sadness overtake her; *what would she do if Adora left her.* Surely she would be left broken. . . even more broken than Shadow Weaver could ever leave her, because Adora had done something Shadow Weaver *never* could. Adora held Catra's heart in the palm of her hand. "I guess we can-" sniff- "continue. . ." her voice was tight and non-existent by the end of her sentence, but she had gotten it out. . . and maybe talking about it would help. . . maybe.

Adora's eyes were soft as her hand came up to wipe away a tear that had shed, running along her cheek. Leaving her hand to continue stroking her cheekbone in that loving, *familiar* way she captured Catra's gaze, "Catra, Love. I'm not going to ignore your being overwhelmed simply because I'm curious, c'mere."

She held her arms open in invitation, but didn't move any closer, despite the longing in her eyes. Catra found the answering longing in her own chest as she felt herself shuffling into her embrace, seeking the solace of Adora's throat, breathing in her scent where it was strongest. "I-"

"Shhh, let us calm down a minute first. I'm feeling quite overwhelmed, and I think I need a moment. . ."

"Yeah, ok. . ." she wasn't sure if Adora was truly feeling overwhelmed, or if she was doing this purely for her sake, but she was grateful nonetheless. Latching onto her, Catra threw a leg over Adora's torso, pulling her close and wrapping her tail tightly around her thigh so she was wedged as close as humanly possible. Then she squeezed an arm between Adora and the floor, holding her tightly before burying her face as close to her neck as her need for oxygen allowed and just let herself *feel*.

***

After Catra wrapped around her, tighter than even Kam had managed as a child, she wrapped her arms around the woman, stroking her back gently. Her heart twinged when she felt the hot tears reach her collarbone, and wrapped her arm tighter, keeping her strokes even and light. Then Catra began giggling uncontrollably before the tears came once again. And still, she continued her stroking, holding Catra securely to her body.

They stayed like that for some time, Catra switching, with no apparent pattern, between crying and laughing, but now she lay still, not crying, but not laughing either, so Adora dared to speak, "Catra? Love, I'm going to move us to the bed. Hold tight."

The only answer she received was Catra's arms tightening even more and her head turning to kiss her jaw, featherlight. Bracing her arm on the floor she hoisted herself onto her knees, then, once she was steady, lifted them until she was standing straight – and she did well if she didn't say so herself, only grunted once, partly because her back and neck were sore from laying on the hard floor too long, and partly from the added weight on her torso, also known as Catra. Letting the top sheet of the pallet fall

from Catra's frame, she headed to the bed, thought about laying Catra separately, but she seemed rather. . . *attached* at the moment, so she instead awkwardly rolled onto the bed, keeping mind not to land on Catra, or her hair. . . which was no easy feat. By any means.

Rearranging limbs until they were both comfortable, Adora huffed, "Catra, Love, did you fall asleep on me already?"

"No. . ." Catra lifted her face to catch Adora's eyes, they were red and swollen from crying, but they seemed. . . lighter, somehow, "I'm just trying to word this right. . ."

"You don't need to word it perfectly, Love. I'm sure you'll get your point across either way." She smiled at the way Catra's nose scrunched. . . they really were similar, both learned perfectionists, haunted by their childhoods, to very different degrees, of course. But all the same, neither felt that they could be anything less than perfect, but it was something they could work on. . . *together*.

"I-" she frowned, still trying to piece together her thoughts, "I *know* that I'm not ready to face the people of the Rebellion, of Brightmoon for that matter. I'm not *ready* to have an entire Kingdom sneer in my direction simply because my people were wiped out by the Horde before they could fortify their village. Do they not realize *I didn't have a choice*? I didn't choose to be a Horde soldier, and I certainly didn't choose to be 'raised' by an insane sorceress that's had a grudge on me since the day she laid eyes on me. I don't deserve their hate, and yet. . ."

“Catra. . .” lifting her hand from stroking Catra’s back, she swiped a stray hair that fell across Catra’s forehead, then smoothed her brows. Taking a breath, she readied herself to rip out her own heart; Catra wasn’t ready to face the world, a world that hated her for simply existing, and so, Adora wasn’t going to force her. But before she could suggest Catra stay behind, she cut her off.

“That being said, the thought of you leaving tomorrow without me hurts even more. I may not like what’s happening to me, but you’ve wormed your way into a heart that I had long ago thought destroyed.” Catra looked away, searching the darkness for a time, but when her eyes returned to Adora’s, they were determined; sure. “You are quickly becoming my whole heart, my dear Warrior. I am too far gone to allow you to leave me. Where you go, I go. Do you hear me?”

Adora’s heart squeezed. While she had felt love before; she loved her Aunt, she loved her nieces, nephews, and the people of Ardglass. She had never loved them quite the same way as she was beginning to love the woman who lay before her, eyes raw and ringed with red, her voice hoarse, and hair a mess, and yet still so strong. Letting her emotions go, she felt a tear slip down her cheek, “I hear you, Catra.”

Unable to hold on any longer, she laughed. Pure, simple, and full of joy, she laughed, and after a moment she realized she wasn’t alone; Catra was laughing with her. Quieting, she listened to the first, real laugh she had heard from Catra. It was beautiful, light, and Adora would never get enough of it.

Still giggling, Catra opened her eyes capturing Adora’s, “I’ve known you for, what?” *giggle*, “all of 6 days, and I’m over here

confessing my loyalty to you. . .” *giggle*, “ I truly have gone mad, haven’t I?”

“If you believe yourself mad for that, I believe I am insane; I don’t know what I would have done if you wished to stay behind.” Catra’s forehead bunted into hers, and she sighed deeply.

“Adora. . .”

“Hmm?”

“I-I’m scared. . . of, well, of everything. But. . . I think I’m most scared that you’ll no longer be safe if you were to associate with me. Even if you are their ‘Legendary Princess of Power’ and the ‘saviour of Etheria,’ I’m afraid they may take their hatred of me out on you as well. Not to mention, Shadow Weaver and the entire Horde army will no doubt be after you as well. Are you not hesitant to fall for an outcast?” Catra didn’t look at her, instead leaving their foreheads pressed together, but the arms around her tightened.

“No.”

That caught Catra’s attention, her head whipping back, surprise evident on her features, “wha-“

“I have long since learned to disregard others’ opinions of myself; what does their opinion matter so long as *I*, and *you* are happy?”

“I suppose that makes sense. . .”

“Besides, if anyone were to be so bold as to attempt an attack, I believe we are well suited to defend ourselves. Don’t you think?”

Catra snorted, “yeah, yeah. I got it. . .” Catra disentangled her limbs from Adora’s, sitting up on the bed, “. . . thank you. For everything, I mean.”

“You have nothing to thank me for, Love.” She sat up, mirroring Catra, resting her forearms on her knees.

“But I do. Before you. . . and Kamila, I didn’t know what a simple conversation with another person could feel like. Y’know, just shooting the shit; no reason to be talking to that person except that you *want* to. . .” Catra sighed heavily and began to pick at her nails, “what I’m saying is. . . thank you for treating me like a person.”

Adora peeked at Catra, the sincerity in her tone broke her heart to pieces. . . to feel the need to thank a person for simply treating them like a living, breathing creature with a set of feelings of their own, it. . . broke her heart. “You’re welcome.” It was time for a lighter subject she decided, “I don’t know about you, but I’m hungry, how about you?”

“Me too. . . you could say I’m hungry enough to. . . eat a horse.” A wicked smile pulled up the edges of Catra’s lips, her eyes twinkling with mischief as she stood, holding a hand out for Adora.

Snorting, Adora accepted her offer, pulling herself up, “don’t let Swift Wind hear you say that, he’ll never stop whining about it.

“Ha! He was planning to spray me with water earlier! This is simply payback.” Catra turned to walk out of the room, swaying her hips purposefully.

Adora *noticed*, her breath coming in uneven bursts as she hurried to follow her to the kitchen, “wicked woman.”

“You love it, dearest.” Catra sent a smirk over her shoulder, her teeth flashing.

“That I do. . . that I do.”

Chapter End Notes

Next update will likely be April 30th, subscribe to be notified, or follow my Twitter/Instagram for updates (@samm_arts//@samm_arts_)!

A Fallen Warrior

Chapter Summary

Y'all are about to get huuurt :P

Chapter Notes

I know, it's a day early, but I'm moving tomorrow and can't guarantee id remember to upload, so today it is

CW: please be aware of: swearing, mild descriptions of past abuse, and implied sexual content. If you are uncomfortable with any of these, please either do not read, or prepare yourself to see such content.

Anyways, Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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"Addy! Look at what I found!" Running out from the forests edge where she'd been exploring, Kamila rushed over to Adora cradling something extremely *fluffy* to her chest.

Catra sniffed the air, the tangy scent reminded her of something, the name on the tip of her tongue, "is that-"

"A bunny! Lookit him, he's just so cute!" Kamila opened her palm to show a grown Veasna Rabbit. Indigenous to the Whispering Woods, generally extremely skittish, they were rarely seen close up and, when nesting, the mothers can be extremely irritable;
~~~

best to keep away from them if you wish your ankles to remain unharmed. But in this case, oddly enough, the rabbit appeared docile, completely content being held by Kamila.

"Wow Kam, I've never seen one in person; they're generally extremely skittish around people, especially this many people." Cupping her hand beneath Kamila's, she helped adjust the animal in the girls' arms, feeling for injuries, "ah, there it is. Looks like he has a broken leg; its extremely swollen and displaced."

Catra's head popped over her shoulder, examining the creature with curiosity. "He doesn't seem all that agitated though. . . the only times I've seen these creatures is when I travelled at night, and as soon as they sensed my presence they would get extremely anxious and run. He seems to be completely relaxed in your arms though. Odd indeed."

"That's kind of the same as how I met Swifty over here, well before his magic was unlocked." She smiled at the memory, looking over at her rambunctious steed. "We had been searching an abandoned planet for refugees and came across a *very* skittish foal. I was only 8 years old at the time, my first mission." She stroked his mane as she reminisced. "I was so excited. . . then I noticed a bunch of senior soldiers chasing after a small dirt-soaked creature that suddenly turned and ran full speed at me. And in that moment, all of my training was running through my head at once, and yet my body would only lift my arms and brace for the impact." She laughed lightly remembering the way it felt to have his head smack directly into her lungs, expelling all of her breath in one go.

Swifty laughed, “I don’t remember that, the only thing I remember from that day was the warmth surrounding me for the first time in my life. And I never let go.”

“Me either, Swifty. Not for anything.” Smiling she looked over to Kamila who continued to cuddle her newfound friend, “would you like to take him home? Help him heal?”

Kam looked up, eyes hopeful, “can I do that?”

“Of course. And by the looks of it, he seems quite alright staying with you.” The Rabbit nestled further into the girls’ arms, a light purr starting.

The giggling girl skipped the rest of the walk, until they heard the sound of metal clashing.

~~~ *Village of Ardglass, a few hours earlier* ~~~

Freja woke with a start, feeling frantically around the bed, only calming when she felt Mina’s familiar warmth at her side, her hand falling on her uninjured shoulder. The sadness returned as she observed the crisscrossing pattern of bandages covering Mina’s right shoulder trailing down her bicep. Continuing, her eyes fell on the bandage covering her torso, down to her hips and under the blanket. She didn’t need to see the bandages to know where her love had been hurt, the image of a blood soaked, limping Mina had been seared into her mind. . . that had only
~~~

been merely a week ago, the wounds had healed enough, and today was the day they had 'agreed' she would go back and help protect the Village from the Horde encampment. But the closer they came to today, the more she wished she had pushed harder to keep Mina out of the field, even if only for another week. "Mina, darling, it's time to wake." Swiping a stray hair from her cheek, Freja kissed the base of her loves ear in hopes of stirring her, "we will be late if we sleep any longer."

Mina stirred, stretching out her limbs, a groan escaping as her sore muscles were stretched taunt. "Hmm? Free? What time is it?" groggy eyes met her own as Mina slowly came to consciousness.

"Its early, but I wanted to make sure I got you to the healers before work." She passed her hand lightly over the bindings and bandages littering Mina's torso and arms, the rage darkening her mood and leaving a bitter taste on her tongue. "I could *kill* those Horde *idiots* for touching you."

"I know you could baby, but it would hurt *you* too. I've seen what your magic can do to you and I never want to again." Her eyes grew haunted, and her brows worried making her look far beyond her years.

"I'm sorry. I didn't think- I didn't realize. . ." trailing off, she continued to check for any blood on Mina's bandages. There was none, which, on one hand was good. But on the other hand, it meant she would be back out fighting off the Horde encampment that had appeared not long after Adora and Kamila had gone. She just hoped they would stay away; stay safe.

“Its ok, I know you were just protecting us.” The life returning to her eyes, Mina sat up, pulling her in for a quick kiss before getting dressed, “let’s go, I wanna check in with Tecla before I get back out there. I heard the stables were hit pretty bad yesterday.”

“Ok, but only as long as you two-“

“’stay out of trouble,’ I know.” A smirk pulled Mina’s lips upward, and Freja couldn’t help but marvel at her beauty, despite the bandages peaking out from her clothing. Despite the dark circles under her eyes. Despite her weary eyes that she was trying so hard to hide, tiredness that came from overexerting her exhausted, healing body. Tiredness that she shouldn’t be feeling. Tiredness that Freja would give almost anything for her not to feel, but there was nothing she could do about it. While she was strong, her magic had harsh side effects if she were to use it on such a wide scale as destroying a Horde encampment. Not only that, but she was out of practice; she hadn’t used her magic seriously or trained in the years after she had escaped to Etheria, even less after she had allowed herself to fall in love. She had fallen complacent, and she had regretted nothing more in her life than she did her complacency.

Pulling Mina into a tight embrace, she dropped her face to whisper, “I love you; you are my heart.”

Mina’s arms came around her, holding her tight, “I love you too.”

***

Crash, clang, "Elke, over here!"

"That sounds like Mee?" Kamila looked up from her new friend, worry evident on her features, "Addy? What's going on? Why is Mee yelling?"

"I. . . don't know yet. Stay here, ok? Melog, Swift Wind, can you stay with her?" Already heading past the edge of the woods, she turned to look back at Swift Wind and Melog making sure they heard. At their nods she turned back to the village, peaking over the edge of the hill.

Clang clack, "Hathor, I'm pinned, can I get a hand?". . . "on it, one moment and ill be right there."

Her step faltering, she took in the scene before her. . . it was nothing less then a warzone. The villages front gate looked as if it had been shot open and burned, most of the bungalows still stood, but were worse for wear, but what truly worried her was her friends and family that looked about ready to collapse. Injured and beaten, fighting at 3:1 odds; odds she didn't like. Masking her expression as not to worry Kam, she waved Catra, Bow and the Queen over.

Walking quickly over to her, Catra looked worried. She must have been able to see through her mask, "Adora, what's wrong?"

“Just. . . take a look for yourselves.” Pointing over her shoulder to the town, perfectly fine merely a week ago, that now lay in shambles, the townspeople minutes from defeat to the oncoming Horde soldiers. Turning to The Queen and her Archer, she gestured to the village, arm shaking slightly with the need to run in, “will you help me save my village?”

“Of course, just tell me where you need me.” The Queen began to jog over, “I have teleportation, and offensive abilities along with being an accomplished sorcerer. Bow is the best archer on Etheria; decent fighter too.”

“Hey! I’m an amazing close-combat fighter.” Smiling, she took comfort in their light banter, it was generally a sign of an accomplished combatant; a good ally to have.

Breaking out into a sprint she looked over to Catra, her expression was hard as she surveyed the Horde soldiers. When their eyes met, Adora gave her a small smile, receiving a weak one in return. As they approached the fight, she yelled out to Hathor who seemed to be taking on the entire Horde force, protecting the small group of downed villagers. “Hathor! We’re coming to you!”

His eyes flashed to hers, giving a small nod before decking the soldier running at him, knocking them out cold before moving onto the next. “Why did you give away our location? The Horde knows we’re here now.” Glimmer moved in closer beside her, no accusation in her tone, just curiosity, “there coming at us, fast.”

“Hathor gets this sort of tunnel vision when he fights.” Sliding to a stop, she planted her feet, taking the first soldier that made it to her, knocking him over her shoulder then to the ground. “I re-trained him to fight in Etheria’s climate and atmosphere. When he fights though, you don’t want to get in his way. He can’t discern the difference between friend and foe, that is unless you’re able to get his attention.” Moving onto the next soldier, she let her training kick in, her mind focusing solely on making it to her friends and keeping an eye on Catra. Though, her concern was entirely unneeded as she watched Catra cut through all the soldiers coming at her with ease.

“Hey, we need to angle for Hathor and the others; the big red skinned guy cutting through the soldiers like butter. The others look hurt. Are you guys able to help him cover us while I see if I can heal them?”

“Of course.” Glimmer placed a hand on her shoulder, “are you not going to bring out She-Ra?”

“Nah. This fight doesn’t warrant that kind of magic. Unless the wounds are severe, my magic is strong enough without the transformation.” Finally getting close enough to gauge the injuries, she saw mostly minor scrapes and bruises. . . they just looked completely exhausted. “Hey Hathor, this is Catra, Glimmer, and Bow, they’re friendly and are here to help.”

“Got it boss. Mostly minor injuries here, just couldn’t fight anymore.”

“Got it.” Dropping to her knees she checked on Elke and Marcus, “hey guys, anything broken or bleeding?”

“Nah Chief, just my pride. You think my boys saw me collapse?”

“Probably not, they’re underground with everyone else. . .” Marcus smirked until he got punched in the shoulder, falling face first into the dirt, “ow.”

“You two will be fine. Why don’t you head underground to see how your families are doing?” Moving onto the next, Marcus stopped her.

“My entire family isn’t down there; Kam is with you. . . *was* with you.”

“Kam is safe. I wouldn’t be here if I was not sure of her safety. Now go.” Nodding, Marcus and Elke headed to the bunker. Turning to the triplets, she assessed their injuries. While Tecla and Sorina looked unhurt, the sheen of cold sweat and unhealthy paleness on Mina’s face worried her, “Mina, where are you hurt?”

Unfocused eyes landed on hers, slow recognition bringing the familiar lopsided smile to her lips, “heeeeeyyy A! You’re back!” Her smile fell as a coughing fit took over, then groaning as she grabbed her side, “ow. I’m not hurt. . .”

“Mee. . .”

“Adoraaaa. . .” lifting the edge of her shirt she caught a glimpse of a blood-soaked bandage before Mina knocked her hand away, shirt falling back over the bandage, “ok, ok, ok. . . maybe I’m a *little* beat up. But I can still help!”

Sighing she helped Mina stand up, “Mee, I know you *think* you can help, but I really need you to help in the bunker, ok?” at her reluctant nod, she handed her off to her siblings. “Now stay out of trouble you three,” turning back to the fight, she marveled at Catra cutting through the Horde soldiers. While Glimmer, Bow, and Hathor weren’t slouches, there was definitely something about the way Catra fought that was utterly beautiful.

Before she could join though the soldiers called a retreat, falling over each other as they tried to get away from Catra who began to chase them, her face contorted in rage. Running after her, she slowed to shout to Bow and the Queen, “hey, do you mind staying with Hathor to fight off any stragglers? I’m going to follow Catra.”

“Of course,” Bows eyes followed Catra as she disappeared into the woods, “you may want to hurry though. . . she looks seriously pissed.”

“Thank you,” quickening her pace until she was running, she searched the woods until she saw a group of Horde soldiers crowding around. . . something. And she bet she knew exactly what that *something* was. . . “Catra, what were you thinking?” speaking to no one in particular, she dropped low to the ground,

shielding herself behind the thick brush, making her way closer to the group.

"Hey, we should get in there too. Why does Nisha get to have all the fun?"

Glancing up, she tuned into the conversation of the young soldiers standing in front of the bush she was crouching behind:

"She's the boss. . . and has a personal grudge on Catra. They were cadets together y'know?"

"Still, why not just gang up on her? She'd be helpless against this many people. C'mon guys! Let's get her-"

"No!" Her heart dropping to her toes, Adora sprung up from the brush, grabbing the soldier and quickly incapacitating them. . . but she wasn't quick enough. She watched in horror as Catra was grabbed by the one called Nisha; the other soldiers descended on her in a horde. "Catra-"

Before she could cry out her body was engulfed by She-Ra's magic, both familiar, and alien at the same time. It was like she wasn't in control of her own body as she tore through the gaggle of soldiers, one thought on her mind: *Catra!*

***

A flash of unruly auburn hair caught her attention and seconds later hard, angry yellow eyes filled her own as her oldest enemy appeared in front of her, only mere inches away. Careful not to react to the move she knew all too well, she plastered a mocking smirk on her face, "Hey Nisha, how've you been?" At the annoyed growl Catra's smirk grew, she was enjoying the newfound power she had over Nisha. She had always had this *power* over Catra, ever since they were children, she was the only one that truly got to her.

The only friend she had ever had in the Horde. Her only friend and her fiercest enemy.

~~~ Fright Zone, roughly 23 years ago ~~

In front of her stood the biggest *tree she had ever laid eyes on; it was like* a hundred *feet around. Placing a hand on the trunk she stroked the rough surface, marveling at the feeling; everything was so smooth. . . and cold inside the Fright Zone, but just outside the monstrous structure was the mysterious Whispering Woods where the trees stood, rough and warm. They weren't supposed to be here, but Nisha had wanted to come out here, and so had Catra. "Catra! Catra! Lookit, this is the smoothest rock I have* ever *seen!"*

Turning to face Nisha, she snorted, "c'mon Nish, that's the only *rock you've ever seen."*

Huffing Nisha pouted, "I'm sure I saw one before. . ."

"Not here! Maybe before you got here?"

"Nah."

Shrugging, Catra smiled grabbing Nisha's hand pulling her along the edge. Soon they were both laughing and playing.

**** a few years later ****

Catra stood in their spot, the one they had escaped to all those years ago, running her hand on the enormous tree soaking in the rough warmth as she waited for Nisha to meet her. "Catra, what are you doing here?"

Everything inside her went cold, a cold that not even her tree could warm. Turning slowly, she faced her greatest nightmare, a nightmare that was very much tangible, "Sh-shadow Weaver! Uh. . . nothing. I mean-I'm just-uh. . ."

"SILENCE! Get back to your barracks. I will deal with you later."

Hurrying away, her eyes caught sight of wild auburn hair and yellow eyes as Nisha stood, sly smirk on her face, waving

nonchalantly.

A cold, numb feeling in her gut burned white hot as rage and pain bloomed from deep withing her soul. This was a betrayal that she would never *get over.*

~~~ Present time ~~~

Ever since that day, Nisha had held an awful power over Catra, but for some reason, she didn't feel that crushing pain and rage in her gut as she looked into Nisha's cold, unfeeling gaze, she just felt unbelievably calm. And she loved it. The nonchalance in her tone seemed to annoy Nisha to no end as her face contorted into anger, "I don't know, *kitty*? Being Shadow Weavers number one is treating me p-r-e-t-t-y well, huh? Don't I look it?"

Giving her a once over, Catra, for the first time, noticed just how *normal* Nisha looked. She wasn't some *goddess* that deserved all of Catra's attention, "Hmmm, you look pretty dumpy to me. Have you gotten shorter?"

Nisha growled before attacking, seems little miss perfect had a sore spot. Not that her height should be a problem. . . she easily towered over everyone in their age group as Cadets, and even now, at 6'7, she towered over nearly anyone. Nevertheless, she filed that insecurity away for later use.

As they fought, she noticed the other soldiers kept their distance. . . smart of them. But then she heard the "FALL BACK!" coming from somewhere. Smirking once again she pinned Nisha to the ground, "looks like your little friends are falling back. Better scamper on with them." Lifting herself off of her, Catra watched the indecision and hatred flash over Nisha's face before running back to wherever their encampment was located.

"Too bad, Kitty. . . I was *really* looking forward to bringing you back and *presenting* you to Shadow Weaver. . ."

Rage turned her vision red as her feet moved of their own volition, giving chase to the retreating soldiers, eyes locked onto Nisha.

Suddenly she noticed that there were no other soldiers around Nisha, and she had slowed significantly. . . and then she saw it, she was surrounded. She had been so intent on catching up that she hadn't noticed the group of soldiers falling in around her to block any and all escape. *Shit!* Stopping and spreading her feet wide, she surveyed those surrounding her, there had to be at least 20, how could she have not noticed *that many* falling behind.

But she knew. . . Nisha had mentioned Shadow Weaver who, to Catra's dismay, was still an incredibly sore spot. . . especially coming from Nisha's lying mouth. Still crouching, she brought up her fists, "Heh, needed a little backup taking on little ole me, *Ashwin*?"

“In your dreams! They’re here for the show,” the easy smirk on Nisha’s face peaked her nerves as she began to circle. . . she wouldn’t be the one to start this fight, and she knew Nisha wouldn’t last long. Patience was not her virtue.

And Catra was right, they had only made it round once before Nisha charged, smiling she moved out of the way, watching her fall to the ground as the expected impact never came, “ah, typical, typical Nisha. Will you *never* learn?”

At that, their fight truly began, all quick jabs, blocks, and insults. They were getting nowhere; a perfect combative match. Catra, disadvantaged in height, brute strength, and magical prowess, but she was fast, and. . . *she planned her moves through to the end*, she thought, smirking when Nisha left her middle open once again. She put all her weight behind her next blow, ensuring to catch her claws in the soft skin as she ripped them away. “Agh,” staggering backward, Nisha held her side, “oh you’ll pay for that, Catra.”

“Will I though?”

She was passively aware when murmuring erupted between the surrounding soldiers, but one voice could be distinctly heard as they spoke up, “C’mon guys! Lets get her-“

. . . *Shit!*

Arms came around from behind her, locking her in an iron grip, one arm around her waist immobilizing her arms, the other around her neck, squeezing hard enough that her vision swam, her peripheral vision darkening as she watched the soldiers descend on her. “I told you you would pay for that, bitch,” she tracked the voice all the way until it was right in front of her, but no amount of blinking was going to clear her vision, all she could see now was the cold yellow orbs floating with her into unconsciousness.

But as she passed out, she could almost swear she heard Adora yell out for her, “Catra!” But then she, well *felt* it more than *saw* it, but she would know that magic anywhere, She-Ra; *Adora!*

*****

“Catra!” Detransforming, she fell to her knees just as Catra’s eyes rolled back into her skull and dropped, hard. Catching her falling frame, she laid her softly onto the grass before patting her down lightly, looking for any major injuries. “Shit,” a long gash ran along the bottom of her chin all the way up her cheek to narrowly miss her eye, instead curving around it and ending just above her eyebrow. Though it was bleeding profusely, it wasn’t deep, and it would heal; it certainly wouldn’t render Catra unconscious. . . continuing her search she stopped as her fingers ran slick with Catra’s blood, blood pooling just above her pelvis on the right, “double shit.”

[I decided this moment was best to draw (heh) - check out the art here]

Carefully ripping her bodice, she hoped, prayed, it was only a small cut that was bleeding badly. . .

. . . it wasn't. . .

Right where she'd bled through her bodice lay a jagged opening, a stab wound, but not a simple stab wound; the one who had stabbed her not only stabbed her, but had, evidently, twisted the blade in order to inflict as much damage as possible with a single strike. The only reason Catra was still breathing was the unbelievably bad luck of the perpetrator, and extremely good luck on Catra's part, that the placement of the stabbing seemed to have missed all major organs. It had simply ripped through the skin and muscle. "A. . . dor?" at Catra's weak call, she lifted her gaze to Catra's.

"Catra? You're going to be alright. Do you hear me?"

"S'ok 'dor. Too 'uch bloo-ugh-d, won't last long-*cough*-'eave me be. . . hind."

"Not a chance, love. You. Are. Going. To. Be. Just. Fine." Cupping Catra's cheek, she forced eye contact, "promise me you will fight. All the way until you are healed. Promise me."

Cough- "Adora. . ."

“Promise me.”

“I promise.” *Cough, cough.*

~~~

“Catra!”

Adora? Everything went black and she began to fall, falling into an endless pit.

“Ah-huh?” jolting awake, she stared into the nothingness around her. So, she’d finally done it, huh; she’d gotten herself into a stupid situation way over her head and gotten herself killed. And yet, despite herself, she wasn’t at peace with the thought of finally being rid of her pathetic, menial life, because despite her life being pathetic and menial, she finally had something to live for, a light at the end of the tunnel. Her light comprised of a solid frame, shiny blonde hair, soft blue eyes, a strong nose, a mouth derived directly from the heavens; lips appearing hard, yet when she touched them, they were as soft and supple as a cloud. A strong neck connected with wide shoulders layered with muscle; she was perfect, and Catra had fallen completely head over heals in love with her.

Before she could finish that thought though, excruciating pain radiated from her hip. Looking down she watched as blood flowed from a slice in her bodice, “shit, she really did get me. Damn her.”
~~~

Suddenly tired she simply watched as a pool of blood formed on the white floor producing a sickeningly red circle around her pelvis. Just as she felt the numbness creep up to her shoulders, something caressed her cheek, oh so softly, ". . . Adora. . ."

"Shit! Double shit."

It was faint, but that was definitely Adora, her hand trailing down from her eyebrow to her chin, then further down her neck passing over her chest, then. . . nothing. The numbness stole from her the last touch she would ever feel from her light, and she hated herself for the yearning she felt deep within herself. Dying was all she had wanted for the majority of her life. For as long as she could remember, the idea of dying had been rather appealing to her, in the Horde, and even after she managed to escape, her life had only moderately improved. Yes, she no longer had to deal with Shadow Weaver, but in her stead, the Rebellions soldiers made sure to continue the living hell that had been her life. And yet. . . as she lay in this endless empty space dying, she couldn't help but feel helpless because she didn't *want* to die anymore. But such is life she supposed.

Closing her eyes, she waited for the numbness to take over her completely until she just. . . floated away. Then she heard something, it was distant, but it sounded like something was being. . . *ripped?*

How peculiar?

Opening her eyes, she saw the hazy outline of a person hovering over her, a person with a solid frame, shiny blonde hair, soft blue eyes, a strong nose, and soft mouth, "A. . . dor?" her voice wasn't working like it should, and she hated how hoarse and hollow what was left of it sounded. That would definitely worry Adora, and yet, when Adora's eyes locked on hers, the worry was evident, but it wasn't the slight worry she was expecting to see, this was full blown panic. She must look like she's teetering on the edge of death to bring on a look such as that. S*hit, now she had to* watch *Adora watch her die.*

"Catra? You're going to be alright. Do you hear me?". . . *barely*.

Adora's voice was only reaching her at a whisper, but she could hear her, clearing her throat, she tried forming a coherent sentence again, tried to prepare Adora for the inevitable, "S'ok 'dor. Too 'uch bloo-ugh-d, won't last long-*cough*-'eave me be. . . hind."

"Not a chance, love. You. Are. Going. To. Be. Just. Fine." Adora's hand lifted to cup her cheek. She knew that, and yet, she couldn't feel the contact, "promise me you will fight. All the way until you are healed. Promise me."

Cough- "Adora. . ."

"Promise me."

"I promise." *Cough, cough.*

~~~

Making sure to keep pressure on her stomach, Adora hoisted Catra into her arms, "*For the honour of Grayskull.*" Before her transformation was even complete, she was running as fast as her legs would take her.

Running out of these Whispering Woods.

Running across the field that never seemed so large as it did in this moment.

Running past Hathor and the others at the Villages gate.

Running straight to her cabin.

Placing Catra on the bed she made sure Catra was keeping pressure on her stomach before grabbing a cloth to clean out the wound. She wasn't about to risk sealing her wound before ensuring the blade used wasn't poisoned. While She-Ra's magic was extensive, she knew for a fact that healing a wound made by a poisoned blade before the poison was extracted was a deadly mistake. One that she was simply unwilling to make with Catra. But she was losing blood. Too fast. Her earlier analysis must have been incorrect, the knife may have nicked her stomach. . . *shit.*
~~~

That cut her time in half; working quickly, she cleaned out the wound until she was *sure* there was no chance any poison could have been left behind, she placed her hand carefully over the cut, pooling her magic before releasing it through her palms, imagining, feeling the skin knit back together.

Catra began moaning and twisting as the pain radiated through her. This was Adora's least favourite part of her healing powers. They simply accelerated the healing process, that included forcing the injured person, Catra, to feel all the pain of her wound healing in an extremely short period of time. . . it was why she so rarely healed serious injuries so early. . . it was a torture she had felt countless times herself, a torture she was now inflicting on her heart, her Catra, simply because she was not willing to let her go. Even if Catra had seemed so at peace with the idea of dying in that clearing. "Please. . . stay with me, now. I don't think I want to be without you again. . . ever."

A hand came to rest on her cheek, making her jump, her magic faded, "who said -*cough*- you were gonna get rid of me so easily, my dearest warrior?"

"Catra. . ." her voice broke as the adrenaline flooded out of her body; Catra was conscious and *talking*. She began to shake, tears falling from her eyes. She threw herself onto Catra, holding her tight.

"Oof, what's gotten into you, huh? My savior breaking down right in front of me?" by the end of her tease, Catra's voice was tight. Lifting her head, she watched Catra's tears falling, matching her own, "gah! Look at me, crying like a baby. You're making me go soft!"

“I think it’s the other way around, Love.” Finally getting a hold of herself, Adora, still She-Ra, passed a hand over Catra, healing all of the bumps and bruises as she went, paying particular attention to the cut over Catra’s cheek; that particular cut didn’t need to be another ‘memory’ for Catra. “I’m sorry about your bodice. . . it. . . didn’t make it.”

“No shit! You nearly ripped it in half!”

“Y-you were *bleeding*! A lot!”

Snorting, Catra’s lips lifted into a sly smirk, “Guess that means I don’t need it anymore. . .” eyes wide, Adora watched as Catra lifted her mask from her forehead, throwing it to the side, then she crawled until she was sitting comfortably on her knees before placing her hands under the edge of her bodice, lifting the edge slowly revealing her toned stomach. The newly healed wound still pink above her right hipbone, but her eyes didn’t stay there long as the edge of Catra’s bindings were revealed and her mouth went dry. “Like what you see, Princess?”

Clearing her throat, she simply couldn’t tear her eyes from Catra’s soft skin as she pulled her bodice off, “y-yes.”

“Haha, I can see that. . .” Catra’s eyes roamed her, simply *eating her up,* “what are you waiting for, huh? Are you gonna help me, *Princess*?”

Quick note:

Yes, the next chapter will be a smutty continuation of this scene, but it won't be uploaded in this work. Id like to keep this story 'teen and up'

I've created a 'Warrior Woman AU' series; subscribe to the series (or to my user) to be notified upon upload of the NSFW chapter (will be a work of its own) – SERIES LINK, CLICK HERE

Chapter End Notes

I hope everyone enjoyed the angst, it was both fun and hurtful to type out.

As I said, the next chapter will be 18+ and posted as a separate work in the Warrior Woman AU series (linked above) so that this stays PG.
I should have it ready to go for May 15th. . . hopefully. . . Please, please only read the NSFW chapter if you're over 18. . . please. The next update (ch 13) will be on May 30, and will pick up right where we left off, you will be missing NO context :)

The Past is Never Past

Chapter Summary

> Lots of fluff, guilt, and working through trauma for pretty much everyone

Chapter Notes

> This is a long one, I had to cut my self off and move a bunch of work to the next chapter. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Making sure to keep pressure on her stomach, Adora hoisted Catra into her arms, "For the honour of Grayskull." Before her transformation was even complete, she was running as fast as her legs would take her.

Running out of these Whispering Woods.

Running across the field that never seemed so large as it did in this moment.

Running past Hathor and the others at the Villages gate.

Running straight to her cabin.

***

“Was that Adora that just ran by?” The man named Hathor turned to Bow, eyes utterly confused.

“Yeah, I think so.”

“Well, her face was definitely Adora, but that outfit. . . I’ve never seen it before. . . and her magical presence was immense. I’ve never felt her magic so strongly before. Almost like whatever has been diluting it has finally been lifted. . .” he stroked his chin thoughtfully, “interesting.”

“Wait you’ve never seen Sh-“

Cutting Bow off, she quickly diverted the subject, “magic is closely related to the mental state of the wielder, if Catra was hurt, it may be that she just lost control of her emotions and her magic by proxy. Its also possible that her clothing was soiled in the skirmish and she didn’t want to scare the children,” she offered, gesturing to the gaggle of children that had begun to emerge from what she presumed to be their bunker. “I assume the two running over here are yours?”

“Ah, yes, my twins. Odilon! Anne! My sweetlings, are you alright?”

Turning away from the reunion, she faced bow, “Glim, what was that about?”

“Bow. . . if he didn’t recognize She-Ra, he probably has never seen Adora transformed before. There may be a good reason for that.”

“Shoot, you’re right. I didn’t even think about that!” face palming, his shoulders slumped.

“I know, Bow.” Placing a placating hand on his shoulder, she observed the villagers, now mingling. Almost as if nothing had happened; as if this were a regular occurrence. . . “I’m sure Hathor is too distracted to make any sort of fuss over it. . . hey, doesn’t their reaction to this attack seem a little weird to you?”

Straightening out, Bow followed her gaze, “not really Glim, I know it’s been a while since you’ve been on a mission, but you had to know how bad things have gotten for the villages outside our perimeter. . . right?”

“Wait. . . you’re saying that Horde encampments and attacks like this are. . . normal?” She could feel his gaze burning a hole through the side of her head, mirroring the shame roiling in her gut. . . she hadn’t known, but she should have.

“I mean. . . yes?” Bows hand wrapped around her bicep urging her to face him, so she did. As the cold, tight lump settled in her gut, she looked to Bow for. . . support? No. Anger? No. *Anything*. But all she saw was pity, she was the ruler of Etheria and yet she

knew nothing about what was happening to her people outside of Brightmoon's protection.

This was her job, she was the Queen of Etheria, not just Brightmoon. And yet, here she stood, completely ignorant of the pain and suffering of those under her rule, "I didn't. . ."

"Glim-"

"No, Bow. You're right. I should have known. These people are my *responsibility*. . . I should have known."

"Its ok, Your Majesty, I'm sure you were having your own problems. At least, that's what Adora always tells us; 'even if those with power do not help, you are not powerless. Help yourselves.'" Looking over her shoulder, she found the source of the soft, reassuring voice. She was a beautiful young, green-skinned woman whose piercing eyes were aged well beyond her years.

"That's no excuse, really."

"I know. But what else is there? You weren't doing it maliciously, just plain ignorance." The girls eyes widened when she realized what she'd said, a blush exploding over her cheeks, "oh no, I've misspoken! I'm so sorry! Please forgive me."

“There’s nothing to forgive, you’re right. I was ignorant and I ought to have known better.” Turning to face the girl properly she gestured to Bow, “this is Bow, my best friend, and please, call me Glimmer. I don’t think I caught your name?”

“Oh, I’m Cara!”

“Great to meet you, Cara. Would you mind terribly if I asked you to take me to an adult, or anyone who knows what’s going on with the Horde influx in this area?”

“Of course, I can take you to my Father, but I know more than him. Adora’s been teaching me military tactics for years and I take over for her when she’s away.”

Bows mouth fell open, “no way, you can’t be more than 15!”

“I’m 12.”

The guilt in her gut tightened impossibly as she remembered her sheltered childhood. At 12 she was barely even allowed to leave the castle let alone plan and lead tactical missions. This girl had had to grow up way too early. “Alright then,” her voice was tight and she had to fight to get any words out around the lump in her throat, “tell me all about the situation, then. I’d like to help.”

"Of course. Let me take you to my dad anyway, he's the mayor and I run everything past him anyhow." Turning on her heal she headed deeper into the village without waiting for a response. Without much of a choice she numbly followed after Cara trying, and failing, to work through the situation. *How could she have been so blind*?

~~~ *Adora's house* ~~~

Opening her arms, Catra beckoned Adora over, watching as she crawled up to her. Waiting for Adora to get comfortable, she brought her arms and legs around to cradle her, tucking her face into Adora's neck, content to be in her arms. "Adora. . ."

"Yes, Love?"

"I-I think I'm falling in love with you. . ." The realization was slow, but it was there, slowly her eyes widened as fear took over her body, "that's not what I-. . . shit. I was *not* supposed to say that out loud, was I?"

"I honestly don't know. . ." her voice was quiet, too quiet. She was probably uncomfortable. *Of course, just as something was going her way, she just* had *to find a way to ruin it*.

Pulling her arms back from Adora she tried to sit up, but Adora's arms didn't budge, ". . . Adora, you need to let me go." No movement, "Adora?" nothing, just silence. Trying again, she pulled
~~~

at Adora's arms, and just as her hands unlatched, they circled even tighter around her waist forcing her back down onto the bed.

Determined not to embarrass herself any further she looked anywhere but the eyes she could feel boring into her. Looked anywhere but the face she saw every night in her dreams. Focusing on the wall, she waited.

"Catra, won't you look at me?"

"Can't do that, Princess."

***

"I-I think I'm falling in love with you. . ." she knew it was a heat of the moment confession, but nonetheless pure joy ripped through her at the confirmation that it really wasn't just her that was falling hopelessly in love. Then she felt Catra's body stiffen, and she knew that she wasn't ready to know that Adora felt the same, it would be too overwhelming and would likely just result in her shutting Adora out completely, "that's not what I-. . . shit. I was *not* supposed to say that out loud, was I?"

Resisting the urge to laugh at the notion that she had any more idea what the hell was happening than Catra she set her jaw to keep from smiling, "I honestly don't know. . ." her voice came out

strained with her effort to keep from laughing. She just hoped Catra didn't notice.

But of course, she did, and she didn't take it well, she pulled her arms back trying to sit up, to move away, but Adora wasn't about to let her get away, ". . . Adora, you need to let me go. . . Adora?" staying silent, she tried to find a response that wouldn't scare her off, and she came up with absolutely nothing. When Catra tried again to disentangle herself, she tightened her arms even more, encouraging Catra to lay down again.

They may be facing each other, but Catra was determinedly looking anywhere *but* in her direction, which, admittedly, hurt a little. "Catra, won't you look at me?"

"Can't do that, Princess." Her eyes may have stayed fixed on the wall, but the fear in her voice stopped the self pity churning in Adora's gut; this wasn't Catra falsely admitting to a love she didn't feel, this was just a fight-or-flight response to being in a vulnerable position. She had just confessed to falling in love, something Adora was sure she had never experienced before, of course she felt the need to escape.

"Catra, I know you don't want to hear it back, just listen to me for a minute, ok?" Finally, Catra's eyes landed on her own, indecision and confusion evident in her gaze, "you are allowed to feel alright. I am not, and will not ever judge you for feeling, *anything*. Ok?"

"Ok."

“Ok. Do you still want to get up, or lay here for a bit?”

“Lay here for a bit. . . please.”

Smiling, she adjusted so that Catra lay more comfortably at her side before lifting the sheet over them both, “right answer.”

***

Cara threw open the doors to a decent sized home, “hey, Daddy, we’ve got some visitors!”

“Who are they, Sweets?” a man’s voice could be heard from deeper within the house.

“The Queen and her friend.”

Glimmer could hear the man choke on whatever he had been eating before replying weakly, “what? I don’t think I heard you right. . .”

“I said, ‘The Queen and her friend.’”

Bow was trying valiantly to hold in his laughter. . . but also failing miserably as he ran out of the house laughing hysterically. Shaking her head, she looked back to the entryway just as a man appeared. His mouth dropped when he realized that Cara had, in fact, been telling him the truth, "Hi, I'm Glimmer, it's a pleasure to meet you."

Holding out her hand, she waited for him to regain his composure, "and you as well, Your Majesty, I'm Connlan."

"Cara says you're the mayor?"

"That I am."

"Great, I want to help with the Horde situation. Cara mentioned she knows the most about the situation but wanted to run everything by you first. Shall we sit?"

"Of course." He didn't move, "might I ask what precluded your visit to Ardglass, Your Majesty?" He threw his hands up, "not that I don't appreciate the help!"

"Of course you can ask, and please call me Glimmer, no need for any formalities. I am here as I met Adora in the woods and have asked her to help the Rebellion in our fight against the Horde. She has agreed to meet with my advisors."

“Very well, we can sit at the kitchen table if you’d like?”

“Lets.”

Suddenly Cara smiled brightly and waved frantically at the doorway, “hey Mama! How was work?”

“Oh, fine sweety, I thought I’d head home a bit early. Part of the outer wall of the shop was blown off in the attack today so I had to close down.” Without looking up or missing a beat the woman leaned down to untie her boots, “now, can one of you tell me why there is a strange young man outside our house rolling around laughing?”

“That would be my friend, Bow.”

The woman’s face shot up when she spoke, surprise evident at the unfamiliar voice in her home. “By the Gods, you’re Queen Glimmer!”

“Yes, my apologies for the intrusion.”

“No, no. No need to apologize Your Majesty!”

"Just Glimmer is fine." She smiled, hoping to ease the woman's excitement as her arms flailed about trying to fix herself, "you're Cara's Mother?"

"Ah! Yes, I'm Frieshia!"

"Pleasure to meet you Frieshia, we're just about to go to the kitchen to discuss the Horde encampment, would you like to join?"

"Oh, no need. I don't want to bother you all. I'll be around, just holler if you need anything, alright?"

"Yes, thank you." Turning to Cara, she smiled politely, "let me just go grab Bow and we can sit down?"

"Works for me!"

Heading out the front door she found Bow exactly where Frieshia had seen him, lying on the ground laughing, holding his sides as if in pain. "Bow!" She peeked around, there were a few villagers eyeing them curiously, "get up! You're scaring the locals!"

Bow coughed trying to compose himself, "di-did you hear him, Glim! He was so *shocked*!" He delved into another fit of giggles, "I *love* that girl, she's hilarious!"

“Yes, Bow, I like her too. C’mon, we’ve got to go discuss what to do about this encampment,” offering her hand, she waited.

Suddenly serious, he took her hand, pulling himself up, “Lets get strategizing, then.” All of a sudden, she was reminded just why she had fallen for this guy, he could be the laugh of the party. Finding the humor in any situation, master at making her feel better. But, when a situation such as this arose, he was a serious as she’d ever seen him. No hint of the laughter that had just had him rolling on the ground. She was in love with her best friend, but he could never know, and would, *could* never love her back. It just wasn’t in the cards for them.

Together they walked back into the house, following Cara and Connlan to the kitchen and began strategizing.

***

Her eyes closed, Adora was completely blissed out as Catra’s claws lightly massaged her scalp, her free hand running along her waist to her hip and back. She heard Catra huff and her hands faltered, forcing her eyes open she gave Catra a questioning look, which was all she could muster at the moment. Huffing again, Catra resumed her scratching, “I have seen no less than 10 people come up to your door, stand there for a minute, then walk away. I think they need you, Princess.”

“Hmm.”

“Adora? Are you awake?”

“Mhm. . .”

“No you’re not!”

“Mhm. . .”

“Oh yeah, what did I just say?”

Opening her eyes, Adora tried to register exactly what Catra had asked, “too tired.”

Sighing, Catra tried to think, “I know your healing me wiped you out, how about you stay here and get some sleep and I go see what they need?”

“M’kay,” Adora placed a warm hand on her cheek, pulling her into a clumsy kiss.

“Ill see you later?”

“Mhm.”

***

Extracting herself from Adora’s embrace she looked around for her clothing, putting on her undergarments and trousers before eyeing her destroyed bodice, “shit. . .” Looking around, she spotted a small dresser in the corner. Making her way over she pulled out the top drawer revealing an impressive assortment of weapons ranging from daggers to magical staffs. Opening the next drawer she found what she needed, folded neatly on the right were 2 pairs of grey pants identical to those Adora wore regularly, and one black pair, which Catra swiped. On the left were 2 long sleeves identical to the one she wore regularly, “jeez Adora, soldier to the core, huh?” Not that she could say anything, she didn’t have a change of clothes at all. Pulling off her blood-soaked trousers she fingered the hole from the knife blade, “son of a bitch, she couldn’t have aimed a little higher? I liked these pants.” Huffing she threw them to the side before sliding into the pants she swiped from Adora, they weren’t loose, but they definitely weren’t fitted, but they’d have to do. She pulled the shirt on, then eyed herself in the mirror, the pants could pass for her own, but the shirt was no doubt Adora’s and there was no hiding that, it was extremely baggy on her and looked exactly like the one Adora wore. *Oh well. . .*

Pulling on her armoured plates, foot coverings, and headpiece she snuck a look over to Adora. She looked absolutely wiped, the kind of tired that came after a particularly long and arduous training session. Grabbing some of her weapons she began to secure them under her shirt, and anywhere she could fit them before heading to the door.

~~More art - click here for a visual :)~~

Taking a deep breath, she let her eyes trace Adora's face one last time before forcing herself out the door. . . right into an incredibly tall, incredibly beautiful pink skinned woman who somehow looked familiar. *This must be Kamila's mother*, "oh! Uh, hi. . . I was just looking for Adora, is she here?"

The woman looked down at her awkwardly, as if trying not to look down *on* her, "she's asleep, and I don't think she'll be awake enough to help you just yet."

"Oh."

An awkward silence hung between them as she tried to think of what to say to the woman, "I'm um-uh, Catra." Jutting her hand out awkwardly at the woman, she waited for the sneer and rejection. But it never came, instead the woman gently shook her hand, a light, lyrical laugh escaping her mouth.

"I'm sorry, I'm not laughing at you, its just. . . I know who you are, Catra, you've stayed with us before, many years ago. I'm Freja."

The awkward silence returned, "I uhm, don't remember the town, sorry."

“Oh, no worries.”

And silence. . . “do you-uh, think I might be able to help you? Just until Adora’s awake?”

“Do you know any first aid? Our healer is extremely busy and I was just going to grab Adora for some help.”

“I do.”

“Great! Follow me?”

A light feeling exploded in her chest at the first civil conversation she had held with someone other than a child or Adora. Trying to keep her composure, she followed Freja to what she assumed was the infirmary. Entering the large building she saw numerous cots filled with people injured to various degrees, she looked over to Freja, “where should I start?”

“Can I be a bit selfish?”

“Oh-uhm, sure?”

“Could I get your help with bandaging up my partner, Mina?”

“Yes, of course. Where are they?”

“Just over here in a back room.” Heading off into a secluded hallway, she beckoned Catra to follow. Instinctually, Catra felt for her weapons, this wasn’t the first time she had been lured into a secluded area, and she wasn’t about to be caught vulnerable. But she followed, and when they made it to a door, Freja opened it and Catra could immediately smell blood, and a lot of it. Still keeping a careful eye on the woman, she entered the room. The woman lying on the bed looked half dead, skin carrying an unhealthy white colour, sweat covering her forehead, “oh my,” rushing over, she checked the wounds, “these are all partially healed, what happened?”

Looking up to Freja, she saw the sheen of tears, “it’s bad, isn’t it?”

“Yes, but she’ll be fine. What exactly are these from?” trying to keep her voice calm, she had an idea what, or *who* inflicted the cuts and burns criss-crossing her torso, and she was trying to keep her anger down and her voice steady. She had many scars that looked exactly like this.

“There was an incredibly powerful sorceress with them that first night they came, she was using this odd red magic and shadows to fight. It was awful. I was able to get her away from Mina, but only barely-“ her voice breaking, the woman looked like she was holding back tears.

“Just as I thought. She’ll be fine, but there may be scarring.”

“Oh, I don’t care about that, I just want her to be ok!”

“Got it.” Getting to work, she started cleaning the wounds, so familiar, and yet not on her own skin. She was just grateful that the woman appeared to be passed out and wasn’t feeling any pain.

They sat in silence for a long time as Catra worked, but for the last few minutes Freja had been pacing, almost as if trying to psych herself up to saying something, and Catra knew exactly what she was going to ask, “yes, I am familiar with the pattern of her injuries.”

She stopped pacing and turned to Catra, “can I ask why that is?” she chewed on her lip, “I know you were trained in the Horde, but I have a feeling that woman is not someone everyone in the Horde encounters. They all seemed. . . afraid of her for some reason.”

“They are.” Squeezing out her cloth and rewetting it, she breathed, trying to find the words. “That was Shadow Weaver.”

“You’re in incredible pain, dear.”

Turning to Freja she saw the same glowing markings and white eyes that Kamila had had before grabbing her. “You’re reading my thoughts?”

“No, just feeling your emotions. I find it incredibly rude to reads someone’s thoughts without their consent.” Her markings faded, but her eyes stayed white, “no need to continue, Catra. I can tell from your emotional state that this Shadow Weaver is not someone you want to discuss. Especially with me.”

Turning back to her cleaning, she whispered, “thank you.”

***

“They’ve been here for about 5 days, and there are roughly 80 soldiers and 20 ‘higher ups,’ which we currently assume are Force Captains or higher.” Cara’s maturity level still amazed Glimmer, if you didn’t know, you’d think she was 18-20 years old, easily.

“There really isn’t anything above Force Captain though,” Bow looked confused, trying to sort through what he knew of the Horde and their ranking system.

“Yes, but there is one sorceress that they all seem to report to.”

Cara may not know who that is, but Glimmer had a bad feeling she knew exactly who that sorceress was, “long black hair, odd

face mask, long dark robes?”

“Uh-yeah?”

Shit, it has to be, “. . . Shadow Weaver. . .”

“Shadow Weaver?”

Shit, shit, shit, “Second in Command of the Horde, only person above her being Hordak. Nasty piece of work. You said she’s here?”

“Yeah, she pretty much ended the fight on the day they came, Freja had to pull out some magic that she’s never had to use on this planet. She was out of commission for days, fighting Shadow Weaver off nearly killed her.” Cara’s voice was nonchalant, but her eyes were growing worried as the gravity of the situation settled on them all.

“Is she still here? Have you seen her since?”

“No. Not in the 5 days since.”

“Still, something we have to take into consideration. Bow, you’ve fought her before, right?” There was a chance she was no longer

here, but there was also a good chance that she was still. In either event, they needed someone who knew how she fought. They needed to be ready for the event that she was still here.

"Not personally. I have seen her fight though. . . from a distance."

"Hmm, probably not the best to go by then."

"I wasn't in the fight 5 days ago. Maybe we can talk to Mina and Freja? They're the ones who fought her." Cara had brought her hand up to her chin, deep in thought.

"Maybe. . ."

"Uhm. . . why don't we ask Catra?" Bows tone was matter of fact, and she was embarrassed to say that she hadn't even thought to ask the woman that had spent a good portion of her youth under the woman's command.

"Catra?"

"Small woman that was with us earlier. She was raised in the Horde, specifically under Shadow Weaver." Turning to Cara, Bow tried to describe Catra with the little they actually knew about her upbringing.

“What? You mean that girl who escaped? She’s here?” Connlan seemed to at least know of her, but by the tone of his voice, he was suspicious.

“Yes, we came across her, Adora, and Kamila in the woods yesterday.”

There was an uneasy silence as she let the Mayor and Cara mull over the information, “I hate to be the one to say it, but can we really trust her? She was in the Horde for a long time, and I know she’s been out for a long time too, but could there possibly be any loyalty left? Anything that might lead her to lying to us?” Connlan turned to her, lowering his voice as if he didn’t want to be overheard.

“W-“

Before she could get a word out, she heard the door open behind her and Adora’s voice came along with it, “I trust her with my life. She has given no indication of loyalty, or even a positive thought towards the Horde forces. Quite the opposite actually.”

“O-oh, hi, Adora. You don’t say?” Bringing his hand to his chin, Connlan thought on that. He and his daughter were very much alike in the way they thought, hand on their chins, even their expressions, “well alright then. If you trust her, I trust her. Cara?”

“Hey, if Addy says so, I listen. She’s never been wrong before.”

“Thank you.”

“Now, about you, Addy. Why do you look like you got run over by one of the horses?”

Her blunt questions and serious tone caught her and Bow off guard and she had to look away to compose herself. Bow on the other hand burst out laughing, “Bow!”

“What?”

Rolling her eyes at him she turned back to Adora, who really did look like she’d been trampled. “Are you alright?”

“I am fine, just tired.” Pulling a chair out she plopped down rubbing her eyes as she went, “so, care to fill me in? Why do you need Catra?”

***

Leaving Connlan’s house she had a nervous feeling coursing through her body. Yes, Glimmer had said she and Bow would help them fight off the Horde encampment that had apparently come only days after she and Kamila had gone off to her ship to train, she was worried about Catra. Glimmer was certain that the

sorceress that had nearly wiped out the village was Shadow Weaver, Second in Command of the Horde, but it wasn't her magical prowess Adora worried about, it was the affect she seemed to have on Catra. Every scar and every bad memory that Catra had confided in her about was from this woman. She really wasn't sure how Catra would react to the news that she may be in the encampment, she had told Connlan she trusted Catra implicitly, and she did, but she just wasn't sure if she would help or retreat into herself. Sighing she set out to find Catra, first checking the stables to see if Melog was with Swift Wind. They were. "Hey Swifty, you doing all right?"

"Yeah, we didn't fight at all, just snuck around back to get Kamila to Marcus."

"Good, so she's fine?"

"Not a scratch on her!"

"Thank you, bud." Running her hand along his mane she gave him a good scratch before turning to Melog, "can you sense where Catra is by any chance?"

Melog nodded and began walking out of the stables.

"Ill come by later to see you, Swifty." Following after Melog, the nervous feeling only got worse. *What if Catra couldn't help them? There were parts of her memory that she'd never regained from*

past brushes as a prisoner. What if Catra was the same? What if her brain blocked out her time spent with Shadow Weaver?

Meow, looking down at Melog she realized that they had come up on the infirmary. Thanking him she took a deep breath before walking through the doors, taking in her surroundings. Searching for an unruly head of hair she scanned the room. . . then again. . . and again. Catra wasn't in here? That couldn't be? "Hey Adora, you look a little lost. Are you ok?"

Turning to the voice she saw Sayyida staring back at her cleaning off his hands. He must have just finished helping one of the injured villagers, "Hey kid, you seen Catr-uh-a short dark-haired woman come through here? She would have had a tail and cats' ears?"

"Oh! Yeah, someone like that came in with Freja a while ago. Haven't seen her in a couple hours, but I think she headed to one of the back rooms. Probably helping Mina. She's in the back hall 3rd door on the right."

"Thanks bud. You been learning a lot?"

"Yes! Not great circumstance, but great learning at least!"

Chuckling she turned to look for Catra once again. Heading to the back hall she stopped when she heard voices coming from Mina's room, *"can I ask why you're wearing one of Adora's shirts?"*

"O-oh-uh. . ."

"Ah, I see."

"N-no, its not-"

"Oh, dear. Your feelings are too strong to deny, please don't try to cover them up. Adora is a lovely woman, and so are you."

"I-uh. . . thanks."

Knocking lightly on the door she watched as it opened to reveal Freja smiling knowingly at her, of course, Freja would have known she had been outside the door, "hey Free, how's Mina doing?"

"Oh, I think she'll be ok. Catra here is doing an amazing job patching her up and keeping me calm."

"Good, that's great." Peeking over at Catra, she tried to keep her emotions under control as she let her eyes wander over her back, admiring the sight of Catra in her clothing.

"My, my, the two of you."

Smiling sheepishly she looked to Mina, assessing her injuries, “hey Catra, how’s she doing.”

“She’ll be fine with a little healing. Wounds are clean if you’re feeling up to it?”

“Of course.” Leaning over Mina, she let her magic pool, releasing it over her letting the wounds mend leaving only pinkish marks that would soon heal. Almost as soon as her magic receded, Mina began to wake, “mind if I grab Catra from you?”

Freja didn’t look at her, eyes fixed on Mina, “yes, yes, thank you.” Finally looking at her, Freja gave her a quick kiss on the cheek, “so I’ve heard through the grape vine that Kamila is with Marcus? Was she hurt at all?”

“She is and she wasn’t. Swift Wind was able to bring her in round back.”

“Amazing. Thank you so much, dear.”

Before she finished her sentence she was rushing to Mina’s side, holding her face gently. Turning to Catra she held her hand out, “follow me?”

***

"Can I ask why you're wearing one of Adora's shirts?"

Her heart dropped as she tried to think of something, *anything* to say, but she really didn't have an explanation for why she was wearing Adora's clothing, "o-oh-uh. . ." yes, hers had been soaked in blood, hence the new clothing, but that didn't explain why she was in *Adora's* clothing, especially since they really didn't fit her.

"Ah, I see." Heat exploded on her cheeks as she realized Freja could sense her feelings. And she knew exactly what they were saying.

"N-no, its not-" *It is.*

A lyrical chuckle sounded behind her that instantly calmed her, this woman was so charming. She was sure it was just the effects of her magic, but even so, Catra was at ease with Freja. "Oh, dear. Your feelings are too strong to deny, please don't try to cover them up. Adora is a lovely woman, and so are you."

Her hands faltered as those words registered in her mind. . . *she thinks I'm lovely?* "I-uh. . . thanks."

A light knock sounded at the door and as soon as Freja opened it she was assaulted with Adora's scent. Taking a moment she let it

sink in, coming back at the tail end of their conversation, ". . . my, my, the two of you."

Adora's footsteps came closer and she peeked up taking in her features, "hey Catra," her heart skipped at the way Adora said her name, "how's she doing?"

Shaking her head slightly she got back to the job at hand, "she'll be fine with a little healing." Looking over Adora's features again she noticed just how tired she looked still. Her eyes looked tired but determined. "Wounds are clean if you're feeling up to it?"

"Of course." *Of course she'd say that, idiot.* Adora leaned over the woman, and she watched as a low glow engulfed her and the wounds on Mina closed. "Mind if I grab Catra from you?"

She didn't hear the rest of their conversation as she watched the energy visibly drain from Adora's features. . . her magic really did a number on her. *Maybe because she keeps using She-Ra's magic without a full transformation? Why doesn't she just transform?* "follow me?" zoning back in she notices Adora's outstretched hand waiting for her. Accepting her hand she let Adora pull her from the floor.

When she was vertical, Adora put an arm around her shoulders and led her out, when they were out of earshot she turned to her, "you can lean on me. I can see that you're still tired."

They continued to walk in silence to the door, but Adora eventually leaned against her, sagging slightly as they went. Walking out of the infirmary she didn't stop until they made it back to Adora's bungalow. Closing the door behind her she placed her hands on her hips, "so, you wanna fill me in on why you're wandering about when you're clearly *not* fine?"

Adora's hand slipped behind her neck and avoided eye contact, "I-uh-I. . . couldn't sleep after you left. . ."

". . . what?"

"After you left, I just couldn't get comfortable. No matter how tired I was I just couldn't sleep." Adora's eyes flashed to her own before quickly moving away, a dark blush exploding over her cheekbones, "I'm sorry. This has never happened before. I just didn't know what else to do so I got up to help."

Tsking at her she pinched Adora's nose lightly, "you should have just asked me to stay."

"Ouch. . . I know. . . so, can you? Stay I mean?"

"I can." Pulling out her hair tie she tsked again, "I swear, Princess, you'll be bald by thirty if you keep your hair so tightly wound," moving on she pulled her shirt over her head and arms, then her boots and pants taking notice of her complete lack of weapons. *Odd*. Moving onto her own clothes she quickly stripped everything

save for her undergarments and led Adora to the bed watching her fall unceremoniously next to the unmade covers. “You really do need to sleep, huh?”

Laying down next to her she pulled the covers over them both before turning to face Adora. When her eyes opened and the slow recognition registered, Adora pulled her flush against her so she wrapped her arms where she could reach and began running her nails in light circles on Adora’s back, “hmmm, much better.” And then she was out, breathing evening out, body falling limp. Taking her cue, Catra let her mind wander before falling asleep herself.

***

Waking in a cold sweat she shot up in bed eyes darted about searching each nook and cranny for danger, but all she saw was her room, her clothing in a pile on the floor, and Catra waking sluggishly at her side, “mmh-dora? Are you alright?”

“Fine. Just. . . a nightmare.” Falling back to the pillows she waited for the adrenaline rush to pass, “it’s been a while since I used that much magic in such a short time. I guess I couldn’t protect my mind.”

“Protect your mind?”

“Hmm. Before I came to Etheria, I was a soldier in a galactic armed force, specially trained in tracking and reconnaissance.”

Shifting her arms under Catra's head she took comfort in the easy contact, "I was young and barely out of training when an opportunity to take a reconnaissance mission came across my path and I took it without a second thought. My commander warned that there had been numerous reports of allied forces sending their best, but never any reports of their return, but I thought I was above it all, I was top of my training class after all and I wielded She-Ra's magic. Nothing could get to me. I was wrong."

Catra's hand cupped her cheek, her thumb rubbing her eyebrow, she hadn't even noticed they had drawn together. Taking a breath and giving a small, insincere smile she continued, "I landed on their planet with no trouble, textbook landing and successful start to the mission. What I didn't know was that they had known I was there since the beginning and had proceeded to play with my mind for days afterword before eventually capturing me. Their mind games were like nothing I'd ever experienced in my training and had nearly driven me insane, by the end of the first week I couldn't remember my own name, and learned after that I had dropped all contact with my base only 3 days in. They had thought I had died there. There was no trace of me, not my communications equipment, not my ships beacon, or even my vitals." Taking a moment to breathe she let herself feel Catra's hands still rubbing along her eyebrow lightly. Felt her tail tighten ever so slightly on her thigh, "I was there for 4 months and I remember only the first week. I 'woke up' months later right next to my ship and got out of there as quick as I could and it was another 2 months before I tracked down my Base as they had moved on. After that I can really only remember snippets. The scar on my back," she paused, remembering the burn as the medics seared her skin, "that was given to me by my people." Catra's finger faltered on her eyebrow, but only for a moment, almost unnoticeable, but she didn't speak. "I was later told there were strange markings and scripture scrolled across the entirety of my shoulder and they didn't want to risk any exposure so they did a scan for any trackers then burned the entire area in case

they were magical in nature. They offered to show me a picture of the symbols in case they tripped something in my memory, they asked every year, but even a decade later I could not bring myself to look at them, I probably still couldn't." The adrenaline rush had yet to subside, rather just continued making her feel like running, but her body felt so heavy that she wasn't sure she'd even make it out of the bed without collapsing on the floor, "I had violent nightmares for years after, waking up in a cold sweat, sometimes screaming for mercy. Every night. I later found out that, with She-Ra's magic, I could sort of 'cocoon' my mind. I haven't had a nightmare since. Well, until today. . ."

The silence hung between them for a few minutes, neither had anything to say, but Catra's hand stayed on her cheek her thumb smoothing down her eyebrow and her tail stayed firmly gripping her thigh. Catra huffed, "well, I knew you hadn't had an easy life Princess, but just how hard. . . I had no idea. . ." Catra's hand fell from her face before she rolled on top of her. Their bodies fit together perfectly, "I don't remember much of my childhood, even less of my time in the Horde. Some of my scars are just blank memories, but some aren't." She moved so that the long scars on each of her forearms were visible, "these long ones, I remember, happened during a training exercise, got caught in some metal and broke a bunch of bones in each arm." Pushing off her chest, Catra sat up so that she was straddling her, turning to point at her right hip at a large scar ranging from her hip to her knee, "this was another training 'accident,' Nisha, another Cadet cut open a bot and battery acid sprayed out at me. Ate through the training uniform instantly." Catra didn't even try to hide the sneer, "didn't get to see the medic until I had cleaned up the mess, and then the snooty bitch refused to help because I had waited too long to see her and it would be 'too hard to clean now.' Ended up spending the night cleaning and dressing it myself."

Catra's breathing got heavier as she seethed, "Catra. . ."

Her hand shot out, stopping Adora, "No. I've got a couple more."

"Catra-"

"I'm fine, Adora." Taking a few deep breaths, Catra's eyes opened, determined. Pointing to numerous puckered scars along her abdomen and chest, she started again, "these, Nisha, again, and her friends decided that my beating them all in training that day was a go ahead to gang up on me and 'teach me a lesson.'" Catra continued looking over her scars as the rage began to build in Adora's gut, this Nisha, she was going to pay. "these are from a freak storm where these weird fireball things began raining from the sky and I was forced to 'save' the training equipment." Catra's eyes flashed to hers, indecision crossing through the depths. Holding her hand out, she offered some comfort, and Catra took it, placing her hand in Adora's and squeezing. "The rest I don't really remember, but most are from Shadow Weaver and honestly, I don't really *want* to remember. . ."

"I know Catra." Sitting up she pulled Catra into a tight embrace. Her muscles screamed at the movement but she wasn't about to let go, especially at the way Catra clung to her, her body shuddering. "I know."

They sat like that for a long time. Long enough that she actually felt her energy returning slowly, she'd rested long enough she supposed. And yet, for once, she didn't feel the need to get up and help right away, because the one who needed her most was sitting in her lap still clinging to her tightly.

***

As much as she wanted to tell Adora, she couldn't bring herself to say she actually remembered how she got a lot of the scars from Shadow Weaver. Sure, there were some she truly had suppressed and couldn't remember, but the look of suppressed sadness and rage on Adora's face. . . she just couldn't continue. So now she sat, completely content and safe on Adora's lap surrounded by her love contemplating whether or not telling her would hurt her more than not telling her. She wasn't really sure how this 'trusting another person' worked. "Adora. . ."

"Hmm?"

"I lied. . . I do remember."

"I know."

They sat for another while, just soaking in the company, and she almost fell asleep again, but Adora moved a hand to rub her cheek, "Catra?"

"Mhm?"

“Shadow Weaver might be in the encampment and we need your help.”

Chapter End Notes

I’m hoping ill to have the next chapter ready to upload by June 30th and get back to the regular schedule – stay tuned on my twitter/Instagram for updates :)

Sweet Tooth

Chapter Summary

There are some sickeningly sweet catradora moments to feed the soul. . . mixed with some trauma.

Im trying to move the story along, hopefully the pace will pick up a bit. Ive got A LOT of ideas :)

Chapter Notes

Its late, I know, but I was SUPER busy yesterday. My life has gotten so unnecessarily busy in the last week (and will be for a while). . . The art for this update is not done yet - ill add the link when I have time to finish

As always, please be aware, there is swearing, mild descriptions of past trauma/abuse, and very mild sexual connotations.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As much as she wanted to tell Adora, she couldn't bring herself to say she actually remembered how she got a lot of the scars from Shadow Weaver. Sure, there were some she truly had suppressed and couldn't remember, but the look of suppressed sadness and rage on Adora's face. . . she just couldn't continue. So now she sat, completely content and safe on Adora's lap surrounded by her love contemplating whether or not telling her would hurt her more than not telling her. She wasn't really sure how this 'trusting another person' worked. "Adora. . ."

"Hmm?"

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"I know."

They sat for another while, just soaking in the company, and she almost fell asleep again, but Adora moved a hand to rub her cheek, "Catra?"

"Mhm?"

"Shadow Weaver might be in the encampment and we need your help."

***

Well. . . that's one way to wake her up, she didn't move an inch, "what?" She'd known there was a chance Shadow Weaver was actually here. Freja *had* described her magic to a T, but still, it hadn't actually registered.

Shadow Weaver was here. She wasn't one to leave anything unfinished. Especially since the town had fought back. . . and won. If only momentarily. For now, her target would be Mina, Freja had jumped in to protect her, so she must be important to her. She would target Mina to get to Freja, disrupt her magic and get the advantage. That's how she worked, and its exactly how she had taught Catra to take down her enemies. Get into their

mind and rip them apart from the inside, the best way to get to your enemies: go after their heart; their families. It was brilliant and worked flawlessly. Every time. It had even worked on Catra, the one time she had allowed someone into her heart since losing her family, her childhood. . .

Nisha.

Adora's hand fell back to hold her once again, "Shadow Weaver was here 5 days ago in the initial raid, and she might still be. No one has seen her since, but we need to plan for her being here. No one else really had information on her. Can you help?"

She should have seen that coming. . . she was one of the few people on Etheria that had intimate knowledge of the inner workings of the evil bitch. Her immediate reaction: *run*. But the hand on her hip that continued to pet down her sides, and the calm gaze that held her own – hopeful, but not forceful – she knew Adora would accept if she chose to run, but her body simply refused to listen to her brain. She was firmly planted on the bed in Adora's arms soaking in the attention, but her brain continued to scream at her; *run! Get as far away as possible! Put as much distance between yourself and the witch! RUN!* "I-uhm-I. . ."

"You don't need to." Her voice was even, comforting. Not demanding at all, and that's exactly what Catra needed. She just had to work through her instinctual response.

"I know. . . I just," she tucked her face into the crook of Adora's neck and let it ground her. Adora's scent, her strength, her even

breathing. “My brain is telling me to run. Run and never look back. . .” she took another deep breath, “I can’t think clearly. Not right now. All I can think is to put as much distance as possible between me and. . . and what will the villagers think if I-if I just up and leave. . .”

“Catra,” her voice was soft and was accompanied by fingers softly tracing her ear, “what they think doesn’t matter. The only thing that matters to me is if *you* are comfortable and *you* are willing. The Horde encampment can be taken down without digging into your past. Shadow Weaver *can* be contained without intimate knowledge of her fighting style. Its just *easier* to have this information.” Adora’s fingers continued to ghost along her ear, distracting her from the overwhelming urge to run, “but you know this already, you’re just overwhelmed. That happens and its completely normal.”

She took another deep breath, then pulled her head back to catch Adora’s gaze again. “I will. Just. . . c-uh-can you stay with me?” Everything in her screamed that she was letting go of too much control, everything but her heart. Her heart was saying one thing: *Adora*. So, she listened.

“Yes-“

“Sorry, that was a weird req-“ her body froze, her mouth refusing to work. She just laid there looking at Adora, eyes wide with. . . surprise? No. Fear? Not really. Maybe a mix of the two? Maybe a cocktail of everything?

“It wasn’t weird, Catra. I’m happy to stay with you.” Almost at once, her body stopped screaming at her and her heart sang. She couldn’t help the smile that broke through. “There she is,” Adora was smiling too, eyes sparkling. Now that she was paying attention, her eyes were *actually* sparkling, white flecks dancing within the blue.

“Adora. . . your eyes,” she couldn’t tear her gaze away from the white highlights swirling in the sea of blue, almost as if it were calling to her.

Adora blinked, almost as if she were trying to gauge what was happening, “She-Ra. . .” she wasn’t speaking to Catra anymore, her eyes held a faraway look.

“She-Ra?” She’d almost forgot about Adora’s magical counterpart. Her magic must be what’s calling to her. She let her eyes continue to trace the swirling pattern in Adora’s irises, mesmerized by the magic sparking in them.

“. . . Yeah. That-that’s never happened before,” Adora’s voice was surprised, but also curious, but Catra wasn’t really registering her words fully, her focus solely on the white leaking into her eyes, slowly taking over the calming blue.

“What do you mean?”

“She-Ra is trying to. . . um, surface?” forcing herself to focus on Adora, she registered her words.

“Adora, what are you talking about?”

“She-Ra is trying to trigger a transformation.” Adora didn’t seem panicked, just confused, so she stamped out her own rising panic in favour of keeping her cool.

“Oh. Is that bad?” *Nice, nonchalant.* Her voice was filled with unease and, of course, Adora picked up on it, her eyes growing a bit worried. She could tell when Adora started to fight the transformation, solely for Catra’s sake. Her body got stiff, her hands stopped petting her sides in favour of gripping her hips firmly – not painfully, just firm – the white receding slightly before coming back, forcefully this time.

“I’m not too sure. She’s never done something like this be. . . fore,” Adora’s voice trailed off and she gasped, her eyes going completely white, shining, “Catra, just stay calm. I’m letting her out.”

Forcing her muscles to relax, she closed her eyes when the light emanating from Adora became blinding. She felt the chest against her broaden and the hand on her waist grow. Adora’s hands resumed her earlier ministrations though, caressing her ears and waist softly, but her presence somehow changed, Adora’s scent mixed with the spicy smell of magic. Opening her eyes cautiously they immediately locked onto She-Ra’s inquisitive stare, “Adora?”

"No. I am She-Ra." She-Ra's voice *was* Adora's but held a note that was distinctively *not* Adora. Her features were flat, no emotion at all. Now that she thought about it, her voice was monotonous as well, likely the difference she noticed.

"Oh." Her muscles stiffened unconsciously.

"Adora is here, watching." Her eyes flashed blue momentarily, and she saw Adora in them, "*I will not come forth again unless called on, after this. I have one inquiry, if you will hear it?"*

"Um. . . ok?" what an odd way to put it. From the surprise in Adora's voice at She-Ra's insistence she knew that this was probably the first time she had 'taken over' her like this. It was still troubling though, that she had this kind of power over Adora. In any sense, she was curious as to what She-Ra wanted from her.

"I see you are an honest, truly caring individual, Magicat. I see it in your eyes. But can you vow to me that you will not take advantage of Adora's trusting, kind nature?"

"Of course. I swear I will not only *never* take advantage of her, but I will also protect her with my life. She has my loyalty." An odd question, true, but it made sense in a way. She would want to keep Adora safe, to keep herself safe. Something about the intonation though seemed. . . *personal* somehow. Almost as if she truly cared abut Adora's wellbeing. . .

"As she has mine. I did not choose her lightly. I rarely pledge my loyalty to one so young as she was, nor before the time of my previous partner is up. Mara is strong and was an excellent host, but Adora called to me, and so I will serve her – and you – for the rest of our time together."

"Thank you." It seemed like the right thing to say. She had so many questions, but it seemed She-Ra was here to give her some sort of message. Not answer questions.

"Adora, and you, can call on me at any time."

"What do you mean?"

"Adora, she is strong, but even with a full transformation, she can only harness a fraction of my power. After-" She-Ra paused, a worried expression passing over her features before they fell flat once again, "after her encounter with an old enemy of mine, they placed a harness on her powers. She can now only access my full power if she allows me to take control."

That situation. . . it sounded so familiar. . . "that reconnaissance mission. Her first."

"Yes."

“The scripture on her back. . . it *was* magical in nature?” Her mind whirled. *What the hell had happened to Adora on that planet?*

"No. He cannot control magic, and so he avoids it at all costs. The scripture is purely scientific in nature, and even I cannot remove its affects."

He? “Can I?” it was a long shot, but it was worth questioning.

"I do not know. To counter science, you will need science. Just remember, you can call on me as well, Catra."

What an. . . odd thing to say. . . “ok?” hoping for some elaboration on that, she quirked an eyebrow, waiting.

"All you need to remember is to say, 'For the honour of Grayskull' and I will come." Well. . . that didn’t help.

And then she was gone, the transformation reversed leaving Adora with an odd look in her eye, “so-“

“Well, that was-

“Catra-“

“Something-“

She huffed out a laugh, chuckling with Adora, before gesturing for her to continue. “So, that was weird, right?”

“A little, yeah.” She brought her hand up to rub her thumb over Adora’s cheek, “but I think it was needed. She answered a few questions I didn’t even know I had.”

Adora’s nose scrunched and a small smile graced her lips, “me too, actually.”

“So. . . you were there, then? I mean, you could hear us?” She assumed so, when She-Ra had brought out Adora, she seemed so close to the surface after that. Seemed almost as if she were talking to both of them, not *just* She-Ra.

“Yeah, it was weird. I was in control of my body, well, my hands and eyes, but she was speaking and thinking for me.”

“Oh. Good, cause you were still rubbing my ear and it was a little distracting. . . and a bit weird if it were her.” She chuckled lightly, ruffling Adora’s hair. “Well, you? I-uh, I’m a little confused on the dynamic still. Who is who. How do I know who I’m talking to. . .”?

“I am She-Ra, and She-Ra is me. Just, she can. . . *come out? Surface?* I guess?” Adora’s eyebrows came together in thought, “When I am She-Ra, its just me. She’s never taken over before. . .” She nodded, more to herself than Catra, “yeah, those are the right words.”

“Ok. So, I don’t need to worry about laying in bed with an immortal magical being again, then?” she tried to keep her voice even – its not like she was afraid of being alone with She-Ra, its more the fact that she was uncomfortable with the fact of cuddling someone aside from Adora, even if it were still Adora’s body – but her voice trembled anyway.

“Yeah.” Adora’s voice was concerned, but she seemed to sense that Catra needed to work through this on her own. She made no moves to crowd Catra or ask what was wrong. She already knew.

Shaking her head, she decided it was time to get over herself – Adora had an immortal Warrior Princess that allowed her to use her magic so long as they were connected, that was it. She could always ask about the details later, right now they had bigger problems, “ok, right, onto more important subjects. Your time in captivity, do you know *anything* about your captors? Do you remember *anything* at all? She-Ra didn’t mention *who* captured you, just that ‘he’ was an old enemy. Does that ring a bell at all?”

“Yeah. . . I don’t know. I still don’t remember a thing.” Adora’s brows furrowed more. She looked as if she were about to pop an aneurysm.

Moving her thumb, she smoothed out the wrinkles gathering there. “Looks like you’ll need to see those photos after all.” Adora looked at her again, her eyes were worried, “do you have any way to get access to them?”

“. . . No. . . now we just need to get into contact with my old base.”

“Oh. . . yeah. Forgot about that. . .”

“That will take. . . a while. If at all. . .” Her brows wrinkled again, “in the meantime, lets get some rest before we go back to planning. We can re-group with Cara, Connlan, Bow, and Glimmer after dinner. Head out in the morning if at all possible.”

She laid back, letting her shoulders relax. She hadn’t noticed just how tight her muscles had been after Adora mentioned Shadow Weaver. Adora’s presence – and She-Ra’s oddly enough – had kept her relatively calm, but her muscles had still stiffened at the mention of the bitch. Now that she finally allowed herself to relax though, her body began to shiver uncontrollably, “Adora,” her teeth chattered as she tried to get her voice to work, “c-could-d you m-move on to-p of me?” She tried to keep her eyes locked on Adora’s, but it was proving difficult as her muscles continued to spasm. “I need the pressure to help calm me down.”

Adora didn’t answer right away, instead Catra felt her body move on top of hers, Adora tucking her arms along her sides, trapping her own and her legs entwining with hers. “I’ve got you, Catra. You’ll be alright.”

She continued whispering sweet nothings in her ears as her body caught up with her brain, and eventually she stopped twitching. “It’s been a while since my bodies done that. Forgot how much it sucked. At least I had help this time.”

She felt Adora’s eyes on her face at her comment. She avoided her eyes, it was embarrassing, having a panic attack. “Catra,” Adora’s fingers came up to tip her chin down, “a panic attack is nothing to be embarrassed about. I have them too. You’re stressed. It happens.”

She let out the breath she had unknowingly been holding. Looking down at Adora, she gave her a weak smile. “Just. . . stay there. You’re warm.”

“Of course.” Adjusting herself so she was settled more comfortably on top of her, Adora smiled up at her, her chin cushioned on her breasts, “You want to talk or sleep?”

“Sleep.”

Adora’s hands snaked under her back, splaying out along her spine, her eyes falling low. She watched Catra through her eyelashes, “ok. We can nap until supper.”

Letting her fingers weave into Adora's hair her own eyes falling closed, lightly scratching along Adora's scalp. Adora's fingers flexed along her spine one last time before her breathing evened out. Letting her mind wander, she thought about what She-Ra had said to her, her words echoing clearly in her mind:

-

"She called to me. . ."

Called to her, how? What was the exact nature of the Warrior Princesses magic, and how did it coincide with her need to attach to a host? By this point, she had deduced that She-Ra was intangible. A non-corporeal being, so that explained the host, but not how Adora had called to her. . .

-

"They placed a harness on her powers. . ."

That scared her, how could they place such a hold on Adora's powers. It didn't make any sense.

-

"He cannot control magic. . ."

'He' placed a harness on a powerful magical being without the help of magic. How could this 'science' overpower such magic?

-

"And so, he avoids it at all costs. . ."

That was odd, if he could beat magic with his science, why would he run from it. . . could it be that magic weakened him? It was definitely something to keep in mind as they tried to remove the harness.

-

"The scripture is purely scientific in nature, and even I cannot remove its affects. . ."

If She-Ra's weakness was this science, it would make sense that *his* weakness would, in turn, be magic. She hoped. . .

-

"To counter science, you will need science. . ."

So, they just needed to find someone on Etheria with knowledge of, well, science. It was vague, but it was better than nothing. It was something to go on, at least.

-

"Just remember, you can call on me as well, Catra. All you need to remember is to say, 'For the honour of Grayskull' and I will come. . ."

This confused her the most about their interaction, how could she – an orphaned child soldier of the Horde army – be able to summon an ancient magical being that was somehow hosted in her partner? It was. . . a lot, and they would have to talk about it. Like they had to talk about a lot of other things, just not now. Not when the woman who single handily ruined her life was only minutes away. Not when they were planning a raid on that same woman. Not now. But at some point. At some point they would *have* to talk. Catra had a lot of problems, and a lot of trauma. It was enough to scare anyone away, even herself.

Putting that thought aside, she focused on her breathing and the warm body weighing down on her, willing herself to sleep.

***

Her conscious returned to her slowly. She was just so comfortable, her head cushioned perfectly, her body at just the right angle, her body was the perfect temperature – not too hot, not too cold – she was just so comfortable. Opening her eyes, she didn't move, just looked around a little, to her right, she saw the suns beginning to set, to her left, her room, piles of clothing littering the floor. In front of her though was the best sight she had ever laid eyes on; Catra was sleeping peacefully, mouth open slightly allowing her fangs to peak out, glinting in the light. Her pillow that cushioned her head and neck perfectly were Catra's breasts, and her body – which lay at the perfect angle – was cradled by Catra's hips and legs. Smiling to herself she cuddled further into Catra's chest, turning her head to listen to her breathing, heartbeat, and a slight purr rumbling deep in her chest. The movement revealed Catra's fingers still tangled in her hair, nails pricking her skull dangerously sending a chill through her.

She let out a shuddering breath before her eyes fell closed, Catra's heartbeat strong in her ear, "hmm, like a little bit of danger, Princess?"

She let out a little squeak before looking into Catra's tired, half-lidded eyes. Her words dripped with sarcasm and teasing, but they were laced with sleep as well. "I didn't wake you, did I?"

"No. Not really, anyway. I was in and out of sleep." Her nails started back up on her scalp and she let her eyes fall shut. Her breathing hitched and caught as Catra massaged her scalp, ensuring to get every inch. "You mentioned supper. . . when is this usually? I don't see any food here."

She let Catra's words roll through her, delighting in her husky voice, "hmm. . ."

"Adora?"

"Mhm?"

"Supper? Its getting on a bit."

"Mhm, villagers eat together. . . Freja and Frieshia like to – hmm – cook." She was surprised she got that out, Catra's fingers were working her scalp perfectly and she was having trouble focusing on anything *but* the sensation of her fingers.

That is, until her fingers stilled. . . *"Adora?"*

"mmmh. . .hmn," she sounded pathetic, but she really didn't *care* at this point. Pushing her head into Catra's palm she hoped she got the message. When Catra's fingers didn't budge she forced an eye open, trying to focus on the beautiful turquoise and gold in front of her. "Hmm?"

"Adora? Adora!"

“Hm? Wha-?” blinking she brought her eyes back into focus, Catra’s words registering, finally.

“Hey, come back to me, Princess.” Her voice wavered, holding back a laugh.

“Sorry. . . what?”

“Its late and I’m a bit hungry. Where’s your food?” *Ah, right. Food.* Her mind was coming back online. . . slowly.

“Oh, um, the village just eats together. I don’t really know how to cook. Y’know, rations.”

“Understandable. You wanna go eat?” her tone was cautious, almost as if she were afraid to ask for food. Afraid to request they go somewhere. *Afraid*. It was a bitter taste in her mouth and broke her heart.

“Yeah. I could do with some food.”

“And strategizing.”

“And strategizing.”

***

Adora smiled at her, it was soft – if she were an optimist, she would describe it as loving, but she wasn't – her hands flexed on her spine, "I can't feel my hands anymore. . ." there was a note of humour in her tone as she pulled her hand free from beneath Catra. Chuckling, Adora rested her forearm on her stomach, flexing her fingers trying to regain feeling.

Catra didn't move, enjoying watching the sleep drain from Adora. She was fascinated how Adora, a fellow soldier, could wake in such a manner. Slowly, as if she hadn't a care in the world. It was a nice thought, wishing, *hoping,* that one day she could wake up with the same reckless abandon as the woman laying before her. Catra, on the other hand, never truly slept deeply, always mildly aware of her surroundings. Never *truly* relaxed. She let her fingers start moving again, this time slower and not as thorough. Adora *clearly* enjoyed her massage earlier – maybe a little too much – but she needed her alert. They had shit to do; food to eat, tactical missions to plan, witches to take out.

Adora leaned her head into her palm, her eyes falling closed again, "hmmm." She could feel Adora stretching her muscles along her stomach and pelvis.

"Adora. . ." she didn't respond at all, "come on, dearest. Come on back to me."

“I’m here, Catra. Just a little distracted.” Her words were slow, but she sounded alert. Her head pushed harder into her palm.

“You want to get dressed?”

“Not really.”

“Oh, Princess,” laughing, she pulled on Adora’s hair – not too hard, but enough to get her point across – and her eyes fell open. A little unfocused, but she was there. “Are you sure?”

“Mnh. . .”

“You want me to help?” Adora’s eyes widened, suddenly focused on her own.

“Yes.” Her voice was deadly serious but her weight on Catra’s torso didn’t budge. Instead, she brought her knees forward and snaked her hand back along Catra’s spine.

“Adora?”

“Just let me. . .” Adora’s hands kept moving until one stilled on her lower back, the other on her neck and shoulders, then they

were lifting her. Lifting until she was perched in Adora's lap, straddling her, "there."

"What are yo-"

"Hush," her brain screamed *no*, but niggling at the back of her mind was curiosity. *What exactly was Adora up to?*

She kept quiet, her body alert, tail lashing behind her impatiently. Then Adora kissed her, soft and caring, and her brain quieted. Sighing into the kiss she relaxed, her purr kicking up again lightly. "Hmm, ok. What are you up to, Princess?"

"Keeping you close."

Her eyebrows shot up almost in disbelief, no one, *no one* had ever wanted to keep her close. She was bad luck. "Oh."

Adora kissed her again, just a peck, but somehow it still had the same affect as her tongue sweeping into her mouth. Then she stepped off the bed holding Catra to her. "So, earlier. . . you were in my clothes."

Her breath caught – not necessarily in fear, but she was pensive, she knew Adora wouldn't care. She *knew* that, but her mind still spiraled into the 'what ifs?' What if she got mad? What if she didn't think Catra was *worthy* enough to wear her clothing? What

if, what if, what if. . . "mhm," her voice was small and she hated it. She hated the vulnerability. She was frozen though. Too frozen to move, her hands falling lax against Adora's scalp.

"It was incredibly *hot*. I had trouble controlling myself."

"Oh."

"Catra, don't doubt me. I care for you." A hand slipped to grip her ass, the other coming up to cup her cheek caressing her cheekbone. "I *want* you to feel comfortable with me. Comfortable sharing with me."

"I don't mean to. I know that. . . in my brain. But my body. . ."

"Its instinct. Running is what you do to survive."

"Yeah."

"I get it." Adora smoothed her bangs back from her forehead, "am I making you uncomfortable. Do you want some space?"

"Yes, I mean no. But yes too." She disentangled one of her hands – not as easy as she thought, especially as she tried not to hurt Adora in the process – running it over her face, covering her eyes.

“I need-can I stand on my own.” Adora put her down instantly, “I just-I-I need to feel the ground.”

“Yeah, of course.”

“I’m sorry. . .” this is *not* what she wanted. She didn’t want to break down in front of Adora, not again. Yet, the tears came unfounded and without her permission. And still they came.

“Oh, Catra. No need to be sorry.” Arms engulfed her Lightly, not too tight, but just enough pressure to be present. “You are *allowed* to feel. If you’re overwhelmed, ask me to stop. If I scare you, ask me to stop. If you get surprised, tell me. If you need time, tell me. Yes?”

She stayed quiet, processing. It was going to be a bumpy ride for them. She just hoped Adora was ready for the ride. “Yeah. I know. It’ll just take time. I need time.”

“Ok.”

Sniffing she wrapped her arms around Adora squeezing tightly. They stood like that for a long time, “ok. I’m ready.” She waited for Adora to respond and when her chin lifted off her head, she took the opportunity to drown in the blue depths of Adora’s eyes. “Let’s see about getting you dressed, then.”

Turning in Adora's arms she looked through the pile of clothes scattered on the floor. She could easily tell whose was whose. Her scent permeated the long sleeve she had borrowed. An idea popped into her head, scooping up the shirt she'd worn and Adora's pants she headed back to where she'd left her. Adora's eyes were half-lidded and she could tell she'd been watching her – she may even know what she was up to – but her mind was already made up. Dropping down to her knees, she looked up at Adora, "lift your foot for me?" an easy smile pulled at the edges of her mouth when Adora's foot lifted from the floor. She felt in control – her being 'below' Adora not really a factor – a small part of her delighted in that, the other, though, the part she so desperately *wanted* to listen to was pleased simply because Adora was listening to her. Watching her. Focusing solely on her.

She was ashamed of the part of her that wanted to dominate. The part that was delighted in her successful domination of Adora. Adora was bigger than her, stronger than her, and, by all accounts, had been the stable one in their short relationship. Her domination of Adora was a great success to the small, *evil*, part of her.

The part of her Shadow Weaver had created and fostered. The part of her that the evil bitch had tried to bring out of her. The part she had brought out of Nisha when they were young.

She wasn't going to focus on that though, she had. . . *better* things to think about at the moment. Tapping Adora's other foot, she pulled the pant leg over her foot and up her legs. Then came her shirt. Then boots.

Gathering her own clothing, she turned to pull them on quickly. "Catra. . can I help you too?"

"Um. . . sure." Her heart skipped a beat, but when Adora kneeled to help her with the pants, it squeezed painfully, "wait. I-I can't. . ."

"Ok. Do you want to talk about why?"

"Not right now. . . later?"

"Got it." She rose, no protest or doubt in her eyes, just plain curiosity. . . and, dare she say, *love*.

Pulling the pants, her foot coverings, and her ankle braces as quickly as possible, then straightening out before whispering, "I don't deserve you or your understanding."

Adora's fingers lifted her chin, forcing her eyes up, drowning her in the care and understanding she saw in the blue depths, "You deserve it all, Catra. I won't have you doubting that. You deserve to be loved." At her nod, Adora held up her shirt, "can I at least help you with this?"

". . . yes." Adora's fingers brushed lightly over her skin as she pulled the shirt over Catra's head and arms. Goose bumps exploded over her skin trailing behind Adora's touch. Her stomach

tightened when Adora flattened her hand, tucking in the front of the shirt, but when that same hand moved to her back it brushed the base of her tail. The movement spiked a sharp pleasure, all of her blood instantly rushing to the spot. Her head light she barely heard the groan that escaped her throat, "Ador-ah. . ." Her eyes widened, *that was new. . .* "uhm."

"Oh?"

"That's. . . new."

"Something to keep in mind. . . for future *endeavours*."

Her breath caught. But before the moment could extend past that, Adora moved away from her, her hand brushing tantalizingly down her tail before falling at her side, searching for. . . something?

"What's up?"

"Your forearm braces, I'm just trying to find them."

"Ah. Here." Pointing to where her pile of clothing had been, she saw her armoured braces peeking out.

Adora leaned over to pick up the braces – when her back turned, she allowed herself to pick up the edge of Adora's top, sniffing the edge to breathe in her scent; *heaven* - her fingers tracing them, "these are quite worn."

When Adora turned back to her she dropped the edge of the shirt. "Yeah. I've had them for years. Made them after escaping. Stole some armour and leather from a neighbouring town." Shooting her hand out she cut off her rambling. She wasn't really sure why she was nervous all of a sudden. When Adora handed her the garments, she busied herself putting them on. When she looked up, Adora's hand was in front of her.

"Ready?"

She placed her hand in Adora's, squeezing her palm. "Yeah."

"They are very well made, Catra."

"Oh-uh. . . thanks"

Adora handed her her mask, "I used to make my own clothing too. That is, until Lyla told me they were done horribly wrong. Next day she handed me the clothing we have on now. Been wearing them ever since."

She couldn't help but laugh. Still smiling they left to get supper.

~~~ Supper, Village Center ~~~

She had never seen Catra shy. True, she hadn't known her long, but by the way Catra was acting, she was sure Catra was *not* normally a shy person. They had been sitting around the table for a couple hours, food gone long ago, just talking the time away. Relaxing after a hard week. The conversation had died down when the playful shrieks of children were heard from behind her and Catra, they had discovered a new person – Bow and Glimmer had already been ambushed by the children – one that had slipped in late and gone unnoticed. . . until now.

"W-what are they doing." Catra's eyes were glued to the array of children approaching, "Adora?"

"They just want to meet you, Catra."

"Why?"

"They're curious about you?"

"Why?"

She laughed at the line of questioning the twins often nailed her with, "just say hi and find out."

***

She eyed the children looking at her with hopeful eyes, two were quite young, the other older – more subdued, but equally as curious – "uh-hi?"

The younger two started talking at once, "Who are you?" "Did you come with the *Queen*?!" "Why do you have a tail?" "Your ears are so fluffy!"

"Ode, Anne, one at a time." Adora was holding back a laugh. Her lack of reaction calmed her a little, this must be normal then.

The girl walked up to her, excitement evident on her face. Her wild curls, Catra decided, matched her personality perfectly, the light strands reflecting the waning sunlight in every which way. "I'm Anne. I think you know my Daddy, Hathor. What's your name?"

"Catra."

"So pretty!" The excitement in her tone threw Catra off guard, was this what normal children found fascinating?

"Uh. . . t-thanks."

“I’m 7 years old! My other Daddy said when I turn 8, I can have my own bow! I just share with Odilon now.” She began to pout, as if she were truly offended by having to share.

“Odilon?”

“Oh! He’s my baby brother!” she gestured to the boy beside her with remarkably similar hair pulled into a ponytail. Their smiles were identical.

“I’m not a baby! Your *barely* older.” His intense green eyes fell on her, “I’m 7 too!”

“Oh. Ok. . .”

“Why do you have such a long tail?”

“I-uh. . . don’t really know”

“Why not?”

“Cause I don’t?”

“Why not?”

Adora was laughing now, her attempts to stay quiet failing. “I-haha, sorry. Come on, go see If your Daddies will let you grab some dessert,” she put a hand up to cover her mouth, whispering loudly, “I saw Aunty Shia putting a cake in earlier, maybe go see if she needs a hand?”

“Ooooh! Cake!”

“Let’s go!”

The older boy stayed behind, looking at her hopefully, “I’m Thane.”

“Hey, Catra.”

“I-its nice to meet you,” he smiled shyly. “I like your ears!” He ran off as soon as he said it, off into the kitchen.

“What?”

“I think he may have a little bit if a crush on you.” Glimmers voice came from across the table, her teasing tone accompanied by a shit-eating grin. Adora was giggling to herself beside her, matching Bow beside Sparkles.

“A. . . crush?”

“He likes you.” Her tone was matter of fact.

“Oh.” *That still makes no sense?*

Adora’s hand landed on her shoulder, “don’t worry too much about it, it’ll pass. Your just new and pretty.”

A hot blush rose involuntarily colouring her cheeks, “oh.” Adora smiled at her knowingly.

“Alright everybody! Time for some cake!” A Cheery woman emerged from the kitchen holding a *very* large tray, a trail of kids followed behind her, chanting.

“Cake! Cake! Cake!”

“Cake! Cake! Cake!”

~~~ Some time later, town hall, planning meeting ~~~

Glimmer and Cara were discussing tactics, how to move in, how to neutralize Shadow Weaver, when to do it, etc. But Adora had, oddly enough, not been able to pay attention. She'd zoned out quickly watching Catra analyze her piece of cake with razor focus. Her ears pricked and moved when the conversation got interesting, or something new was mentioned, so she was listening, but her eyes were focused entirely on the fluffy white square, squishing it, ripping off small chunks to roll them between her fingers, testing the durability. She turned the cake in her hands again before taking a small bite, chewing slowly. She watched the muscles in Catra's jaw work while she tested the cake in her mouth. Her eyes flicked up to catch hers, eyes unreadable. Her mouth opened slightly, her voice barely a whisper, "what is this?"

She shouldn't have been surprised, she hadn't known what cake was either, well before coming to Etheria that is, "Its cake."

Catra looked. . . confused by the word, and she understood. The language on Etheria had been fairly easy to learn, her only setback had been food, connotations, and slang. "Cake?" her child-like curiosity was endearing – simply trying to learn about new things in the world.

Now that she thought about it. . . she really didn't know what cake *was*, or what's in it. . . "A sweet pastry. Fluffier."

Catra's brows furrowed, but her eyes stayed curious as she took another tentative bite, bigger this time; big enough to *actually* taste it. "Its-uh. . . really good." She almost sounded embarrassed. . . something they would work on; expressing themselves, learning likes and dislikes, just exploring really.

The child-like novelty – alongside the embarrassment – in Catra's voice brought a smile to her lips, a light laugh bubbling up. "It is," she pushed her own piece towards Catra, "you want to try some icing? Its much sweeter. Yours didn't have any."

"Sure." Her finger reached out hesitantly swiping a bit of icing before licking it off. Her pupils blew out a bit and her eyes locked on Adora's cake.

Struggling not to chuckle at the longing in Catra's eyes she pushed her piece closer to her, watching as her pupils dilated more, "take the rest? I'm not really hungry anymore." Catra's eyes flicked to hers, her eyes were narrowed and searching her for the lie, but they were hopeful too.

She kept her expression completely innocent. When Catra picked up the cake and took a bite she let herself smile at her giddy demeanour. Catra had a small, pure smile pulling at the edges of her lips, her eyes were happy. She looked as if she were stopping herself just short of doing a happy little dance – her shoulders were swaying slightly and her tail was flicking happily. She could watch this happiness all day. This is what she wanted for Catra. This was the best sight she had seen in a long time.

". . . -ra?" she blinked at Cara's voice in her ear, "Addy? You with us?" turning back to the huddle of people she chuckled guiltily when she saw that all eyes were on her.

"Sorry, what?" Cara was smiling at her, not so much knowingly as shit-eating at her being caught day dreaming. Ruffling her hair, she tuned back into the conversation.

"You're coming with us, right?" Glimmer spoke up, ghost of a smirk pulling at the corners of her mouth.

Fighting down the blush that threatened to rise she cleared her throat. "Yeah, where do you want me."

"With Catra, if possible. Reconnaissance. I'm told that your specialty." Her eyes darted between the two of them, somehow not able to keep her eyes away from Catra discovering sweet food.

"Yes, it is. Got it." She nodded, then brought her attention over to Catra, there was definitely curiosity in her eyes, but with the way she was brought up, in a royal family, she assumed that The Queens rigid manners forced her to keep her curiosity reigned in. Especially in a professional setting.

“That is, if you’ll come with us, Catra?” The question was probing, almost as if prompting Catra to come out of her shell and join the planning. She hadn’t really spoken to anyone since her short description of Shadow Weaver. It had been concise and directly to the point, explaining her weakness and strengths without needless elaboration. An explanation that had been perfected. Like Adora, she memorized her enemies’ abilities and how to counteract them.

Catra’s head shot up, her jaw stopping, eyes wide with surprise. “Uh-y-yeah. Sure, yeah.” Her attention returned to the cake, though more cautious now, listening carefully. Not to be surprised again.

“Right, so reconnaissance. Anything in particular we need to look for?” taking everyone’s attention off of Catra, she got back on topic. If they were going to do reconnaissance, they needed a plan.

“We need a more exact body count and if you can determine if Shadow Weaver is still here. Maybe even a layout if you can?”

Glimmer was looking at her hopefully, as if she was expecting her to say no, “yeah, no problem. Should only take about an hour to do. Maximum two.”

Surprise was evident on her face which only confused Adora more, was there more to the mission than she thought? What exactly had she missed? “That fast?”

“I mean, yeah? I am highly trained and the encampment is not far. It shouldn’t take very long if activity is normal. Did I miss something?”

“Damn, ok.” Bow chimed in, impressed by. . . *something* she had said. She just wasn’t sure what exactly that was.

“Is-is that not normal.”

“Well. . . not really. We usually need an entire day, and a team of 5 to 7 specially trained rebels just to get a semi-accurate head count. Layout would need to be a completely separate mission entirely with rebels trained in *that*. No one could do it all”

Catra snorted, “being a child soldier does that to you.” It was blunt, but ultimately it was the honest truth. She had been training since her brain could comprehend language.

“Well,” Glimmers voice sounded strained and a little horrified, “in Brightmoon, you can’t even join the academy until 18, so. . .” she trailed off, looking around the group.

“Oh how. . . strange.” She just couldn’t imagine a soldier with so little training being considered ‘specially trained.’ It seems the Rebellion was in *desperate* need of training – well, *better* training at least – alongside the assistance they requested of her.

Cara made a disproving sound, “mhm. You’re just superhuman lady!”

“Cara! More like your mother every day! Where did all this sass come from?” Wrapping her arm around Cara she gave her a noogie.

“Haha, stop!”

“Yeah, yeah, squirt.” Letting her go, she turned back to Glimmer, “so, when are we thinking? Sooner is better, at least in my experience.”

The Queen glanced around the group, when everyone continued to look to her for a decision she huffed a bit, rolling her eyes. “How about tomorrow?”

She nodded, Catra still seemed *very* into her cake, moving on to her own piece. “We’ll leave early, then. Before anyone wakes. That’s the easiest time to get concrete numbers – as they emerge for the day – and try and determine their rank. Depending on when they wake and how confident they are, we can determine whether they are in charge or a foot soldier. Its also a good time to locate a particular person, in our case, Shadow Weaver.” Looking around the group to make sure no one protested she continued, “does anyone have a pad and pencil I can use? To sketch out the layout of the encampment?”

“I do!” Cara jumped up, “if were done, we can get it now?” She looked to Glimmer for permission.

“I’ve got nothing more, Bow?” Used to the attention by now, Glimmer didn’t hesitate to take charge again.

“Nope.”

“Connlan?”

“No, Your Majesty.”

“Catra?”

“Huh? Oh, no.”

“Alright, then I. . . guess we’re done. We can meet again tomorrow afternoon to go over the results of yours and Catra’s reconnaissance.” Her eyes swept the group again, and again no one spoke up, “Ok. . . uh, dismissed?”

“Cool! C’mon, Addy!” Cara pulled her after her, into her room. “Its here somewhere,” she began tearing through her room which was

a weird balance between young girl and grown woman. Tactical formations and terms accompanied by stuffed toys dressed in frilly tutus. “Here.”

A pad of paper was thrust into her vision, grabbing it she brought her attention back to Cara, “thanks.” She was young, her face too round, immature, too young to be ensnared in this war. Too young to be planning tactical missions. Her teaching the girl always made her heart hurt, but she was determined to keep them safe, doing that consequently took some of their innocence. An innocence she had never possessed.

“Good luck on your mission.” There was that child-like innocence again. She looked so much younger now than she had in that meeting. She looked, now, like she always should. Guilt stabbed at her – she had a part in the loss of this child’s innocence.

“Thank you,” ruffling her hair again she smiled down at the girl, the lump in her throat made it hard to breathe, “get a good sleep, now. Ill see you late tomorrow with the information.”

“Ok! Goodnight!”

Heading back into the kitchen her eyes fell on Catra who was now focused on a map of their surrounding area. She was so focused and Adora couldn’t help but smile at the familiar crease in her brow. Walking over she smoothed the crease, keeping her finger there to tap lightly on Catra’s forehead, “your gonna get wrinkles if you stay so serious, Love.”

Catra looked up at her, eyes full of mischief. “Let’s go. I have something that I want to try.”

Chapter End Notes

I may or may not get the next chapter out by the 15th. . . I'm thinking I might release a short explicit chapter on the 15th to the other fic 'Warrior Woman - After Hours' and a full chapter update here on the 1st of August :)

Reconnaissance

Chapter Summary

Draaamaaaa aaand a beautiful ending :)

Chapter Notes

I still haven't decided if I like the longer or shorter chapters better....

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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Catra stood before her, hands on her hips, tsking. "As much as I enjoy wearing your clothes, they aren't very practical for reconnaissance. Got anything subtler?" She picked at the white shirt, holding it out to clarify her point, "we would get noticed *very* quickly in these."

"I do." Adora walked over to the far wall next to the dresser, running her hand along the paint. "Ah. There." A panel about 6 by 3 feet wide moved into the wall, back about a foot before swinging open to reveal an assortment of recon gear. "This is everything I had on my ship from my last mission."

She took inventory, roving her eyes over the multitude of weapons and lightly armoured clothing, all designed to fade into the background seamlessly. She whistled, "impressive, Princess. Your space force was really something, wasn't it?"

"It was." She turned away, shutting down in the same manner Catra herself had done many times. It helped her to realize just how understanding Adora had been in the past few weeks – letting Catra in, talking about her past, to an extent, and getting nothing in return – making a mental note to be more open, she followed after Adora, into the sea of tactical gear.

Fingering through the lightly armoured shirts she stopped on a sleek – adjustable – bodysuit. It was dark, but in earthy tones rather than pure black. A subtle difference, but important – people noticed the black figures lurking in the background, but not the dark purple and blue hues not dissimilar to the ever-active wildlife and plant life of the Whispering Woods. Directly underneath the bodysuit was the matching boots, but, while they were sleek and would definitely fit, the idea of putting them on set off a

momentary panic in her mind – from the outside, relatively unperceivable panic aside from her slight step back and change in her breathing, but inside her mind was screaming. . . the last time she put on shoes. . . was not a time she remembered willingly.

"Catra? Are you alright?" Adora's voice came from beside her, but all she saw was a flash of blond hair, her eyes weren't working well, the black flooding in as rapidly as her breathing. She tried to force her voice to cooperate, to ease Adora's fears, but all she got were a few sounds and wheezes. "Catra. Breathe. You know how to work through a panic attack. Don't mind me, pretend I'm not here if it helps."

Adora was right, she supposed. She wasn't new to panic attacks. The vulnerability though, that was new. A panic attack was one thing, a panic attack in front of another person was another thing. *Its just Adora. Its just Adora. Its just Adora.*

Its just Adora.

Its. Just. Adora.

Her mental screaming didn't seem to be doing working though, reaching her hand back she waited until Adora's fingers laced through her own. That did the trick, the panic in her mind quieted until there was only the fear of the memory, *nightmare* of her past. "The last time I wore shoes," her voice was barely a whisper, but she knew Adora was listening, her hand squeezed encouraging her to continue. "It wasn't really my choice. I've always hated shoes, the constriction. They hurt my feet." She

paused to breathe, it was hard to talk about her past, but it wasn't as painful as she thought – the warmth of Adora's hand seemed to drain the panic from her naturally – so she continued, "the day before I ran, I went on a mission. They assembled my team and gave us a last-minute reconnaissance mission just outside of the Rebellions watch, a small civilian village. We weren't told that though. They told us the town was full of insurgents and Rebels. Since it was reconnaissance, we were given special gear. It included shoes. Shoes that I *knew* wouldn't fit me. They never had before. I tried to sneak out without them but I got caught." Adora's hand squeezed hers again and she knew what she meant, 'you don't have to tell me.' But she did. "The Force Captain in charge of the mission took me out in front of everyone and told me to put the shoes on. . . When I refused, they forced them on." Stepping backward she leaned on Adora's chest, taking comfort in her warmth, "they broke 3 of my toes. I had to reset them myself after the mission."

"Catra. . ."

"Its fine, Adora. It was a long time ago. I thought I was over it, but I guess not. . ."

"Love." Adora moved in front of her, waiting until she opened her eyes before continuing, "its *not* fine. What happened to you was indescribably evil. Its not something you 'get over.'" Her fingers ghosted along her jaw, "its just something you learn to live with."

"Yeah. . . I guess so." She let the memory slip back into the depths of her mind, hopefully, to never be thought of again. "So, this bodysuit. Is it spoken for?" She held up the dark suit she had been gripping tightly through this whole ordeal.

“Go for it, Love.” Adora stepped back and began pulling various clothing items off the rack, stripping, pulling them on, adjusting everything, then looking back at her soft smile adorning her lips.

“Efficient.”

“Haha. Of course!”

Pulling the bodysuit on she took her time adjusting and acquainting herself with the various sheaths and pockets. *Very ergo dynamic*, all the pockets were lined perfectly with the thought of the wearer in mind. If strapped and adjusted properly, this bodysuit could work for anyone. To her right she noticed a bin of gloves of various sizes. Flitting through she managed to find a pair that fit her, well, like a glove. She heard something ripping behind her, and when she turned, she saw Adora wielding a knife, cutting through a piece of material in her hand, “what. . . are you doing?” Adora opened her palm revealing a. . . sock, with the toes cut out. “What the hell?”

“I’m making you some foot coverings. So you don’t need to wear shoes.” She must have noticed the baffled expression on her face because a hot blush exploded over her cheeks and she scrambled to explain herself. “The terrain isn’t that great for bare feet and it would make me feel *so* much better if you had something on your feet. Please?”

“You. . . cut some coverings for me?”

“Well, yeah? You can’t wear shoes and shouldn’t have to go bare footed in the woods. . .”

“Oh.”

“Do you not want your feet covered? You don’t have to-”

“No. I do. I just. . . was surprised.” She smiled, “thank you, Adora.”

“My pleasure.” Grabbing the socks from Adora she pulled them on. They were extremely good quality, better than her regular pair. Reaching her hands up she pulled her hair into a knot, securing it under her hood.

Pulling the gloves back on she looked up to see Adora’s eyes *sparkling*. “What’s up with you?”

“Nothing. . .” she glared, prompting Adora to tell her, “its just, those gloves-“ *snort*, “-haha, they’re from when I was fourteen.”

Adora burst out laughing, tsking she punched her shoulder, “well, its not *my* fault you have *ginormous* hands.” Adora’s laughter was infectious, she noticed, when she began a little chuckle herself.

“Mhm.” When Adora pulled her own hood up her throat went a little dry. Even with a smile softening her features she was intimidating in her full-recon gear. Catra found her *irresistible*.

She distracted herself with the assortment of knives in front of her, picking and choosing various blades to slide into the numerous folds and pouches littering the bodysuit. “Do you have any close combat shields? For forearms?” She was actively avoiding looking at Adora for fear she would ogle the woman as she adjusted her pants to fit tight along her skin.

“Uh, yeah. I think so.” She heard rummaging, then clanging, eventually turning around to find Adora fingering the bowstring of a very intricate – but also lowkey – bow. “Are you a good archer? I never picked it up well. Only about 85% accurate.”

“’bout 98% accuracy through Horde training standards. What type of arrows you got?”

“Some kind of very lightweight, flexible metal that was picked up by scouts.”

“Let me see.” Adora handed her an *extremely* light arrow, “wow! You weren’t kidding.”

“Nope, a lot of my weapons are made from this material. Its very versatile and strong for how lightweight it is.”

“Well, it looks like a simple Hunting Broadhead.” Settling her feet shoulder width apart she took the bow from Adora, nocked the arrow and pulled the bowstring taunt, getting a feel for how the bow and arrow worked as a whole. It was a very well-made bow. Better, at least, then the bows provided in the Horde. “Sure, ill take it. It’ll give us some long-distance capabilities.”

Sliding the arrow back into a quiver that looked to be made from leather and matched perfectly with the colouring of the bodysuit. Everything in this room seemed to seamlessly work with everything else in the room. It was impressive. Clipping the quiver onto a metal loop that appeared in the correct position on her hip, the other aligned perfectly on her shoulder – scarily accurate – and swinging the bow over her head to rest on her shoulder she let out a huff. Scanning the room once more she found nothing missing. “Here.” Adora held out some forearm braces that were slightly darker than the fabric of her suit.

“Thank you.” Putting them in she tightened them until they were flush against her forearms, rotating her wrists to test the comfort level, “perfect. Well, I’m good to go. How about you Princess?”

“Yes. I am just going to grab some paper and we can head out.”

Whistling appreciatively when Adora turned around she caught the falter in her step, a chuckle blooming in her chest, “you sure

are ready, Princess.” She walked over, pinching her ass, “remind me to take a picture of this masterpiece later.”

“Catra!”

“What? I’m only telling the truth!” she placed a kiss on the back of Adora’s neck before sauntering back into the main room.

~~~ Leaving the Village ~~~

They were walking out of the entrance to the Village when Adora opened up a small handwritten map. “According to Cara’s map, the Horde Encampment is only about a 10 minute walk North from the Village.”

“Hmm. The suns just coming over the trees now, the soldiers will be up pretty soon.” Looking through her eyelashes she watched Adora orientating the map, measuring out the distances, preparing for the mission. Stuff she always found *incredibly* boring; they could do with a little disorganization. A little danger was nothing new to her, “race you?”

“Huh?”

She gave Adora *just* enough time to look up before she took off North. They had time to find the encampment without the help of a map. Her muscles were buzzing with energy, she had done

practically nothing since they came to the village. Still jogging she looked back to see Adora balk at her for a second before taking off at a dead run – terrifyingly fast for a human – so she turned back to the front and kicked up her speed to a comfortable sprint, letting her muscles stretch out. This is what she loved about being a defector – no affiliation – she loved the freedom. What she didn't expect though was the sheer excitement and adrenaline that flooded her system when Adora pulled up beside her.

Giggling she kicked up another gear her feet beating against the soft earth of the Whispering Woods, dodging trees seamlessly as she went. All too fast though she saw the telltale shaft of toxic smoke that was a sure indicator of the Horde billowing from ahead. Slowing down to a light jog she waited for Adora to catch up, "that smog there. That's where the Encampment will be."

"Ok. Time to move quietly then."

Nodding she switched to a well practiced, not so much jog, but speed walk. The only whispering heard was from the woods surrounding them. When they came up onto the outer edge of the encampment it was obvious no one had emerged as of yet. The site was eerily silent, no light emanating from the portable huts. Adora tapped her shoulder and gestured for her to take a mask she was holding out, putting her own on. Grabbing the mask she tried to figure out how to put it on, but there were no straps. When Adora imitated holding it up to her face, she did just that, and the mask latched onto her face on its own. *Oh.*

"I thought these would be better to use than trying to communicate through sign language."

Hissing lightly as her tail frizzed she glared at Adora, "*a* little *warning next time you decide to get into my head?"*

Adora's laughter surrounded her, "*the mask uses bone conduction so you and I can hear our conversations, and everything going on outside, but nothing can be heard outside the mask."*

"Ah, got it." Looking up into the trees she started calculating distances. *Perfect.* Turning back to Adora she tapped her shoulder, "*got any rope on you?"*

"Uhhh," she rummaged around in her pack a moment before producing a bundle of rope, "*here. What are you doing?"*

"*I'm going to map the camp while we wait for them to wake up."* Pulling out an arrow she tied one end of the rope just above the fletching. Grabbing the bow she nocked the arrow, aiming for a tree in the distance – not so far that the rope wasn't long enough, but far enough that she could get a good view of the camp from above. Pulling back as far as possible, she needed a lot of power behind this shot to get a good line, she let the arrow loose. The thud from the arrow was solid, but, thankfully, nothing was disturbed by the sound and it blended seamlessly with the whisperings of the surrounding woods. "*Ok. I can work with that."* She turned to Adora who looked absolutely lost, "*the pen and paper, please, Princess?"* The materials hit her palm and she put them and the bow back on her shoulder getting to work climbing the twisted pine tree next to her, making sure nothing got caught in the branches surrounding her, and keeping hold of the rope – not a small feat now that she was acting out her plan.

Finally, her feet landed on a solid branch that was high enough to keep the rope level. Tying the free end of the rope so that it was taunt she looked down to Adora who still looked a little lost. Chuckling she gave her a little salute as she stepped onto her makeshift tightrope. When she was roughly at the center she crouched low, taking in all the buildings and weapons surrounding her from below.

She began sketching out the rough shapes, trying to be as accurate as possible in her proportions. She was just about finished when Adora's voice filled her head, "*wait, I hear something."* The distinct sound of a door could be heard in the distance, opening, then closing. Holding her breath she waited to see how many emerged. There were only about 6 huts. Likely 1 for Shadow Weaver, 2 with two Force Captains in each, and 3 with about 10-15 soldiers in each.

"Shit. There's fifteen out now. A lot more soon. Gotta get along with it then."

"*We need to get you down, Catra."*

"Not yet, just a few more buildings. . ."

"Catra!" Adora's voice hissed in her ear, but there was no point in arguing, she was done now.

"Done, done. Now for the hard part." Looking below her she watched as another building full of soldiers emerged, bringing the grand total to 30 walking not 10 metres below her. Standing carefully she let her body sway slightly with the rope. She started walking along slowly – she knew she wouldn't make a sound, but that's not what she was worried about at the moment. She was in full view of 30 Horde soldiers. All they had to do was be alert enough to notice an odd shadow moving above them and alert the camp to her presence.

She was in luck though. What felt like forever – likely only a few minutes – later she stepped off the rope back onto the branch of the pine. She climbed down quickly nodding to Adora she handed back the pen and paper with a rough outline of the Encampments buildings. *"Thanks."*

"*There's about 30 out now. If I estimate correctly there's probably about 50 soldiers here. 45 foot soldiers, 4 Force Captains, and Shadow Weaver."*

"Well, shit."

"Probably best to stick around to get a solid count though." As she said that the last hut opened up and 15 more soldiers emerged.

It only took about 10 minutes before everyone was out and about, the Force Captains had emerged, there were 6. Now, all that was left was Shadow Weaver. Every muscle in Catra's body was tense and on high alert, so when Adora put a hand on her shoulder it took everything in her not to jump out of her skin, which would be

bad. She hissed lightly in response, hoping Adora would take the hint. *"Catra?"*

Apparently not. "*What?"*

"Are you alright? You're really tense."

"*Its. . . nothing"* Adora said nothing, but her eyes – the only thing Catra could see through her mask – conveyed a lot, all a mixture of disbelief. *"Hmm. . . Its just. . . Shadow Weaver. And Nisha, I guess."* Her eyes followed the mane of Auburn hair as it moved through the camp away from them. The soldiers gave her a wide berth – smart thinking on their part – and those that didn't were unceremoniously pushed to the ground out of her way.

Adora's hand stayed on her shoulder but her words were cut off when the door of the last hut flew open and the camp fell silent when a dark shadow billowed out from the opened door. Next appeared the same red robes that haunted her. She hadn't changed a bit in the fourteen years since she had run.

And in fourteen years, her fear of the woman never faded.

Even though Adora had never seen the bitch before, she went stiff as well at the womans' presence. It wasn't a far cry to assume that the woman surrounded by shadows and pure evil was Shadow Weaver. *"Shit."*

"*Yep, that abouts sums it up."* Moving her attention to Adora she soaked in the soft blue of her eyes, "*we should get going. Queen Sparkles and Cara need to know what's up."* Her voice was tight, but there was nothing she could do about it now. She had a sinking feeling the lump in her throat would remain until she was *far* away from the godforsaken camp.

"We have everything we need, for now." Standing she watched Adora turn and begin her walk away. Turning back she caught a glimpse of those auburn locks and Shadow Weaver placing a hand on her shoulder. Her heart burned. As much as she hated them both, her heart burned – whether in hatred or with jealousy she wasn't entirely sure – and it hurt. Turning away she tried to wipe the sight from her mind, but it seemed that image wanted to stay with her. Stay alongside the hundreds of others that plagued her.

And so, she ran. Ran away from everything. As far as she could go. In reality she only went a couple kilometres before her legs gave out. Resigning herself to the fall she let her body fall limp. But she didn't hit the ground. Instead she hit something warm, and soft. Something that smelled like lavender and earth.

Adora.

***

She heard a door slam open and shadows billowed out of the opening. The camp fell silent and she instinctually held her breath,

anticipating the person who could elicit such a reaction from an entire camp of soldiers. Ominous flowing red robes emerged with a tall lithe woman. She just looked *cold*. A mist of shadows engulfed her, unchanged by the ever-present winds of the Whispering Woods. Catra didn't move at all, this must be Shadow Weaver, "*shit,*" she could feel the strength of her magic from where they sat.

"*Yep, that abouts sums it up.*" Catra looked at her, finally, her eyes searching, then they were gone. Latched back onto the woman as she walked away from them, deeper into the camp, "*we should get going. Queen Sparkles and Cara need to know what's up,*" her voice was tight.

"*We have everything we need, for now.*" Standing she let Catra have a moment to breathe walking away slowly. A moment later Catra ran past her, her breathing erratic over the microphone. Following after her, she made sure to keep a distance. Feelings were complicated and Catra wasn't used to having another person to lean on. She needed space. As much as it hurt her to hear the sobs of the woman she was in love with, she needed to let her hurt. Alone.

Until she began to fall that is. As much as she needed to be alone, there was no universe where she would let Catra be hurt. Not so long as she was conscious and nearby. Pushing herself she lunged to catch her. Sliding along her knees she caught the falling, limp form, "*oh, Catra. . .*"

She wanted so badly to take the mask off of her, let her work through it, but they were too close still. They could be heard if

they made too much noise. *"I-I can't. I don't know why. I-I don't know* why*!"*

"Why, what?" She kept her voice calm. Maybe she could make it a little easier on Catra. Even only if momentarily.

Catra's eyes locked onto hers. There were no tears, but she was still dry sobbing. "*I don't know why it* hurts *me to see her. Adora. . . it* hurts."

"*I know, Love. You need to let it hurt, baby."* Gathering Catra in her arms she made sure they were hidden well – no one could hear them with these masks, but they could still be seen, and they were extremely vulnerable at the moment. *"You're going to be fine, Love. Can you breathe for me? Breathe with me: In, 2, 3, 4, 5, and out, 2, 3, 4, 5. In, 2, 3, 4, 5 and out, 2, 3, 4, 5."* Catra's eyes never left hers, but their breathing synced and her muscles loosened, "*that's it, Love. You're doing great. Just breathe with me."* Slowly, she seemed to be calming down. Her breathing, at least, was under control. *"How about we get back to the Village. We can relax later?"*

Catra just nodded. Standing them both up she waited for Catra to regain her balance before beginning their walk back to Ardglass. They didn't say anything more, but Catra kept her fingers entwined with Adora's and her head rested lightly on her arm. She wasn't ok, and she wouldn't be fore some time. But she was getting better. Slowly, but surely.

~~~ Ardglass, Townhall ~~~

“There’s roughly 52 Horde soldiers, 45 lower level, 6 Force Captains, and Shadow Weaver.” Her voice rang out into the large room, echoing.

Glimmer’s expression took a downturn at the mention of Shadow Weaver. “Shit. You saw her?”

“Yes. And she looked pretty moved in. I don’t think she’s going anywhere anytime soon.”

Glimmer tsked chewing on her fingers. “That makes things *a lot* harder. Ugh!” Throwing her hands up the Queen grunted, “why couldn’t she have *left*?”

Catra’s ears perked and flicked, as if she were listening, but her eyes held a faraway look, as if her mind were elsewhere. Leaning back from the conversation she whispered to Catra, “hey. What’s going on in your mind, Love?”

“Hmm. I need to say something, I just don’t know how to say it.”

“I find its best just to say it. The people here are very understanding. If its important, they’ll want to know, even if the delivery isn’t stellar.” Catra didn’t answer right away and she could swear she saw the gears working in her mind.

“Ok.” She leaned forward, waiting for Glimmer to finish her planning, “can-could I say something quickly?”

“Uh, yeah. Go ahead.”

“Freja and Mina. They shouldn’t be anywhere near the fight. Shadow Weaver, she-uh, she fights dirty. She goes after the loved ones of those she deems ‘strong’ or ‘worthy’ of being her opponent.” Catra shifted uncomfortably avoiding the stares of everyone around the table. “Freja, she overpowered Shadow Weaver during the original fight so she’ll be after the only thing sure to break a person. Her family.”

“But. . . she doesn’t know anything about Freja. Other than she possesses strong magic, that is. Right?”

“That’s not entirely true. If I heard correctly, Freja jumped in to protect Mina from harm. The only reason someone fights with that kind of fervor is if that person getting hurt *means something* to them.”

“How-how do you know that for sure.”

Catra’s face lost all expression, “I lived it.” There was no emotion left in her voice, and that one sentence ended the entire conversation. Everyone fell silent, not really sure what to say.

“Ok. . . Ill talk to Aunty. I’m sure shell be relieved that Aunt Mee won’t be fighting.” Cara piped up carefully waiting for objections, “. . . ok. Ill get going then.”

After Cara ran off the silence returned. No one had anything to say, “well, its getting late in the day. Perhaps we should leave the bulk of the planning until tomorrow?” That was a lie, she just wanted to relax. Reconnaissance missions were what she excelled at, but they were also extremely draining.

“Honestly, sounds great to me. I want to get a little more acquainted with this layout and think on some action plans before presenting anything concrete. See you all tomorrow?”

There was a round of goodbyes and then they were off. Catra was silent again, but her fingers entwined with hers and that was enough.

“Hey, girls! Got a second?” Eyes following the cheery voice they landed on Layla rushing over, a bundle of something in her hands.

She smiled, “hey, Layla. Of course, what’s up?”

She thrust the bundle towards them. “I made these for Catra! She looked like she needed some clothes.”

Catra’s ears perked at that, “oh?”

Rushing over, Layla flashed them a bright smile, "I noticed you wearing Adora's shirts, so I assumed yours got ruined. I didn't get a real good look at you before you turned in for the night, but I think these should be pretty close! The colours are similar at least." Layla handed Catra the bundle, unfolding the top item, a bodice, "I got a quick glimpse of the bodice you were wearing, and I think I got it." She held up a nearly identical bodice to what was laying on her floor covered in blood. "And, the pants, I just altered some leggings to your size, there are some designs already in the fabric, I hope you don't mind."

"O-of course not. Thank you so much. . ." Catra's sounded absolutely *flabbergasted* at the kindness.

"Great. I also have a couple pairs of modified socks to match what you've got on now. I reinforced them so that your feet have a little more protection, and also another cloak in case yours got ripped. There are 3 bodices and 2 pairs of leggings in there as well." Layla smiled refoldeding the clothing.

"T-thank you, again. I-uh don't know what to say." Catra's eyes were wide as saucers, once again reminding Adora of a child learning the complexities of the world.

"Oh, thank you is plenty, Catra. I should be thanking *you*. My children and mate are safe thanks to your help. Thank you."

“Oh, of course. You’re welcome.” Catra bowed her head in embarrassment. A nervous giggle escaping her at the praise.

“Anyways, I’ve got to get going. I’ve left my boys alone too long as it is, haha! See you kids later!”

“Bye, Layla. Have a good night!” She chimed in for Catra who seemed to be at a loss for words.

“You too!”

She hurried away, making haste back to her home – she wasn’t kidding about leaving Elke and the kids alone for too long, though, she had seen the damage they could do – turning back to Catra she squeezed her hand, resuming their walk back. Stopping in front of her hut she waited for Catra to move. She didn’t. They just stood staring at the door. Catra looked deep in thought, her eyebrows worried, mouth in a thin line her jaw working restlessly. “Do you want to go for a walk? I have a lot of energy I need to expend before I’ll be able to get comfortable.”

Catra looked up at her, eyes blank, “hmm, sure.” Her voice was just as blank, and that worried her a little. Tossing the bundle of clothes onto the small porch she steered them in the direction of the back gate, letting them out, then bolting it back up. Walking forward she continued until she found a familiar, slightly worn path.

“This is where I come to decompress. Sometimes the bustling of the village can get to be a bit much and I just come out here. Its comforting.” She let the silence fall over them again, keeping her paces slow, strolling. She watched the Whispering Woods. They always fascinated her, from the strange wildlife to the ever-moving plants. It was never *truly* quiet here, and yet this is where she found peace on Etheria.

Catra’s head had returned to her arm as soon as they were out of the village and they just walked, for a long time. She had done this for Catra’s sake, but she was now realizing just how much *she* had needed this as well. In the past few weeks with Catra, she hadn’t really had time to think. She hadn’t had time to realize just how far she had fallen for the woman who leaned against her. Their contours moulding together seamlessly.

And she was in deep.

~~~ *Some time later* ~~~

“Seeing them together hurt.” It was the first time Catra had spoken to her since they left the village. “She put her hand on Nisha’s shoulder. Like she was saying ‘good morning.’”

Her voice broke, but she wasn’t crying, she just seemed. . . *broken*. It was heartbreaking.
~~~

“She never. . . not once did she do anything like *that* with me!” She lashed out with her free hand. Nails slashing a nearby tree. “Not *once* did she have a kind word for me. *Anyone* for that matter. Until Nisha. . .” Her hand fell limp again, hanging at her side. Defeated. “She was all I had, Adora. My first friend. She was everything. I don’t remember my family at all. Shadow Weaver said they are all dead. Gone. I had no one else. Only *her*. But she took her away from me! She turned Nisha against me.” Catra stopped, her breathing got heavy, almost growling. “She took my family from me, but that wasn’t enough. I couldn’t remember the hurt of losing them. I forgot. So she had to break me again. She let me find someone else. Someone to replace the hole she left in me, and then she took them away. *Again*.” She was seething now, “this time though, she made sure I wouldn’t forget. She didn’t kill my family this time, she turned them against me. She used Nisha to hurt me again and again and again.”

Catra looked terrifying, her face contorted in rage, her nails fully extended – ready for anything – but Adora wasn’t worried. As mad as she was, her hand that rested in Adora’s was still soft. Catra’s thumb rubbing her palm in soothing circles. She was mad, but she wasn’t out of control; she was hurting.

Catra was hurting and there was *nothing* she could do about it.

So she listened. She listened to Catra pouring her whole heart out, taking the pain. Hoping that, in some way, the pain she was feeling somehow eased Catra’s pain. She knew it wasn’t, and yet, still, she hoped.

She was so busy with Catra that she didn’t notice the form lurking in the shadows; angry yellow eyes and auburn hair whipping

wildly as they fled.

~~~ An hour or so later, heading back to Ardglass ~~~

"Can I ask you something?" Catra had calmed significantly, and they had been talking about nothing in particular for a while. They had gotten closer, Catra tucked into her side, arm around her waist holding her close.

"Go for it, Love," she had her arm wrapped around Catra's shoulders twisting a strand of hair through her fingers.

"She-Ra. I-I just want to be sure, but, can she really come out on her own? Like, without you knowing?"

"I don't think so, no. Why?"

"I just. Last night was a little weird. Her 'coming out' and all. . . I just wanted to be sure."

"Oh. Ok." She looked down at Catra, but her expression was unreadable. "Are you uncomfortable around She-Ra?" Catra looked at her funny, "I just mean, do you want me to keep away from you if I'm She-Ra? If it makes you uncomfortable, I will." It hurt, but it was something she would do.

Catra punched her shoulder. *Hard*. “No! You dummy! I was just curious about She-Ra. Her magic is actually kinda soothing. Now that I’ve ‘met her’ I feel like I can feel her in you.” Catra took a breath, “Its comforting, having her there, I mean.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah, ‘oh.’” Catra flicked her forehead, a soft smile playing at the edges of her lips, “and you think *I’m* bad at reading signals. *Sheesh*.”

“Sorry,” she rubbed her forehead.

“Its fine, baby.” She sighed heavily, “and to think, I fell in love with a big, caring, undyingly loyal, oaf.”

She said it teasingly, but she had said it. . . again. *She loves me!* The smile that broke out on her face was one she couldn’t have held down, even if she tried. She slowed her pace until they stopped. Catra made a questioning sound, but Adora kissed her lightly before she could speak.

“I love you too, Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

Im moving once again - this time a LOT father :/ BUT ill be a LOT closer to my family :))

See you all on Aug 31st with the next chapter upload! As always, if you want to see more of me, subscribe to my user to be notified when I upload or follow me on my social media (@Samm_arts on pretty much everything, or some form of it, eg. Instagram, Twitter, Tumblr)!!

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